

THE
PRIDE O'THE
MORNING

AGNES GIBERNE

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE PRIDE O'
THE MORNING ***

Transcriber's note: Unusual and inconsistent spelling is as printed.



**SHE SHRANK LOWER AND LOWER, TILL HER BOWED HEAD RESTED
ON HER KNEES.**

The

Pride o' the Morning

BY

AGNES GIBERNE

AUTHOR OF "SUN, MOON AND STARS," "THE MIGHTY DEEP,"
"STORIES OF THE ABBEY PRECINCTS,"
"ROY: A TALE IN THE DAYS OF SIR JOHN MOORE," ETC.

"And so the shadows fall apart,
And so the west winds play:
And all the windows of my heart
I open to the day."

WHITTIER.

London

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OLD BAILEY

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THE PRIDE O' THE MORNING

CHAPTER I

COLIN'S RETURN

A BEAM of sunshine from the far west came in at the oriel window of Castle Hill library. As its name might imply, Castle Hill stood somewhat high, at least for English Midlands. The house, an old one, often added to in the course of centuries, was two hundred feet above the village of Castlemere.

It had, therefore, benefits of breeze and light; and this lengthy irregular room, with its four windows, its carved black oak, its hangings of dull green and old gold, enjoyed the latest kisses of the monarch of day. The hour for those kisses was not yet come. Wavelets of ether, shimmering billions to each beat of the venerable clock, speeding across ninety-three millions of miles, still landed on wall and carpet.

Mrs. Keith's mind was occupied with other matters than scientific causes for everyday phenomena, as she paced the room with impatient steps, glancing in turn through each front window, in quest of the expected dog-cart.

She was a handsome woman, tall, with dark eyes of unusual size. The rich brown hair, which held many silver threads, was well-dressed, and she carried herself with a touch of conscious stateliness, which failed to hide

her present restless mood. A fixed red spot on either cheek made the rest of her pale face paler; her lips worked; and she continuously clenched and unclenched her right hand.

Giles Randolph had risen when she rose, and he now stood in the oriel window, reading; a man of large build, six feet in height and robust in make. The face had strong outlines, with a straight solid nose, a good mouth under the heavy brown moustache, sombre blue eyes dragged downward at their outer corners, and a complexion of deep red-brown. In the features was something not easy to decipher. There was fibre of character, and a will to crush difficulty; yet that dim inscription seemed to speak of something in the past that had mastered him, and had given a bias to his life.

"Half-past six! He ought to be here. I can't think why he is not," Mrs. Keith was saying. "The train was due half-an-hour ago."

She took another turn.

"He must have missed it. How vexatious! When does the next come in? I do wish you would look it out for me."

Giles put down his book and walked to a side-table, where some fumbling ended in the remark—"I don't see Bradshaw."

"It's there, I know—on the top shelf of that bookcase."

He took down the volume, remarking in his deep voice, which contrasted with her somewhat querulous tones—"This train is often late."

"O don't be sensible, pray! I'm not in the mood for it."

Possibly her companion was at a loss how to be the reverse. He turned over the pages, and remarked, "In case Colin should have missed—"

"Yes, yes; I understand all that. The time of the train is what I want." Then came an apology. "I really don't mean to be cross, Giles. Somehow, I can't help it."

He looked at her kindly. "Of course—I understand. One knows what this must be to you—your own boy coming home!"

"Yes. That is—he may be different."

"No fear. Colin will be Colin still. Ah! Here is the page."

She had moved again and now stood behind him. A breeze of feeling swept over her face; something of protestation, for which nothing present seemed to account. Tears filled her eyes and were with difficulty blinked away; but she spoke in a tone of forced gaiety.

"You have no business to talk like that. To speak as if Colin were more to me than yourself. You know that you both are my boys—always have been and always will be."

He spoke soothingly. "At all events, if there has been any difference it has lain the other way—more indulgence for me, more strictness for him."

"O surely not!" That which he meant to comfort her proved exciting. "Don't say it, Giles! So hard as I have tried to make no difference—even in my love!"

"You have made none, beyond what was inevitable. Colin has the right to your greater love, and he is infinitely more lovable. Venetian glass can't be handled like granite. Come, you are not going to worry yourself! Things are all right."

"I hope so. I shouldn't like to think—" She left the sentence unfinished, and began anew—"I often wonder—'can' one hold oneself even? I know what you mean by 'greater strictness' and 'Venetian glass.' Just because he is my own, I have tried to be more severe with him, and his sweetness has made it impossible. He is so lovable, as you say."

"Of course your own boy is and must be more to you than all the world beside."

"Yes—true," she murmured.

"I should be the last ever to wish Colin to come second." Giles spoke pointedly; for Mrs. Keith's endeavours to give her ward his full rights had often resulted in giving her son less than his rights. "But here is the dog-cart."

Mrs. Keith's attempts at self-analysing were brushed aside. Colin was through the front door before they could leave the library, moving with an absence of hurry, yet forestalling them. He kissed his mother, shook hands with Giles, patted the old hound who followed him with sniffs and whines, exchanged some chaff with the stout butler which set that excellent retainer grinning with delight, and finally took possession of an armchair, asking and answering questions in a soft deliberate undertone, which was the precise antithesis of his mother's variable voice.

He and Giles were made after different models. A stranger might easily have set down the latter as a man of four-and-thirty, while few guessed Colin to have passed his twenty-third year. Yet less than six weeks had divided the birth of the one from the birth of the other; and each now had passed his twenty-eighth birthday.

Colin was the shorter, though he gained in apparent height from his slightness. His fair pale complexion and chiselled delicacy of feature contrasted with the powerful outlines of Giles, while the finely-developed forehead spoke of intellect. The blue eyes were singular, not unlike those of Giles in colour, observant, yet dreamy.

He had suffered severely in health from an accident in boyhood. A heavy blow on the head had resulted in disabling headaches, which for years prevented study. His high spirit had made him less of an invalid than might have been the case; still, education had been a negligible quantity, so far as any regular "curriculum" was concerned. He had read much by fits and starts, picking up any amount of general information, but steady work had been impossible. Foreign travel at last had been recommended, and much was expected from the three years of absence, now ended.

Glad to be back! Yes, certainly. Though he had enjoyed himself no end—thanks to Giles!—with a glance at the latter.

Then, presently—"Giles, I've been thinking—it is cool of me to talk of this as 'home.' As if I had a shadow of right!"

"You have every right."

"Not a particle. Now I am stronger, I don't mean to be dependent."

"Nonsense!" came emphatically.

And Mrs. Keith stood up.

"Going to dress for dinner," she murmured; and Colin showed surprise, since the hour was early. He did not protest, but when she had disappeared, his glance went to Giles.

"Nervous!" came in reply.

"What about?"

"I haven't a notion."

Colin dropped the subject, and reverted to what he had been saying. "That's all very well, you know; but I happen to have a trifle of self-respect. Call it pride, if you like."

"Between you and me pride is impossible."

"The future Mrs. Randolph—"

"Will feel as I feel, or she won't exist. What is mine is yours. And not a man in the Empire is less likely to marry."

"Bosh! Anyhow, I mean to work."

"You shall do what you can, without suffering for it. But for pleasure, not necessity."

"It's a moral necessity that I should be independent."

"And deprive me of the one thing—" A word of protest cut into the utterance. "Yes, I know! I promised not to say it again. No need; for you understand. I wish you also to understand that never while I live will Castle Hill cease to be your home."

"So be it! Meanwhile, I intend to work."

"At what?"

"Modelling, of course. Will the mater be exercised?" His words dropped slowly.

"I don't see why she should."

"She hates to see me fingering clay. I never can conceive why. It is the one thing I can do."

"Better for you, at any rate, than head-work."

"My dear fellow! Do you suppose sculpture is not head-work?"

"Better than books, I should have said. We must fit up a studio."

Colin murmured a "Thanks." He added, "I've done a lot of modelling lately—in Paris first, of course."

"Ah, that was what kept you so long."

"I went through a regular course. This winter I've had a fine time in Italy, studying the great masters. Plaster casts want a lot of practice. I've not made much way with them yet."

"Don't try for the present. Modelling in clay will give scope for your powers, and a practised moulder will do the casting better. For a wonder, I know just the man in Market Oakley—a young fellow with talent. I shall like to encourage him."

"I dare say! But the cost—"

"Will be my concern, till you can stand alone. When you are receiving hundreds for a bust, you shall pay for your own casting."

"Ah—when!! But I mean to stand alone."

"What are a few pounds between you and me?"

"Well, perhaps for a time!" reluctantly. "I had no end of encouragement abroad. Some of my attempts won great praise."

"Delighted to hear it," Giles said cordially. "What do you think of the old schoolroom for your studio? It is out of the way, and has no room over. You will want skylight windows, I fancy, and a tap of water, and a modelling-stool, and instruments. There's a small inner room, which will be useful. We will have it put in order at once. You must be properly equipped at the outset."

"Giles, you 'are' a good fellow!" murmured Colin.

CHAPTER II

MIDNIGHT MOVEMENTS

"HOW do you do?" a precise voice said.

It was not needful to announce Mr. Thomas Dugdale. He was as much at home in the house as its proper inmates. If a door were open, he walked in; if not, the butler opened it, but did not venture to treat him like a caller.

The greeting was meant for Colin. He never said, "How do you do?" to the others, since they met too often.

He was elderly, composed, critical, daintily neat every inch of him, from the smooth well-cut hair and the shaven face to the immaculate shoes, which never, on the muddiest day, became soiled. Extreme exactitude, inside and out, was his main characteristic. He lived alone in a small house on the estate, built by a former owner for his mother-in-law. Mr. Dugdale might have found a home with his widowed daughter, on a neighbouring property, but he preferred "freedom."

Dinner over, Colin usurped most of the talk, till Mr. Dugdale appeared.

Mrs. Keith looked often from one to the other of "her boys," as she called them, trying to impress upon both that neither was more to her than the other. They, man-like, would have taken the fact for granted. She could not let it alone. If she said "Dear Colin," she dragged in a "Dear Giles" within two minutes. If she laid an affectionate hand on Giles' shoulder, she gave a like caress to Colin. The balancing of affection became irksome, and Mr. Dugdale's entrance made a not unwelcome diversion.

"Tired of travelling?" he suggested. "Three years—enough for the most voracious appetite. What is to be the next step?"

"Settle down at home," Giles replied for him.

"Well—for a while. Give folks time to turn round." He took off the far-sighted glasses with which he had surveyed Colin, put them away, and with dainty finger-tips adjusted his near-sighted pince-nez, pulling forth a letter.

"Something to interest you here. A response to my letter. Signs of yielding, too. It takes the old lady six weeks to evolve an answer."

Mrs. Keith saw the writing. "Mrs. Wyverne!" she exclaimed.

Colin showed interest. "How about Phyllis?" he asked. "Something was said lately about getting her to visit us."

"Mrs. Wyverne ought to consent. Giles will be in that neighbourhood, and he means to try persuasion—not asking leave beforehand."

"Going to storm the fortress?" suggested Colin, with one of his noiseless laughs. "Mind you don't capture by mistake the ogress!"

"Not likely! Barbara must be a person to whom distance lends enchantment," remarked Giles.

"We have nothing to do with Miss Pringle. It is Phyllys whom we want. Certainly not Barbara!" Mrs. Keith knitted her brows.

Mr. Dugdale began to fold up his letter in disgust. "Barbara Pringle is an excellent person of her kind," he said stiffly. "Well-meaning and conscientious. Most people are well-meaning. But the bane of womanhood is to be always in the right. Barbara Pringle is always in the right. She never makes a mistake. Therefore she is monotonous and uninteresting."

"Let us devoutly hope that Phyllys sometimes blunders," laughed Colin. He saw the vanishing letter, and added, "But you were going to read us something."

"Nothing! Nothing!" Mr. Dugdale waved the subject aside with his hand. "Merely a passing idea. Barbara Pringle has usurped its place. Inadvertently I interrupted somebody—or somebody interrupted me. In either case, I apologise."

Glances were exchanged. Mr. Dugdale crossed his legs, and contemplated an empty fireplace.

"The Infinitely Little!" he mused. "It may be masculine; but it is more commonly feminine. Woman, when she is small, is very small indeed. When last I had the pleasure of seeing Barbara Pringle, I should have described her as an excellent example of the Infinitely Little. Good, no doubt; but narrow—painfully narrow. A woman whose whole Universe might be packed into an egg-shell."

"Think what her life has been," suggested Colin. "Forty years in a Yorkshire burrow."

"Narrowness is a matter of mental make, not of circumstances."

"No doubt; but circumstances tell upon one's mental make. A plant, whatever its make, can't develop without light and air. Miss Pringle has had neither."

"If she had, she could not have made use of them."

"And the family aim is to rescue Phyllys from a like fate. Giles should be equal to the old lady, even backed by the redoubtable Barbara."

"Barbara Pringle is a woman not easily managed."

"Ten years since you saw her," said Mrs. Keith.

Mr. Dugdale put his finger-tips together, and entered on a discussion of dates. He proved, to his own satisfaction, that not ten years, but precisely nine and a half, had elapsed since the date of his visit to the Yorkshire village, where lived old Mrs. Wyverne and her pair of grand-daughters. Then he stood up, his eyes bent upon Colin.

"Sorry—no. Can't stay longer. Busy; and so are you." He was still chafing under his supposed slight. "Ta-ta, everybody. Whom on earth has Colin grown like?"

"It's generally decided that I am like nobody," remarked the object of his scrutiny. "Not the mater, in any case."

"I should have said Colin was like everybody in turn," Mrs. Keith observed.

Mr. Dugdale, with wrinkled brows, pursued his quest.

"Can't imagine," he repeated. "It is a definite resemblance." He frowned anew, standing deep in thought. "I have it! That old portrait in oils, which used to hang here—I never could understand why it was banished to the gallery! It's one of the best things in the house!"

Mrs. Keith went into peals of laughter. She held her handkerchief to her lips, overpowered with merriment. Colin laughed sympathetically in his silent fashion, while the set gravity of Giles' features deepened.

"My 'dear' Mr. Dugdale! You really are 'too' comical! The idea of likening Colin to that ancient fogey! Young, was he?—Yes, I dare say he was—two hundred years ago! But it's too rich!—too funny!" Her laughter filled the room. She was not often noisy, but for once she let herself go.

"Oh, very well. Good-night. In future I shall keep my opinions to myself!" And Mr. Dugdale walked off, affronted. He could stand anything better than ridicule.

Giles went with him to the door, and on his return Mrs. Keith's merriment had subsided.

Colin was saying—

"I have reverted lately to my old love—sculpture."

There was a movement of annoyance. "I hope you are not going to take that up again!"

"If I have the gift, why not use it?" asked Colin, in level tones.

"You have not. It is a mere fancy."

"A fancy that has survived twenty years."

"You will never succeed." Her manner showed displeasure.

"But at least he can try," put in Giles.

"It will be utter waste of time."

"That was not the opinion of an expert. He said there was no doubt about my having the gift—if I could work hard enough."

"You won't. You will never keep up anything long."

The words brought a shadow to both faces, more especially to that of Giles.

"If you wish to find work, pray take up something worth doing." She was greatly in earnest, and the red spot in either cheek began to burn.

"This is worth doing, if Colin wishes it," said Giles gravely. He counted her opposition unkind.

The subject was dropped, but Mrs. Keith's face fell into a haggard set. She went to bed early, Colin retiring also, and Giles retreated to his private den beyond the billiard-room. Since he managed his own estate, without an agent, he was sufficiently busy. Papers had to be examined, letters had to be written; and this was his time of quiet.

More than two hours had gone by, when a consciousness came over him of something or somebody moving.

The servants would be gone to bed, since it was past midnight. He went out and listened, standing in a narrow passage, which at some distance to the left joined the central hall; and the whole house seemed to be in darkness, in absolute repose. But as he waited, he heard again that suggestion of a sound—hardly a creak—and then he saw a needle of light falling athwart one corner of the hall.

He took an unlighted candle and a box of matches, and groped his way thither; but the slender ray had vanished.

Again he listened, and could detect nothing. Mrs. Keith or one of the maids might be about: but what puzzled him was that the needle of light had seemed to travel from the long corridor on the first floor, known as the "gallery," its position and slant being in no other way explainable.

Not wishing to disturb sleepers by stumbling about in the dark, he lighted his candle and went upstairs. Mrs. Keith's room was fast shut; so was Colin's. He turned to the gallery, where a double row of old pictures, portraits and landscapes, adorned one wall, the other being broken by windows.

Another glimmer ahead. The gallery ran round two sides of the house, and this ray came from beyond the corner. He went faster, but on rounding

the corner he saw nothing. If anybody had been there, the person must have gone through a door to the back staircase.

Thither also went Giles. He descended the back stairs, which ended on a part of the ground-floor divided by a swing-door from the main hall. Still no one was visible. He pushed the door open and passed through, to find himself in darkness. He could discover no presence except his own. Going once more up the front stairs, to make assurance doubly sure, he saw a light below Mrs. Keith's door, and tapped. She kept him waiting a good two minutes, then opened and faced him in surprise—her hair falling over a dressing-gown flung hurriedly on.

"Giles! Is anything wrong?"

"Some one is about, and I wanted to know if you had left your room."

"I! I was in bed, almost asleep—but I heard a step, and I lighted my candle. Then it was not 'your' step? Not thieves, I hope!" with frightened eyes.

"More likely one of the maids. Probably you heard my steps; but somebody else was on the move."

"I'll speak to the maids to-morrow. They have no business to be about so late. You are 'sure' it is not a thief—" her breath quickening.

"No need to feel anxious. I'm not going to bed yet, and I shall take a look at all the fastenings."

He said good-night, and went the round, but found no door or window unbolted.

CHAPTER III

MRS. WYVERNE'S GRAND-DAUGHTERS

"PHYLLYS BELINDA WYVERNE."

She wrote the words in large capitals with the point of a decrepit sunshade upon a patch of smooth sand by the wayside, and read them aloud.

"And that is Me," she murmured. "That always was Me. That always will be Me. Yet—when one comes to think of it—such a different Me now from what I used to be in the old, old days!"

So far as looks went, she might have been anywhere between seventeen and twenty-one.

"And such a different Me from what I might have been—if 'they' had lived!" she added.

She allowed a handful of dry sand to stream between her fingers, and Wiggles, the rough Skye-terrier, with bright eyes under a shaggy penthouse of hair, had the benefit of it. She broke into laughter at his indignant bark.

"Your temper is too easily upset, Wiggles. You should wait till you have something to bark at. There are worse things in life than a sprinkle of sand. Infinitely worse, dear Wiggles."

Above the sand-patch rose a steep bank, clothed with trees and underwood. She stood, her head thrown back, meditating an assault. She dearly loved climbing, and nobody was at hand to protest, except one who owned no right of protestation. She believed herself to be alone. Wiggles knew better; and for a second time he ran to inspect the intruder. A second time he decided that it was no case for a rousing alarm. He was a dog of discrimination.

Phyllis pursued her soliloquy in a voice which, though subdued, was full and bell-toned.

"On the whole I don't wish to be anybody else. But that is not to say that I would not rather be 'Somewhere' else! Wiggles—" and she broke into energy—"how I long—long—to get away! Right away—from everything and everybody! I feel as if I were shut up in prison for evermore—never to see, never to know, never to reach beyond this little round. I want things different—and people to understand."

She stopped to pat the dog, and he squirmed in rapturous response.

"One thing is clear," she remarked aloud. "I can't and I won't go to the meeting this evening. I'm old enough to judge for myself, though Barbara does treat me like a child. I'm not in the mood, and it never does me any good. I'll play truant till Grannie and Barbara are off—let the consequences be what they may."

The features of her unknown spectator relaxed with amusement. He was about to make a forward move, when checked by a spring on her part. She went lightly up the bank, as a sailor might have done, and swung herself into the branches of a medium-sized tree. He drew back, fearing to startle her if she should glance round in the midst of her acrobatic feat.

She settled herself on the fork of a bough, leant against the trunk, and sighed with content.

"This is something like! Imagine exchanging it for the stuffy schoolroom, and all the 'Ha's' and 'Ho's' and 'Hi's,'—worse still for Miss Robins and Mr. Timkins. Ah, Wiggles, my dear, if you knew what it was to have to do with a Timkins—and 'such' a Timkins!"

By this time her audience was smiling outright, though less easily moved to a smile than some men.

The bough on which she rested gave a creak. "I say!—I mustn't stay long. But it is delicious. Why does one grow too old to do what one likes?"

Silence was broken by the trills of a wren, pouring forth its little heart in song. A cricket chirped, and a large bumble-bee swung heavily by, and a dragonfly with iridescent wings swept to and fro in dashes after his prey.

"Wough!" objected Wiggles, feeling himself in the lurch.

"Hold your tongue, Wiggles. I'm coming soon."

Her gaze wandered over the expanse beyond the opposite wall; a wall of loose stones piled scientifically together, without aid from mortar. Grass-fields, divided by similar walls, sloped downward into a hollow, where lay the clustering stone houses of a village, well named Midfell, since all around, at distances varying from two to four miles, broad moor fells reared their summits. Their clear wide lines stood against a sky of pure blue, and the bright green of grass-land contrasted with the richer green of late July bracken, while other parts had begun faintly to blush with the glow of opening heather. All was grazing-land, varied only by uncultivated moor. No trace of corn could be seen.

It was a fair look-out; so calm that the whisper of a brooklet might be heard on its way to join the main stream which cut the village in half. Phyllys could see that stream from where she sat, and a stone bridge over it, beside which was her home. Now and again a low "moo" floated from one of the meadows, then the bark of a dog, and again a child's voice.

"Wough!" protested Wiggles anew.

He went for a third survey of the stranger, feeling himself responsible for his mistress' safety. There was a slight "Sh-sh!" and the stranger's eyes gazed into his. Wiggles knew that no harm lay behind those sombre blue orbs, and he wagged his tail.

"Good dog!" the stranger said aloud.

Phyllys overheard, and uttered an "Oh!" to herself. She had been well lectured on the fact that at twenty-three she was years too old for tree climbing, and she never now ventured on the amusement except in privacy. There was nothing for it but to wait till the other should have gone on. Owing to the nature of the ground a dignified descent was impossible. She would have to come with a drop, a run, and a leap—enjoyable enough, but not to be allowed before spectators.

"Pardon me," the intruder said, advancing to the foot of the bank, and lifting his straw hat. "I could not help hearing your name. As it happens that I am on my way to your house, perhaps I may venture to introduce myself. If we are not acquainted, we ought to be."

Phyllis paid but divided attention. She had discovered that her bough was unequal to its task, and was giving way. If only the interloper would hurry on and leave her to scramble down, all would be right. He showed no such intention.

"My name is Giles Randolph," he was remarking.

"I say!" whispered Phyllis, as her support yielded more pronouncedly. She clutched the trunk.

"I hardly think you are comfortable up there," the deep voice observed, while its owner steadied himself for instant action.

"It is most delightful," hardily asserted Phyllis. "But if you would please go on round the corner, I will come after you." She was chafing with impatience, for each moment was of importance, and he stood as if an earthquake would not dislodge him.

"I think you had better let me help you down."

"Help 'me!'"—with a laugh.

The slight jerk was fatal, and the bough snapped clean off, leaving her in peril. She strove to cling to a stem too large for her grasp, and hung over the road, which lay far enough beneath to mean, if she fell, at the least broken bones.

Three bounds carried him up the bank, and as she dropped, he caught her with outstretched arms. She was conscious at once of his rock-like strength and firmness. He set her on the bank, and holding her hand leaped down with her to the road.

"You managed splendidly," was her first remark. "But I 'could' have got down alone."

"I hope you might have been able—if I had not been here."

"Of course I could." She hesitated. "No—perhaps not, when the bough broke. But if I had not seen you, I should have been off in time."

He murmured an apology.

"Of course it was not your fault, only everybody says I am too old for climbing trees. What a pity the nicest things in life are just what one ought not to do!"

"Invariably?"

"Very often. Did you say you were Giles Randolph—my cousin? How curious! So many years since we have met!"

They stood face to face, each trying to make out the other. She noted with pleasure his powerful make, the strongly-knit frame, the sunburnt face and grave eyes. "I like him!" she said to herself.

And he liked her, though he did not say so, even to himself. Despite the second-cousinship, he had not seen Phyllis since her childhood, and he had never been to Midfell. Intercourse between the Castle Hill folks and the two grand-daughters had been discouraged by the kind but strict old grandmother, and during late years Barbara had used her influence to stiffen the family separation.

Phyllis was not what Giles had expected to find. Whether pretty or not might be a matter of opinion, but he thought her engaging. She was a trifle over middle height, lithe, and active. Her complexion was a pale brown, and the eyes were violet in hue, not large, but with thick black lashes, while the eyebrows were of a warm chestnut, matching the loosely-knotted hair. She had a trick of half closing her eyes, so that the upper and nether fringes all but met, and only a glimmer of blue crept through.

"We want you to pay us a visit at Castle Hill."

She flushed up. "Do you—really? That is what I have longed for. But Mrs. Keith—"

"Mrs. Keith is as anxious as anybody."

"Really!" in surprise. "But why? We are strangers."

Giles felt the puzzle insoluble.

"It isn't as if she and I were related," the girl added.

"No, she is only a connection even of mine. But she acted the part of a mother for years, and Colin and I are brothers."

"I should like to know Colin. Ought I to call him Mr. Keith? Everybody says Colin. How odd it was that Wiggles did not bark at you! He must have taken a fancy. I always say Wiggles is a reader of character."

Her face broke into a smile, the eyelashes curling with mischief.

Giles's smile was different. It could not be said to "break," but rather to dawn with reluctance. It was rare, but when it did appear, it transformed his face.

Phyllis was conscious of the change, though she only said, "Now shall I show you the way home?"

"You did not wish to hurry. I am sorry, but I overheard what you said."

"How could you help it? I was talking to Wiggles. Yes, I meant to stay away till it should be too late for the meeting."

"Shall we arrive later? I can see your grandmother to-morrow, if they will give me a bed at the village Inn." He had not intended to spend the night at Midfell, but decision was prompt.

"I should have to say that I had made myself late on purpose. And Grannie—" She came to a meaning pause.

"Then shall we go at once?"

"I suppose so," regretfully. She walked by his side down the narrow, rutted, stony road, where purple geraniums grew in abundance on the banks.

"Grannie and Barbara love those meetings," she remarked. "The Vicar doesn't. He calls them a sort of hodge-podge. But Barbara says I dislike them because I am irreligious."

The silence of Giles was more responsive than many people's talk, and it drew her out.

"Not that I'm really irreligious," she remarked, prodding the dust with her ancient sunshade. "It depends upon circumstances. When they sing 'O Paradise' in church on Sunday evening I feel any amount religious—almost as if it would be nice to die. But Barbara says that hymn is unsound."

"Indeed!"

"She says the Vicar is unsound too. He has such a kind face, and everybody loves him, except Barbara and Miss Robins and Mr. Timkins, and perhaps Grannie. I wonder why people with wrong views are nicer than people with right views."

"You find that they are?"

"Well, there is Mr. Timkins!" Another flash. "Miss Robins—she is Barbara's great friend and she gets up the meetings—she calls Mr. Timkins a saint. He is not my notion of a saint—not one least little scrap. He is one of my pet horrors. Grannie and Barbara and Miss Robins admire him, because they say he is so truly excellent. Do you believe in liking people only because they have right views and are truly good?"

"One might, in certain cases, admire the goodness without liking the individual."

"But wouldn't you rather be a great deal beloved than have sound views—if you could not do both, I mean? I think I would!"

Giles felt that she would never have to grieve over being unloved. Something in her stirred something in him which hitherto had lain dormant.

"And you don't think it is wrong to detest excellent people?" Then, with a laugh—"But that is hardly a fair question. I forgot what strangers you and I are!"

"I hope we shall not be strangers long."

"No. It does not feel now as if we were. I suppose that is because we are cousins. Perhaps some day you and I will be friends!"

She said the words smilingly, and he found his pulse throbbing in an unwonted fashion.

"I should very much like to be your friend."

"Would you? Ah, you don't know me yet. I'm always saying things I have to be sorry for. You would soon be disappointed in me."

Then adroitly she turned the subject, as if unwilling to commit herself further.

CHAPTER IV

THINGS PAST AND PRESENT

MRS. WYVERNE waited in the front sitting-room of Burn Cottage, looking out upon the stream, the murmur of which came pleasantly to her ears. She always took care to be ready some time before she had to start on any expedition, having reached an age when haste and flurry are undesirable.

She was stout and heavy in figure, but she held herself with dignity, and there was a Quaker-like serenity about her handsome old face. Her dress was of black silk, good as to material, plain in make, and her bonnet was a copy of the Quaker type. In earlier years she had been drawn to join for a while the Quaker community, and she still admired many of their methods.

By her side stood a small table, on which lay her spectacle case, her large-print Bible, her knitting basket, and her writing case. The centre of the room was filled by a round table, remnant of a bygone age. The walls were adorned with texts, some printed and framed in wood, some worked in silks on perforated cardboard, with fancy edgings of home manufacture. A row of devotional books, most of them printed fifty years earlier, with faded bindings, stood upon the quaint chiffonier.

Grace and charm had evidently not been the aim of those who saw to the interior of Burn Cottage.

The elder grand-daughter, Barbara Pringle, only child of Mrs. Wyverne's only daughter—between whom and the father of Phyllis a wide gap in age existed—had inherited nothing of the old lady's good looks. She was clumsily made, bony and uncouth, with lustreless hair, dressed in a flat and unbecoming style, features of an exaggerated type, and an uncomfortable expression. Her dress seemed to have been put together anyhow, with no effort after what might suit the individual; and results were in marked contrast with the dignified simplicity of the elder lady.

Barbara Pringle was a good woman, but not so good as she counted herself, which augured a lack of humility. One virtue she had—a supreme devotion to her grandmother, for whom she would have done anything. But out of this sprang an intense jealousy of anybody who should interfere with her monopoly. Since Phyllis naturally came in for a large share of

grandmotherly affection, it followed that Barbara could see no good in Phyllys.

Barbara's was not a wide mind. Therein spoke Mr. Dugdale truly. Her natural make was contracted, and her opportunities had been few. Left an orphan at three, she had spent forty years at Midfell, and the two or three people for whom she cared could not uplift her to a broader view of life. Her method of weighing the worth of others was through the test of—not the lives that they lived, but the opinions which they held. Even this she failed to apply fairly in the case of Phyllys.

She did not know herself to be unfair. Few people discover that defect in themselves, and she was great at self-deception. Seldom if ever did she admit, even in her innermost consciousness, that rank jealousy underlay her persistent condemnation of the younger, more attractive, and more lovable cousin. She honestly believed in Phyllys' unmitigated perversity.

Things were hard for her. During more than thirty years she had had her own way, as the only grand-daughter at hand; had been exclusively necessary to the old lady, who to her had been mother, father, all in one.

Then Phyllys, the only child of Mrs. Wyverne's beloved son, was also left an orphan, and she too was adopted by the large-hearted though narrow-minded old lady. At first Barbara had not realised what this would mean.

Not till the charming wilful child of thirteen arrived, not till her winsomeness had been exerted over house and village, not till she had begun to reign supreme in the little world around, did jealousy spring in Barbara's heart. She failed to recognise the weed.

Scarcely the whole of their little world; for Barbara's chosen friend, Miss Robins, held out from the first against the young princess of hearts, but she was almost the sole exception.

Mrs. Wyverne did her best to discipline her darling, but the love which she poured upon Phyllys took precedence of all other affection. The forty years of Barbara's devotion became as nought beside one smile from Phyllys, one touch of her sweet lips, one glimpse of the thick black fringes

which were so perfect a reproduction of her father's. How Mrs. Wyverne had loved that only son, mothers alone can know. He had been in some sort a sorrow to her. He had not thought with her on many points. He had disappointed her expectations. She had been wont to condemn him. But in spite of all, how she had loved him! No wonder her heart went forth to the child whose every look and gesture recalled the dead father.

It all came about naturally, but it meant trouble for the cousin.

So, being what she was, a good woman, but not in character noble or generous, Barbara took twisted views of the younger cousin's actions, constantly misjudging her. For instance—that Phyllis should not, at the present moment, have returned in time for the weekly meeting, got up by herself and Miss Robins, and good-humouredly tolerated by the Vicar, was a case of rank ill-doing.

"You told her to be back, grandmother."

"I really do not feel sure. Phyllis is aware of my wishes. I shall have to reprimand her."

Mrs. Wyverne drew out a huge old pinchbeck watch, then hunted for a letter.

"We shall be in time if we start in a few minutes." Being a trifle hard of hearing, she preferred the front row. "I had another letter from Mr. Dugdale this morning. He writes strongly on the duty of letting Phyllis become acquainted with Giles and his people."

Barbara spoke tartly. "I suppose by 'his people' you mean the Keiths. He and they are alike—people without religion. Bent upon nothing but pleasure. No doubt they go in for ceremonial observance, but as for anything deeper—If Phyllis gets among them she will be utterly spoilt."

Barbara, accustomed to have the upper hand in these questions, saw with amazement a look of indecision.

"It is out of the question," she added roughly. "There is no knowing what might come of it."

"I must do what is for the child's interests. Perhaps I have realised too keenly the other side of the question. She is twenty-three. I cannot always refuse to allow other relatives to see her. Giles Randolph has no one nearer to him than Phyllys."

"Than us, you mean?"

"Yes. But circumstances are different. If Giles should die unmarried, Phyllys would inherit the property."

"You would inherit it, grandmother."

"I should hold it in trust for Phyllys. Nothing would induce me to leave Midfell."

"Giles is a healthy man. Nothing less likely than his death."

"The healthiest are often the first taken."

Since Mr. Timkins had unctuously enlarged on this truth at the last meeting, Barbara was at a loss what to say.

"I must admit," the old lady continued, "that what Mr. Dugdale says, both in this and in his last letter, has tended to open my eyes to the fact that another side exists." She spoke with old-fashioned precision. "He is urgent about what her father would have desired."

"You are more likely to understand that than Mr. Dugdale."

Mrs. Wyverne was silent. In her heart she knew that she had not acted as her son would have wished.

"Besides, Phyllys has no notion about the property. Of course you do not mean to tell her." Barbara's frown grew more forbidding.

"There is no need to tell her at present."

"If she goes to Castle Hill, she will learn it. You ought to prevent that visit at all costs."

But Mrs. Wyverne did not bow to this decision. A long-dormant sense of family obligation had been stirred in her; yet more, a sense of how her son would have acted. While much under the control of her elder granddaughter, she could assert her will when once convinced that such assertion was right. Duty held a paramount position in her life, though her views of duty might be lop-sided; and the strongest longing of her heart was to do the best that could be for Phyllis.

"Grannie," a musical voice broke in. "Here is Giles Randolph. He has come to see us."

Nothing could have been more apposite to the subject of Mrs. Wyverne's thoughts at that moment, and she took the intrusion philosophically. Two minutes sufficed for Giles' explanation. Being in the neighbourhood, he had promised to bring a message from Mrs. Keith, and had also granted himself the pleasure of seeing his great-aunt. He had walked across the moors from the station, and had overtaken Phyllis. Mrs. Wyverne, he heard, had an engagement; but he proposed staying a night at the inn, in hopes that she would spare him an hour next morning.



"GRANNIE, HERE IS GILES RANDOLPH." [A-36]

"GRANNIE, HERE IS GILES RANDOLPH."

Giles used so few words that it was remarkable how much he conveyed. Mrs. Wyverne was not glad to see him, and she refrained from saying that she was; but her charming smile served in place of that which she would have condemned as an untruth. Barbara, declining to smile, waited in glum silence.

"I am sorry that we cannot offer to take you in here," observed Mrs. Wyverne; and the involuntary word "sorry" caused her some after-twinges. "The Cottage is small, and we have no spare room. But you will be comfortable at the inn." Then she weighed carefully her conflicting duties,

and decided to remain at home. Barbara and Phyllys would go without her to the meeting.

There was no escape for Phyllys. Her face fell; but it was evident that the old lady wished for a tête-à-tête with Giles. Barbara, curtly nodding goodbye, marched off, and Phyllys followed. She had learnt obedience in a strict school, and though inwardly rebellious she made no outward sign.

Then Giles bent his faculties to the task of winning the old lady. Now that he had seen Phyllys, he was anxious for his own sake, at least as much as for the sake of gratifying Mrs. Keith, to bring about the proposed visit. He did not know that the path to success had been made smoother by Mr. Dugdale; but he did realise that it might be a difficult path.

However, when Giles chose to be liked, he did not often fail in his aim.

CHAPTER V

THE MIDFELL ATMOSPHERE

BREAKFAST over, Mrs. Wyverne sat in her usual place, darning a tablecloth and entertaining a terribly early caller. Miss Robins faced her solemnly. She was a solemn individual, impressed with the importance of directing the duties of other people. In appearance she had not much to boast of; but, as she was wont to ask, "Who cares for looks?" Some unkind critics had been known to remark that Miss Robins "had no looks."

Despite her superiority, she had not cast off the shackles of a mundane curiosity about her neighbours; and she was bent on finding out what the old lady meant to do with Phyllys. "So very Important, for the sake of that poor empty-headed child, that she should act with wisdom," she observed to

her devotee, Barbara. "If she does not hold that man at arm's length, who can foretell the consequences?" Miss Robins was nothing if not emphatic.

From an abstract point of view, Mrs. Wyverne would have supported Miss Robins' opinion; but she never could lose sight of the fact that she was herself one of the Randolphs of Castle Hill, being only sister to Giles' grandfather. And though, as a matter of theory, she would have maintained that questions of descent like questions of "looks" were unimportant, it gave her no small pleasure to see again the head of her family, and to find him in many respects what she would have wished.

"A singularly fine-looking man," she observed. "He gives the impression of one who may be trusted."

Barbara, who, in imitation of her friend, was a systematic man-hater, spoke tartly, "No men are to be trusted—least of all men without religion."

"How do you know Giles has no religion?" asked Phyllys.

"He may make a profession. There is no reality in it."

"No. He carries the hall-mark of an essentially worldly nature." Miss Robins was so pleased with the wording of her own sentence that she made mental note of it for future use.

Phyllys opened indignant lips and shut them again. What was the use of remonstrance? Nothing ever shook Barbara or Miss Robins in their judgments upon others. Moreover, the latter was delivering herself of an exhortation.

"He may be outwardly fine-looking, but what of that? What of mere looks?" she inquired. "What signifies the body? That poor miserable husk! The handsomest men in feature, the most agreeable in manner, are often the most depraved. Dear Mrs. Wyverne, 'you' know the world well enough to understand. Mere appearance—face, manner, dress,—how unimportant these things!"

Mrs. Wyverne assented as in duty bound, though not without an inward reservation.

"We are called upon to ignore the body. 'I' have learnt to ignore it," declared Miss Robins, with an air of fervent conviction. "All that signifies is the spiritual part of one's self. The rest is dust and ashes—'mere' dust and ashes."

She swayed impressively on her chair.

"If the body isn't of consequence, I wonder why one should care whether one has hot or cold tea, or whether one's dinner is nicely cooked," questioned Phyllys, laying her finger on the other's weak point.

Miss Robins inspected her from a moral pinnacle. "That is different. To care for one's health is a duty. I am speaking of the vanity of minding about bodily appearance—whether one is good-looking or plain—seeking to be admired. What do such things matter?"

"I should have said they mattered a good deal," declared Phyllys, standing up. "I 'love' beautiful people. The world is beautiful, and God made people as well as things. I can't see why He should like 'things' to be lovely, and not care if people are hideous and disagreeable." Then she fled, not escaping the comment, "Really, Phyllys is sadly irrev—"

Ten minutes later she stood, lost in a dream, beside the stream as it flowed through a field, three hundred yards distant from the house. It swept here round a curve, its course being partly arrested by a bank of shingle; and beyond the shingle, in its *détour*, it poured in a rustling flow, bubbling soft whispers and singing to itself.

This hour after breakfast was Phyllys' most free time. At eleven o'clock, if not sooner, Barbara would remorselessly summon her to practise and read and darn. Time spent in the open air was wasted in the elder cousin's estimation. Barbara believed in a brisk constitutional, to and from a given point within a given time, for health; but she never lounged under a

tree, never dallied by a stream, in dreamy thought. That with her meant "idleness."

With Phyllis it neither meant nor was idleness. She was not idle, standing on the grass bank, motionless, her hands clasped behind her back. She wore no hat, and a breeze stirred her hair, bringing forth reddish gleams.

Her mind was at work. She loved Nature, loved the beauty of flower and fell; read meanings in the voices of running water, rustling leaves, singing birds. These things appealed to her artist-nature, and drew her on to deeper thought. When she could escape from home and its restraints, she was happy in what is called solitude, because in touch with her surroundings.

Yet, even in her happiest hours, she was conscious of a want. She craved for some one to understand what she felt, to enjoy the beauty with her. She craved to find the inner meanings of life. There was such an infinitude that she could not fathom; and clues were lacking.

This morning her thoughts were chiefly occupied with Giles.

Once before she had seen him, when a child of nine; and then for years she had been abroad, travelling with her widowed mother, in search of lost health, never to be regained. Since her mother's death she had lived at Midfell, paying an occasional visit to friends of her grandmother, but secluded from other influences. Often she had heard of Giles and Colin, though not in terms of praise. Mrs. Wyverne had rather implied than asserted condemnation; but according to Barbara, Giles and his friends were one and all to be avoided, as a dainty person shuns pitch; and to withhold Phyllis from their influence was a matter of duty.

Which opinion, naturally, made Phyllis want to know them! For years her dream of impossible delights had been—a visit to Castle Hill.

Now the unlikely had come about. She had seen Giles, had talked with him had felt that she and he might become friends. She felt it still, though vexed with herself for letting the thought so soon slip into words.

And she might be again invited to Castle Hill. "If only I could go! To know what it is to live! This is existence! And oh! to get away from Barbara and Miss Robins. Even—for a time—from Grannie!"

The tinkle of a bell aroused her. She was often thus recalled. But already! She did not realise how long she had stood there. Was the whole of this lovely day to be wasted indoors? She walked back with a lagging step.

Within doors the cloud on her face vanished. Barbara was not visible; the grandmother wore a smile; and Giles stood waiting.

"Put on your stout boots, child, and have a wrap. Your cousin wishes to take you for a walk."

The black fringes widened with delight.

"He does not know his way about, and Barbara is too busy," explained Mrs. Wyverne, apologising to herself. She felt uneasy, but, the managing grand-daughter being out of reach, her resolution had not been proof against his will. After all, the two were cousins; and since she had just granted her consent to three weeks at Castle Hill, a walk now could make little difference. The decision seemed lifted out of her hands; and despite her bewilderment, she looked with gratified eyes upon the great-nephew whom she had so long refused to see.

"Must I be back at eleven, Grannie?"

"Not to-day, for once. Giles wishes to go to the head of the dale, if you can walk so far."

"Oh, of course I can. That will be splendid. I have not been there for ages upon ages."

"My dear, you should not make use of such exaggerated expressions."

Phyllis tried to wear a penitent face as she fled. "If Barbara should come in!" was the fear. Barbara might upset all.

"Phyllys is a dear child, but too impulsive," the old lady remarked. "It is desirable that she should be trained in habits of self-restraint."

Giles refrained from saying what he thought.

Fortunately Barbara failed to appear, and the two set off at a brisk rate. Phyllys was a quick walker, and she easily kept up with the pace adopted by Giles. She was in a state of jubilant but veiled exultation. While lacing her boots, she had resolved to behave with dignity; not to allow her friendship to be regarded by him as a thing to be lightly won.

But miles of happiness lay before her, miles of fresh air, of freedom, exercise, pleasant companionship. No need to dwell on what might lie beyond. No need to anticipate Barbara's comments. When the time came for their acidity, she would have had her day of delights; and none could rob her of the memory.

Phyllys, as in duty bound, talked to interest her companion, perhaps more from inclination than from duty; and she found in him an excellent listener. She named for his information the various fells; those near at hand, then more distant outlines, as they mounted higher. She described the long cold winters and the deep snowdrifts. She chatted of the sturdy self-respecting farmers, and of the welcome she had from them and theirs.

"None of the people about are very poor," she remarked. "They work hard and live carefully and lay by. That is the way in these northern villages. People say how different it is in the south."

"When you come to Castle Hill, you will see for yourself."

"They will never let me go."

Then she did not yet know! He kept his counsel.

"The farmers and their wives really are my friends, and they are so good and true—so real. Blunt, of course, but that is their way. I know all the cottagers. No, not district-visiting. When I go to see them, it is because I love to go, not because I ought. Barbara and Miss Robins call because they

want to do the people good. But when I go, they do 'me' good—without any trying."

"That might seem the better way." He was interested, but he wanted to get her out of this sedate mood, to see again the long lashes mischievously drooped.

"Barbara says one ought to be always trying to do good to somebody. Don't you hate being done good to as a duty?"

"I'm not sure that I have had experience in that line."

"How nice! But I've had any amount. There's Mr. Timkins. He's not a Yorkshireman; he is from the south, and he mends old shoes. He thinks he can mend people too!" with a gleam of fun. "Miss Robins says she has 'the very highest opinion of him.' But I dislike his prosy preachings."

Phyllys stopped to pluck a flower, and surveyed it with eyes of loving admiration.

"I suppose Mr. Timkins really is 'good,'" she remarked, with the air of one unravelling a perplexity. "But so are other people who don't think as he does. I never can understand why all good people must have exactly the same opinions about every single thing. Can you?"

"Good gracious, no!"

"I've never been allowed to go to Castle Hill, because all of you don't see things just the same as Grannie and Barbara. I'm hardly ever allowed to know strangers who come to Midfell in the summer, for fear they should do me harm. And I'm not a child now. It is time I should begin to think for myself."

"You have not always lived here?"

"About ten years. Since I was thirteen. Of course I was old enough then to understand, and not to forget afterwards. When people talk as they do, and say all sorts of hard things about those who think differently from

themselves, I always know that my father and mother would have felt with those people, and not with people here. Don't you see, it rubs me the wrong way awfully sometimes."

CHAPTER VI

A BURNISHED STREAM

"IS this what you call the Dale-head?" asked Giles.

"Perhaps more properly higher up. But I think we mean the whole of the valley, as far as you can see, and beginning here. Isn't it pretty?"

It was more than pretty. She used a word inadequate.

They were seated by the river, on its grass bank. Not the little Midfell stream, but a more important watercourse; a river to which the Midfell stream was a tributary.

It flowed between steep banks; and the colour of the water was that of a burnished red-brown chestnut. Hundreds of stones, large enough to act as small breakwaters, lay scattered on the river-bed; and around each separate stone curled a perpetual wave, foam-white, with a gleam of golden light shining as from a fairy-lamp at its centre. This was repeated times without number.

Behind them and in front were rounded fells, like a series of land-waves struck into immobility, forming the sides of the valley; and every fell differed from its neighbour. Here was one shaded in purple and brown; there another bright grassy-green; yet another dark from base to summit with masses of bracken; a fourth clad in patches of dull red, purple rather than crimson, from early heather-bloom; and a round-topped hill which had

donned a veil of blue gauze. To the left, higher up, might be seen a solitary farmhouse; a rough pathway, deluged with stones, winding thither.

"They would give us milk at the farm," remarked Phyllys. But, with a smile, he produced sandwiches and a cup.

"I don't know any place like this," murmured Phyllys, after their simple luncheon. She was in a state of measureless content.

Giles said little, and she hardly looked at him; yet she knew that he felt with her. That was the one thing she had lacked and longed for; and it made all the difference.

"Nor I." He had been thinking how like her hair was to the burnished chestnut of the water. "One hardly expects such a spot in England. Few of us know our own country."

Phyllys lay back, resting her head on folded arms, and looking at the sky. It gave Giles a fuller view than he had yet gained of her eyes. He forgot fell and river in the contemplation.

"I wonder," she murmured, "whether other worlds are half as lovely as this. I wonder whether they have stuffy meetings in Jupiter and Mars—and horrid good people making speeches about the badness of other good people?"

"Jupiter is probably too warm."

She went into a chime of laughter.

"I forgot! I ought to have known." She sat up suddenly. "Tell me about your home."

"You would find it flat." He refrained still from letting her know how soon she would see for herself. "No fells. No mountain-torrents."

"And the house?"

"Respectably old. There was a castle—once. Only a wall of it remains."

"And Mrs. Keith and 'Colin' live there with you. He is not really your cousin, I suppose?"

Giles explained the connection. Thomas Randolph, his grandfather, had one son and one daughter, James and Annie. The son, James, married; and his wife died soon after the birth of their only child—"myself," interjected Giles—the widower dying a little later, thus leaving an infant possessor of the Castle Hill property. The daughter, Annie, married Geoffry Keith, and she too died early; after which her husband married again, his second wife being a Miss Cecil Reeves. They had one little boy, named Colin.

"So at best he can only be called my step-cousin. But when my mother was taken, Mrs. Keith had entire charge of me; and on the death of my father that arrangement became permanent. Colin and I have been brothers from babyhood."

"I understand now. It always puzzled me. And was he not ill for a long time? Somebody said he had an accident when he was a boy, and didn't get over it for years."

"Yes." A stern set came to Giles' face, darkening it as a landscape is darkened by a cloud passing over the sun.

Phyllis was perplexed.

"Barbara is as much your cousin as I am," she remarked, saying the first thing that came into her head. "I suppose you would have asked her first to visit Castle Hill!"—"Heaven forbid!" was on Giles' lips—"But she never goes anywhere, so I come next."

"I think you come first," he said drily, and she laughed.

"If only I had the least hope of going!"

"I don't think it will be long before we meet again." His manner said that he intended it should not be. "Till then, I hope you will remember that you offered me your friendship."

Her colour went up. "But that was silly. We were strangers. I spoke without thinking."

"It would disappoint me if you took your words back."

"It was too soon. I am always saying things in a hurry, and then wishing I had not." She twisted a grass-blade round her fingers. "Does one ever quite get over doing that?"

He ignored the question. "Don't you think we know one another well enough now?"

"Of course I've rather wanted a friend—sometimes," she admitted. "The only one I had went away. There are Mr. and Mrs. Hazel, but Barbara tries to keep me from them. And they are much older. But people ought to wait till they are sure."

"You do not feel sure yet?"

The steady purposefulness of his gaze held her spellbound. It was not that he saw deeply, but that he stirred deep feeling in her. For a moment he had a curious sense that he might do what he willed with Phyllis.

It did not last. She dropped her eyes, and the spell was broken. He did not really as yet will anything further. Their mutual knowledge each of the other was small; and he only felt that he wished to know her better. Besides, he was a man of punctilious honour, and she had been confided to his care.

So they reverted to surface topics, and no more was said about friendship. The word to Giles meant little. If he wanted anything, he wanted more; but it served as a stepping-stone to intimacy. To Phyllis it meant, for the moment, a good deal—more than would have been guessed from her next careless remark—"I was afraid this morning it was going to be a wet day. That would have been provoking."

"There was an early shower, I believe."

"Just the Pride o' the Morning."

He looked an inquiry.

"It's a saying about here. When a little early shower comes, not meaning a wet day, they say, 'Oh, it's just the Pride o' the Morning.' Mr. Hazel sometimes calls 'me' that!"—smiling.

The name sounded far from inappropriate, yet he was conscious of revolt, as he inquired, "Who is Mr. Hazel?"

"Our Vicar. Such a kind man. But I know why he calls me so. It was one day—"

"Yes."

"I don't very often give in, but things were worrying. And I had a silly little cry in the meadow. He came upon me, and he said it was just an early shower—'just the pride o' the morning.' He told me one must not expect to have everything always smooth, but he hoped mine was going to be a happy life. And since then when we meet, he often says, 'Well, little Pride of the Morning, how goes the world with you now?'"

"I should like to know your Vicar."

"Would you? Barbara doesn't like him. And Grannie—sometimes—says he's too fond of ceremonies."

"I am sure I should like him."

Not till well on in the afternoon did they once more stand at the garden gate of Burn Cottage, within which sat the handsome old lady, with a look of trouble on her face. She had been during the interim sedulously lectured by her elder grand-daughter for lapse of principle; and her own conscience was not happy.

After all these years keeping the undesirable nephew out of reach, and tabooing his acquaintance for Phyllys, it was a degree startling that she should have succumbed at the first touch. To Barbara, over whom Giles had exercised no attraction—perhaps could not if he would!—the change of front was inexplicable. She had no imagination, and she could not picture those memories of Phyllys' father, first stirred by Mr. Dugdale, then called into life by Giles. In her eyes the consent was simply an act of weakness and folly. She neither knew nor cared what her grandmother's motives might be. She disliked the idea of Phyllys going to Castle Hill, and she never dreamt of searching into her own sub-surface workings, to find the hidden jealousy.

Having been long used to submit to the joint dictum of Barbara and Miss Robins, Mrs. Wyverne could not meet their condemnation with indifference. She took herself seriously to task for allowing the walk and consenting to the visit.

Still, consent was consent. When, after Giles' departure, a fresh attack was made upon her by the combined forces of the two women, she refused to withdraw permission.

"I cannot alter now," she said. "The matter is settled and I have given my word. If I have yielded wrongfully, I trust I may be forgiven. And I hope that Phyllys, when away from home, will not be led into evil."

Phyllys kissed her grandmother, in token of right intentions. What could she say? The idea of being "led into evil" by Giles was absurd. Though she did not yet know him well, she had not a particle of doubt as to his goodness.

CHAPTER VII

A STERN CHASE

WITH concealed rapture Phyllys heard of the promised visit to Castle Hill; and nothing was further from her expectations than to set eyes again on Giles before going. She hardly even wished to do so. There was so much to do and to think about during the next three weeks.

With Giles things were otherwise. He found himself unable to rest without another glimpse.

He did not yet say to himself that Phyllys might be more than cousin. He only knew that he could not get her out of his thoughts; that no sooner was he away from Midfell than he wanted to get back.

For five days he held out, determined not to act upon impulse. Then a member of his host's family fell seriously ill; and visitors took themselves off. Giles had a shooting engagement in the Highlands a week later, and nothing between. He resolved to spend the time at Midfell, asking no man's leave. The grandmother and cousin might not be delighted, but that he would risk; and he posted a line to Mrs. Wyverne, stating his intentions, remarking on the pleasure it would be to see them again.

The letter brought dismay. Mrs. Wyverne said nothing to Phyllys, still looking on her younger grand-daughter as a child; but she consulted with Barbara. Both recognised that nothing could be done. Giles had as clear a right as any human being to put up at the village Inn, if he chose, and to study the country. Though Mrs. Wyverne might demur, and Barbara might frown, they could not interfere.

"But of course you will not have him in and out all day long, turning everything upside down," the latter said with disgust. "Phyllys will be completely upset. Better to get her out of the way this afternoon, so that you can have a few words alone with him. You will have to be firm!" The speaker set her teeth. "I will make an errand for Phyllys, and we will say nothing to her, or she may refuse to go. You see, he intends to call directly he arrives."

Mrs. Wyverne made no objection, and Phyllys, to her surprise, was asked to take a long walk to an outlying farm, where she loved to go, but was not often permitted. She had been only once without a companion, and the idea was charming. Barbara seldom suggested anything so much to her taste. To fetch a warm shawl, left there, was the ostensible motive. Phyllys laughingly remarked that she would have a good "forenoon drinking," the local colloquialism for a mid-morning lunch, and would get something to eat at the farm. Barbara objected, not wishing her to get back early. After "dinner" would be best, she said. The days were long, and Phyllys could do her morning tasks.

"All right," agreed the girl. "I shall have a rest, and come back by the moor. It will be fun, won't it, Wiggles?"

Wiggles wagged an appreciative tail.

Not till she had left the house did Barbara note an ominous thickness upon the surrounding fells. It occurred to her that she ought to have warned Phyllys to return by the road, but it was now too late; so she dismissed the question from her mind. After all, Phyllys was old enough to be sensible.

Early in the afternoon, as Barbara had predicted, Giles Randolph walked in.

He greeted his great-aunt kindly, his cousin politely; and his eyes went in search of some one else.

"Where is Phyllys?" came soon.

And Barbara thrust in a reply before Mrs. Wyverne could speak. "Gone on the moors," she said, purposely vague, under a suspicion that he would wish to follow.

She over-reached herself.

"The moors—to-day? With whom, may I ask?"

"Phyllis goes everywhere. She is used to it, and the dog is ample protection."

"You do not mean that she is alone!"

His concern annoyed Barbara.

"Of course, she will not go far. Phyllis knows what she is about. She merely meant to cross part of a hill on her way back."

"From where?"

He had to put the question a second time, and facts were dragged out with difficulty. "Thackers' Farm. Yes, I know the direction. I had better go after her. The moors will be foggy."

"A touch of mist." Barbara spoke in vexed accents.

"It will be more than a touch of mist in an hour or two."

His manner aroused Mrs. Wyverne to uneasiness. She was too old an inhabitant of Midfell not to understand what a fog on the fells meant. "I did not know it," she said; "or that Phyllis meant to cross the moor. Surely you told her not to do so, Barbara. Not—alone!"

"She ought to have sense enough to judge for herself." Barbara frowned and bit her lips.

"The child is so fearless," murmured Mrs. Wyverne.

"I will start at once, and I hope to reach the farm before she leaves it. You may trust me to look after her. If I do not meet her on the road, I shall overtake her on the moor. The fog perhaps is not much now, but it may thicken." As he reached the door, he turned. "You told Phyllis I was coming?"

The direct words claimed a direct answer. Mrs. Wyverne, forgetful in small matters, looked at Barbara, who had to admit that Phyllis did not

know. A slight smile stirred Giles' lips. Phyllys had not of her own free will avoided him.

One or two inquiries in the village as to the route made all clear, and he was off at his best pace—a pace few men could rival. By road the distance was over five miles; and he made little of them, spurred by observation of the grey-capped fells. He knew enough of moorland to be aware that a fog, exceptional in density, covered the heights; and he was anxious, if possible, to intercept Phyllys at the farm. But on arrival, he found she had started fifteen minutes earlier; and since he had not met her, she must have gone the other way. The old farmer heard this with a shake of his head.

"Noa, I doan't knaw," he said. "I'm a negligent lad not to ha' ma-ade her go by t' ro-ad. Miss Phyllys ought to ha' knawed better."

"Miss Phyllys is not easily frightened," remarked Giles. "Will you tell me the way she has gone?"

He wasted no time, and was off again. A rough lane, besprinkled with stones, led to the edge of the moor; after which he had a grass track to guide him. It led upward, crossing a high spur, shortening the distance to Midfell by more than a mile.

No mistake here about the "mistiness." Every dozen yards the air grow thicker, as he widened his distance from the edge.

That Phyllys should not have retreated on finding the state of things perplexed him. Yet, had she done so, he must have met her. He wondered, was she one of those people who, once resolved on a course of action, stick to that course, whatever happens? He would not have credited her with obstinacy. He did credit her with unusual fearlessness.

The track, though faint, was distinct; visible by different shades of colouring in the turf, the impress of passing feet. It was clearer than many such tracks, being used a good deal in fine weather between Midfell and a

village on the other side. Here and there it was broken by a rough outcrop of rock; but despite the fog, Giles had no difficulty in picking it up again. And Phyllis was accustomed to such walking. She might have thought it wiser to keep steadily on, rather than to retrace her steps.

No voice of man or beast, of bird or insect, interrupted the silence. No stir in the air moved the heavy white curtain which hung around, shutting him in a contracted circle which moved with him as he went. The great moor-billows stretched away, he knew, for miles; but he could not see them. Landscape and sky were blotted out.

And Phyllis was alone in this! He walked rapidly, expecting every minute to descry a slim figure ahead. Not far ahead, for beyond a few yards, he could make out nothing. Now and again a shadowy form heaved into view, raising his hopes; and each time it grew into a furze-bush, dank and wet.

More than once he stopped, noting what looked like a short-cut to the lower level over Midfell, though no track was apparent. Phyllis might have ventured on some such short-cut. Yet, no—acquainted as she was with the country, she would understand the risk of quitting her path. The farmer had assured him that there was but the one way. He thought less of faint side-tracks, branching at right angles towards upper heights. These plainly led from Midfell, and would not have tempted Phyllis.

Still no signs of her! He pressed on, in deepening uneasiness; and sooner than might have seemed possible, he reached the verge, where a steep descent led downward to the top of a hill behind the village.

Here, being nearer the moor-edge, the air was clearer, and he could see some way. But—no Phyllis!

She could not so far have distanced him. No girl, even with the start she had had, could have failed to be overtaken at the pace he had come. With sickening dread, he realised that she was still upon the moors, that she had left the track.

"Nonsense!" he said, pulling himself together. "Too soon to be sure. She may have come faster than I imagine. She 'may' have missed her way, and be waiting near."

He turned to retrace his steps. If indeed she had advanced so far as this, she would easily manage to get home. His business now was to be sure that she had not failed; and while he encouraged himself his heart sank anew.

To be lost on the moor in a dense fog! Too well he knew what that would imply. Fifty men, searching, might search in vain. A night alone on the moors for 'her!' The thought brought a stab of actual pain.

Walking more slowly, he called at intervals in his strong base voice, listening with the hope that she might respond.

No sound, no whisper, reached his ears. It was deadly still. As he went farther, the fog again grew dense, more dense than before, since the afternoon was advanced. The dank white curtain closed him in.

He made up his mind to return most of the way, shouting at intervals. Then he would again traverse the path to Midfell, and would see whether she had reached home. If not, a party of men including himself should scour the hills.

For this those who knew the country were necessary. To quit the track now, with nothing to guide him, would only mean losing himself also, being powerless to help her.

Yet if indeed she were here, alone on these desolate moors!—the very idea was unendurable.

He felt this keenly, as he paced the turf, raising his cry of "Phyllys! Are you there, Phyllys?"

How familiar, how dear the name seemed! He could hardly believe that ten days earlier she had been nothing to him or he to her. Was he anything to her now? Perhaps not—yet. She had been ready to like him, as

cousin and friend. But Phyllys and he would not be "friends" only. They would be much more or much less.

On this deserted and fog-robed fell, he seemed to be growing intimate with her, as he might not in weeks of common acquaintance. He was shut out from all the world, except Phyllys; but she too was here. Though apart, they were together; both on the moor; she needing him; he bent on helping her. He did not now say that "perhaps" she was there. It had grown to be a certainty.

Were their spirits in touch, though bodily they were separate? He was by no means an imaginative or sentimental man. But, looking at the white wall, he saw her face—not smiling or mischievous; full of distress; imploring his aid.

He made a forward start, half distracted. She was on the moor. She "was" lost. And how was he to know where?

"Phyllys! Phyllys!" again he shouted, with the full strength of his lungs.

Something clammy touched his hand.

"Wiggles!" with an immense revulsion of joy. Where Wiggles was, Phyllys could not be far.

"Where is she, Wiggles? Phyllys, where are you?"

No human voice made reply. Wiggles whined, jumping on him, licking his hand, taking hold of his trouser.

"Where is she, Wiggles?" he asked, every nerve in him tense. There could no longer be any doubt. She would not have left Wiggles behind. That Wiggles should have left her seemed singular; but he might be a dog prone to wander. He might—this flashed up, as Wiggles again laid hold upon his trouser—have come for help.

"You must take me to her," he said, addressing the dog as he might have addressed a child. He drew a cord from his pocket, and passed it through the collar. "Now—lead!"

Wiggles seemed uncertain what to do. He sniffed the air, and whined afresh. Was it that he did not know Phyllys' whereabouts? Or was he stupid? Many affectionate little dogs are not brilliant in an emergency.

Giles put matters to the test. He set off at a resolute pace, as if for Midfell.

That settled it. Wiggles refused to go. He struggled, protested, howled, sat down. He might be dragged, but he would not walk. Giles ceased to pull, and Wiggles moved in a new direction, gaining confidence as he found Giles with him. He led away from the track, across the turf, and Giles followed, urging him on, trying to keep note of his bearings, though unsuccessfully. That troubled him little. If he could reach Phyllys, all else was of small importance.

"Phyllys—Phyllys!" he called again.

And out of the dead stillness rang an agonised cry. He knew the voice.

"I'm here! Where are you?"

"O come! O save me!" she screamed, her bell-like tones for once thin and shrill with horror.

He dashed headlong in the direction whence the sound travelled.

CHAPTER VIII

MR. DUGDALE'S OUTSPOKENNESS

THE model village of Castlemere had a fine aged church of grey stone, with solid square tower and the sweetest chime of bells in the county. A comfortable Rectory adjoined the churchyard; and picture cottages, inhabited by well-to-do tenants, clustered around. Giles Randolph was a liberal landlord.

Castle Hill House, half-a-mile distant, was united to the village by a private road, running through park and avenue; and nearly two miles from Castlemere, in the other direction, flourished a country town, Market Oakley by name.

At the better end of the town, its "west-end," so to speak, was the parish of S. John's, impinging in one direction on the extensive parish of Castlemere. Outside Market Oakley, in this direction, was Brook-End Grange, the home of Mr. Dugdale's daughter, Kathleen Alyn, a young widow, with one little boy.

She stood on the lawn, her gown flowing round her in a fashion peculiar to herself. Whatever she wore flowed, and did not hang or drag. The gown was perfect in make, for she never employed a second-rate dressmaker; and her fair hair was equally perfect in arrangement, for she always had a first-rate maid. Though she owned no good looks worth mentioning, few people observed her once only. There was repose in her bearing; and she was markedly graceful.

No hat sheltered her head. She would run out thus—though "run" is hardly the word for her gradual movements—into the charming, old-fashioned garden, at any moment, at any time of the year, even in winter with deep snow upon the ground. Now the stiff box hedges contrasted with abundant leafage; and the quaint borders were crammed with flowers.

She was intently observing; a queer little smile on her lips.

Some yards off was a small boy in knickerbockers, red-haired, snub-nosed, extremely pleased with himself. Beside him on the gravel path lay a

birdtrap, and in front, on his own private bed or "garden," reposed the dead bodies of three birds, two sparrows and a chaffinch.

It seemed that a funeral function was in progress. He had dug five neat graves in a row, and had deposited two birds in two of them. As Mrs. Alyn watched, he took a third, consigned it to receptacle number three, shovelled in the earth, and chanted a short requiem—

"Ashes to ashes, dust to dust,
What the little worms can't eat the big ones must."

A variety of feelings struggled on the mother's face, amusement among them. The boy, absorbed in his occupation, saw nothing. Bird number four was laid to rest, and again came the chant—

"Ashes to ashes, dust to dust,
What the little worms—"

"Gordon," she said.

Gordon dropped his trowel, and turned.

"What is all this, sonny?"

"Gardener said the birds was just eating everything up."

"Where did you find so many dead ones?"

"I didn't. I caught 'em."

"Killed them! In the trap?"

Gordon's under-lip pouted.

"And the words you were singing—who told you them?"

"Nobody. It's a funeral."

She found it difficult to keep her face serious. Stooping to pick up Number Five, she said, "Poor little bird! And it might be still alive and happy, enjoying the sunshine. I wouldn't have believed that my boy could be cruel."

She upset the trap with her foot, and walked away, her skirt swaying in undulatory style. Gordon stared after her. The worst thing that could happen in his little life was to have his mother displeased.

He shovelled the earth into the untenanted fifth hole; then, with a careless six-foot air, he marched towards the house, where Mrs. Alyn stood in the porch, still handling the hapless bundle of feathers.

"Going out, mum?"

"No, sonnie."

"Won't you take me for a walk?"

"No, sonnie."

Gordon's under-lip quivered.

"I didn't mean to be cruel—course! I promise, I won't kill no more birds."

For Gordon to give in without a struggle meant much. She bent down, and he flung two arms round her neck, anxiously glancing to make sure of no witnesses.

But witnesses there were, and he pulled himself erect.

Mr. Dugdale and Mrs. Keith came up the path; the former, as usual, bland, neat, precise; the latter excited.

"How do you do, Kathleen? I am on my way to the station, to change my books, and I thought I would look in on you for a few minutes. I have left the carriage outside—your father was just coming in, so I got out to walk with him. I suppose you would not care to drive to the station. You don't subscribe to Smith's."

"Certainly I should like it." Kathleen always enjoyed what other people wanted; and part of her attractiveness was due to this fact. "Shall I get my hat?"

"Well, on second thoughts I hardly know if it is worth while. I shall have to go straight home. Has Colin told you about his absurd fad? I wish Giles would not encourage it."

"Modelling?"

"Messing about with wet clay. Such ridiculous nonsense! Four huge packing-cases have come from Italy, with casts that he bought there. He never said a word in writing. I can't conceive why he should be so secretive; and I can't imagine what put the notion into his head."

"Nature!" spoke Mr. Dugdale at her side. "It is inborn."

She turned with a nervous movement of her hands, as if repudiating something.

"I never had the smallest taste that way. Nor any of my family."

"That may be. A genius is often a family freak—not to be accounted for by ordinary rules of heredity. No doubt traceable, if one had the means of tracing it, to some distant ancestor. You ought to be thankful for Colin's gift—no matter how he came by it."

She asked "Why?" Her fine eyes going to his face, as if in search for some sub-meaning. She was handsomer than Kathleen Alyn; yet the greater

charm rested with the younger woman. There was a lack of repose in Mrs. Keith; and she seemed to be perpetually on the watch for something to controvert.

"At the least it is a harmless occupation; and he needs something to do. Desk-work, of course, is out of the question."

"I don't see it, now he is stronger. Besides—" She stopped.

"He will never be strong enough for head-work. I don't mean strength in the muscular sense. His brain wouldn't stand the tension. You were going to say—besides—what?"

"There is no need that he should work."

"I don't agree with you. No self-respecting man will consent to be a burden on another."

"Colin is not a burden." Her eyes flashed resentfully. "It is Giles' delight to give him a home."

Kathleen made danger-signals from behind, but Mr. Dugdale failed to read them. Although himself a man prone to take offence, he was apt to say the wrong thing, thereby giving offence to others; and he never could imagine why offence should be taken.

"My dear lady, it may be Giles' delight to support half the neighbourhood; but half the neighbourhood has no right to be supported by him. Neither has Colin. The two are not related; and if they were, I should still say he ought to work for himself. Eh, Kathleen? Yes?"

Mrs. Keith drew up a haughty head.

"I suppose you consider me to be living on charity too," she said coldly.

"Certainly not; that is different," Mr. Dugdale interposed; but she went on, refusing to listen—

"I am extremely obliged! All those years that I lived for Giles do not count! Goodbye, Kathleen. It is later than I thought. I must go on."

Mrs. Alyn offered no protest. She signed to her father to remain where he was, slipped an affectionate arm within Mrs. Keith's, and walked down the carriage-drive. When she returned, a slight smile was on her lips.

"Now you 'have' put your foot in it, father!"

"Eh? Have I? My dear, I merely spoke the truth. I merely suggested what everybody is saying. Colin ought to do something. His choice is circumscribed; but really there is no reason why he should live a life of dependence. I'm glad he has the spirit to refuse it for himself."

"Colin has any amount of spirit. I only hope he will not bring on another breakdown. It would be a thousand pities."

"He will do well enough if he isn't fussed. I never can fathom Mrs. Keith," mused Mr. Dugdale, with knitted brows. "Whatever one expects her to do, she is certain to do the opposite. I should have thought, with her proud nature—Proud! Yes! A pikestaff isn't 'in' it beside her!—I should have thought she would be charmed at the most distant prospect of Colin making his own way in life. I'd have staked my credit on it! Yet all she wants, apparently, is to keep him in blissful idleness! Can't understand it, for my part. I imagined I knew something of women: but they are a riddle and a delusion to the end of the chapter."

"I hope you don't count me a delusion."

He looked oddly at her. "I had the training of you."

Kathleen could not help laughing.

"There's another puzzle. Why has Mrs. Keith set her mind on getting Phyllis to Castle Hill? You wish it, and I wish it. Her father and I were friends. Giles might wish it too. But Mrs. Keith has talked and worried, bothered and insisted! And why? She has no connection with the girl."

"Perhaps she thinks it will add to the liveliness of Castle Hill."

"If that were all, she could invite a dozen young women. Giles never says No to her—"

"He has gone against her in the modelling."

Mr. Dugdale waved a protesting hand.

"You are a woman too, my dear! Even you cannot let a man finish his sentence before springing an opposite view. I was about to say that Giles never says No to Mrs. Keith, unless saying Yes to her means No to Colin."

"Perhaps she has an idea that Phyllis might make a good wife for Colin."

"Absurd! She has never seen the girl."

"According to Giles 'the girl' is worth seeing."

"That is recent. Mrs. Keith set her mind years ago on getting hold of her. However, I give it up. Woman's ways are beyond me."

He spread forth deprecating hands; then made a new start. "'Lived for Giles!' Nonsense! She lived for herself and Colin. Took care of Giles by the way—and was well paid for it too! The allowance was absurd! It has been a paying concern for Mrs. Keith from first to last."

"At any rate she did her best for Giles."

"Mrs. Keith knows on which side of her bread lies the butter. I don't blame her. There are advantages in worldly wisdom—for its possessor. But when she talks in the high-falutin' style of all she has been and done, as if, forsooth, 'she' were the family benefactor and Giles her humble debtor—no, I can't stand that. Some day I shall speak out."

"Better not. Giles would not thank you. So long as things go smoothly, why stir up the mud?"

Mr. Dugdale struck his hands together.

"I have it! I vow, it never occurred to me before. Phyllys is the next in succession. If anything happened to Giles, she would sooner or later reign here. Unless Giles should have made provision for Mrs. Keith in his will—"

"Which of course he has done!"

"There is no 'of course' in connection with any man's will. The most unlikely arrangements are made; the most likely are left unmade. Mrs. Keith means to provide for contingencies. Gloriously far-sighted!" Then he turned to inspect a hairy caterpillar, reposing on the grubby palm of his little grandson.

Mrs. Keith, driving to the station, smoothed her ruffled plumage as best she might. Mr. Dugdale had a knack of ruffling her.

When Giles' mother died, and he was given over into the care of Mrs. Keith, then a young newly-made widow with one baby-boy, Mr. Randolph undertook to pay her, so long as she should have charge of his child, a yearly income of eight hundred pounds. On the death soon after of the father, the boy's guardian continued the payment; and Giles himself, since coming of age, although she could no longer be reckoned "in charge" of him, had made her the same allowance. These facts were known to Mr. Dugdale; and Mrs. Keith knew that he knew them. She did not really suspect him of having meant to say anything unkind. She had lost her temper, because his manner ruffled her.

Nobody, who observed this handsome well-dressed woman, seated in a luxurious landau, would have imagined her to be in any sense "living upon charity."

And she was not, in her own opinion. She had for years been a "mother" to Giles. She had given the best of her time, thought, and affection to both boys; to Giles not less than Colin. She had earned an income, now hers so long that she seemed to possess a right to it. Charity, indeed! But the

word had been foolishly her own, not Mr. Dugdale's; and this she now recognised, regretting her unreasonable annoyance.

As regarded Colin, she knew that Mr. Dugdale had only "voiced" what everybody would think. A young man should certainly endeavour to make his own way in life. In the present case there were, it is true, peculiar circumstances which, if known to Mr. Dugdale, would tend to put a different complexion on the whole. But Mr. Dugdale did not know these circumstances—never would know them, she said to herself! It would have been more sensible if she had fallen in with his utterances. Of course she too wished Colin to do something, to find some pursuit, even though she knew that it was Giles' greatest pleasure to provide for him.

Some pursuit,—only, "not" modelling!—"not" sculpture! Anything, rather!

CHAPTER IX

A MOORLAND DEATH-TRAP

THOUGH Phyllys could hardly be called obstinate, she liked to carry out her intentions. On the way to Thacker's farm she saw a thickness clothing the fells, but it made no great impression on her mind. From morning to night she thought now of little but the promised visit to Castle Hill.

After tea and a chat with the farmer and his wife, she spoke of return.

"I should like to stay for hours," she said, "if it were only to see the cows 'provened.'" She loved to use local colloquialisms, and the old man chuckled, pleased with her pretty ways. "Oh, and I must go along the

fother'em and take a look at the stalls. Have you any calves?—Any stirks? You see, I know all about it!"—merrily.

At length she was off; and rather by a mechanical movement, than of intent, she turned towards the moor, carrying over one shoulder the heavy shawl.

Not till on the lower slopes of the fell did she note how heavy was the grey pall that hid the heights. As yet she approached only its dragging fringes, but she had to ascend, and it was getting on for five o'clock. The fog would thicken as evening advanced.

But, as Giles had said, she was not easily frightened. She found the shawl heavy; and she would have to go all the way back to the farm before beginning the long round by the road. She had only to keep to the track. When she reached the other side, descending towards Midfell, she would soon leave fog behind.

"Shall we go on, Wiggles?" she asked. "It looks rather horrid up there. But turning back would be still more horrid. Shall we make a dash for it?"

Wiggles wagged his tail.

"Ready for anything, are you not, you old dear? I'll try!" And she murmured, touching in turn each coat-button, "Will go!—Won't go!—Will go!—Won't go!" Till the last was reached. "The 'will' has it. Come along."

Having decided, she pressed forward, and was surprised to find how much farther the way seemed in these conditions than in sunlight.

Still, she was on the path, and she was all right.

The fog at first was not so dense as when, later, Giles retraced his steps, but it was dense enough to be unpleasant; and more than once she regretted not having chosen the road. She met no human being, and heard no voice. Dim outlines of bushes dawned as she walked, and disappeared again. She advanced at a good pace; and presently, growing used to the gloom, she fell into a muse upon the coming joys of Castle Hill.

Giles would be there; and to know more of Giles would be charming. She liked him. He was just the sort of friend she wanted; caring for the things she cared for; ready to hear, prompt to understand. Then there would be Mrs. Keith and Colin. She might not like the latter so much as Giles; still the fact that Giles thought much of Colin proved that there was good in him. About Mrs. Keith she was doubtful. Giles had been reserved; but she had detected a something in his manner which suggested lack of admiration.

However, since Mrs. Keith had wanted Phyllys to go to Castle Hill, she would be grateful.

It would be such an escape! She would be in a new world, free to see with her own eyes, to hear with her own ears, to form her own ideas, to observe, to learn, to feel, without home trammels. She would be no longer in a stiff groove, where everybody was expected to think the same as everybody else, under penalty of condemnation.

How dense the fog was! Absorbed in anticipations, she had not noted surroundings, but had followed the track in a mechanical fashion. Now she realised that it was time to have reached the brow of the fell.

Wiggles drew her attention. He was close to heel, not running about as was his wont. When she looked, he sat down, as if unwilling to go farther.

"Why, Wiggles, are you tired?"

She went on, and he followed, then again sat down, with a whine.

Phyllys knew that in keeping to the track she was all right, fog or no fog. She had but to go on. But a doubt assailed her. This "was" the track, of course—this shadowy line. She bent to look more closely, and stood up, grave in face.

Not the right path. It was a mere sheep-track, probably leading to the top of the fell. In sheer absence of mind she had quitted the path to Midfell—perhaps at one of the rocky breaks—and had turned along this instead.

Vexed at her carelessness, she hurriedly retraced her steps, following the feeble little line. Soon she was brought to a standstill; for it died out, and she searched in vain for a continuation. The ground here was stony, and doubtless a continuation did exist; but she could not find it.

Phyllys kept her head. She stood still, striving to grasp her situation.

No easy matter this, to the most experienced man, in such a fog, with all landmarks blotted out. She did not understand fully the risks involved. Had she felt more afraid, she might have allowed Wiggles to act as her guide; but she was naturally confident, and the idea did not so much as occur to her. Wiggles, satisfied that she no longer aimed for the summit, awaited her pleasure.

"All right," she said aloud, having made up her mind whereabouts she stood. She pictured the way that she had—must have—come. She placed the hills mentally, localised Midfell, and decided on her direction. Then she started briskly, and Wiggles followed—reluctantly still, as if not happy.

No sign of the vanished track appeared, but she went on in good spirits, convinced that she was nearing the ridge behind Midfell, expecting each minute to find the path. According to her reasoning, this was a certainty. If the top of the fell lay "there," and the village of Midfell "there," then the track along the hillside "must" cut across somewhere in front.

She failed to gauge the momentous character of that word "if."

That she should have lost all count of the true positions of hill-top and of village; that north and south, east and west, should be as one to her consciousness; that in the fog she should not know whether she was going uphill or downhill; that when she supposed herself to be following a straight line, she was describing a semi-circle which brought her indeed within half-a-mile of the lost track, but to a part of the fell which beyond every other ought to have been avoided—all this was miles from her imagination.

It did occur as curious that the fog should thicken instead of lessening as she—according to her belief—neared the moor-edge. But the advance of evening might account for so much. The track must now be close, and she

hurried on, shivering with the clammy atmosphere. The heavy shawl still hung over her left shoulder; and lifting its front folds she flung them over her right shoulder, for warmth.

She was growing anxious, and because she would not give in to the feeling, she hurried on more recklessly, not noting how Wiggles hung back.

Ah, here was boggy ground. "I must keep clear of that," she thought, being used to such patches on the moors. Many a time she had crossed them, springing from root to root of heather, deftly avoiding insecure parts.

A yelp made her glance round. Nose in air, with cocked ear, Wiggles had made out something which failed to reach her duller senses. Then he was off, regardless of her recall. Perhaps he knew that disobedience had become a duty.

Phyllis hesitated, but she could not follow, for he was out of sight, swallowed up in the white curtain. She supposed that he had caught sight of some small creature, and had started in chase. He would be back directly, and would find her.

She scanned her limited circle of visibility. In front and to the right lay an expanse of green—bright green, so far as anything could be bright in such an atmosphere. It was mottled with red and yellow, variegated moss-hues; and dotted with clumps of rushes. Here and there grew the white-tufted cotton-grass; and wiry bog-grass of an olive-green with red tintings might be seen in abundance. Despite the dulness, these colours, which in sunshine would have been ominously brilliant, suggested a need for caution.

She could not see far. She did not suspect that this was no mere patch of boggy soil—that a wide reach of treacherous slime, with only a thin coating of moss and grass, a death-trap for the unwary, lay around. On a clear day she would have read tokens of peril in the very brightness of colouring, which alike concealed and revealed the deadly danger. But though she had been in sunshine to this place, and had been warned of the trap which that fair surface offered, she never dreamt that she was now on its verge.

It was just a bit of "saft" ground, as they call it in Scotland, and she was not troubled. She went on again, more swiftly than before, eager to cross it, then to wait for Wiggles. One moment later she would have heard Giles' voice shouting—but—

A false step; and she plunged in, over both ankles. It took her by surprise. The effort to save herself might have proved successful, had she been going cautiously. But the impetus of her run made it impossible to stop; and as she tried to leap to what looked like a firm spot, she caught her foot in a tangle of rushes.

She fell far forward, spread-eagle fashion, sliding on with the struggle to save herself, down into the horrible slimy bog, which yielded beneath her.

Phyllys was a girl of high courage, but in that moment of terrible helplessness and sinking, the soft, sucking, sticky grip upon her limbs and the sense of nothing to cling to, nothing to hold by, nothing to pull against, brought a sickening agony of terror.

CHAPTER X

DIREFUL REALISATIONS

SHE knew what it meant. Thought at such a time is rapid; and as she went down, as she felt the black slime rising around her, she knew she was in a quaking bog, that bog upon the fell against which she had been often warned; that bog which, had she been questioned one minute sooner, she would have averred to be at least half-a-mile away, in the most unfrequented part of the moor.

And she was in it—lying face downward upon its treacherous surface; the bright deceptive moss giving way like paper under her weight, the dark half-liquid peat covering her limbs.

Had this been winter, had the accident happened after any spell of heavy rain, no hope for Phyllys could have existed. At such seasons the whole swamp was a lake of foul watery mud, in which she would have instantly sunk, and from the first plunge nothing more would have been seen or heard of the hapless girl. Strong men, lost on the moors after dark, had so met their end; and as she fell, she remembered the last—a traveller who had inadvertently leaped upon the smooth surface, and had disappeared from sight.

But the weather lately had been dry, and the peat-mud was in a semi-liquid, tenacious condition, capable of bearing up a prone body for at least several minutes.

One other pressing peril was met. Falling thus, she might have met with immediate suffocation, but that her heavy shawl, thrown from the front over both shoulders, dropped upon the bog outspread below her face, guarding nose and mouth from the smothering grip of the mud.

At the first moment, as she realised what had occurred, she fought wildly, desperately, to escape. But she had gone too far, sliding beyond reach of firm ground, and she had nothing to hold by. She was powerless to drag her feet from the gripping black stuff. She had nothing to grasp, nothing which would give her a purchase, and each effort sent her deeper. It seemed that she was being slowly dragged under.

She tried to shriek for help, but voice was gone. Breath and strength failed with horror. Again she strove to raise herself, and again she sank lower. Her only hope lay in keeping still.

The position in which she lay was the best she could have chosen—her weight distributed, the shawl under her face. But she could not long remain thus. In a little while the black mud would rise up and overpower her.

Afraid to stir, prone and helpless, every nerve was alive, every faculty wide awake. Thoughts flashed like lightning one upon another; past, present, future intermingled. She strove to be calm, to pray for help. She knew that death meant life beyond, and she was conscious of a definite clinging to the One Great Name, which alone has power in man's last extremity. She tried to think of re-union with the father and mother whom she loved. But she was so young, and life in this world held much of promise, and she wanted to learn more, to do more, to understand more, before the final passage. She shrank from such a passage as this. Suffocation, alone in a horrible bog, mantled over by the white fog-pall, was ghastly.

"O God, save me!—Save!" she panted.

A shout reached her ears. Somebody was coming. She tried to call, and it seemed that her voice went no distance. If she could keep up till help came!—but the slime was creeping higher. She saw it, felt it. It was making its way round the borders of her shawl. She watched with fascinated eyes. Soon the shawl would be sucked under; then the mud would reach her lips; then—nobody would know what had become of her.

Would Giles be sorry? She thought so, and she sobbed a little. The man whose voice she had heard must have gone by; it seemed hours since the sound reached her. Had she been told that not five minutes had passed since her fall, she would have counted the words wild.

Another shout roused her from despair. She called, "O come! O save me!" And the mud began to pour in a slow stream over the shawl.

Led by Wiggles, Giles had aimed for the swamp, and suddenly Phyllis knew his voice. Her courage revived, for if anybody could save her, he could. She felt no surprise at his appearance.

"Where are you?" he called.

"In the bog. Take care; don't get in too!"

He had to approach with caution; but he made her out, lying nearly submerged, head and shoulders alone visible above the dark surface.

Had he not been compelled to give his whole mind to the problem of rescue, the horror of her condition would have overwhelmed him. He realised how awfully critical it was, how great the need for action. But he also realised that to rush recklessly in would only seal her fate.

"Keep still; don't move," he urged. "I'll have you out. Don't be afraid."

He measured the space at a glance, and tested the boggy earth with his stick, to find a spot which would bear his weight. Whatever he felt, he was composed, and she now made no sound, but lay motionless on her loathsome bed. The white brave face—so much as he could see of it, which was little—went to his heart.

Three steps, taken in a direct line, would have carried him within reach; but those steps were impossible. A few feet farther he found a tongue of firm ground jutting into the bog, and this brought him nearer to where she lay. Not yet within touch—a single long step would do the business, but he sought in vain for standing ground.

She was sinking—visibly—and his dread was that she might go under. Few though the moments were since his arrival, he saw a change.

The mud here was drier, less soft than farther out. He pulled off his coat, spread it upon the boggy surface, and went down full length, creeping gingerly towards her.

"Don't struggle; keep still and trust yourself to me," he said.

Never in after-life would Phyllis forget what the first grip of his hand meant after the past interminable horror. She obeyed him, and did not struggle—at what a cost of will she alone knew. For still the slime was around, and during one terrible moment it seemed that Giles was sinking, that her last hope was gone.

But slowly he drew her towards himself; then worked his way to firmer turf, where his feet rested; and as he went, he pulled her with him.

He was on it at last, kneeling deep sunk in "saft" earth, but not drawn under. Another moment, and he had regained his feet; another, and they were on solid ground.

"Come this way—farther," he said.

He stood still, breathing hard, and Phyllis said nothing. She could not speak at first, the awfulness of what she had escaped rendering her dumb. She was a mass of black mud, except the head; and Giles was clothed in the same.

"Thank God I was in time!" he faltered, and the break in his voice made her look up.

"I can't thank you—" she tried to say, and because a lump in her throat choked her, she laughed. "What a state we are both in!"

The laugh grated on her own hearing, but not on his, for he read in the strain of its unnatural tone a fresh effort of her undaunted courage. She stood gazing towards where she had fallen. "If you had not come just when you did, I should have been—"

"Don't!" he entreated.

She gave him a wistful glance. "Isn't it strange? Just one step wrong, and everything nearly at an end. No going to Castle Hill!"

He knew this was not lightness. Her limbs shook, and she was ashen. "Come," he said, and he led her farther. "The question is how we are to get to Midfell."

"I know about where we are. There's a path near—if we could find it. It leads straight to the village,—and to a farm half way, where we might stop."

"A good plan. Wiggles will lead us; he brought me to you."

"Did he?" in surprise. "I shouldn't have thought he could." A cold nose was thrust into her hand, and she surprised herself by bursting into tears. "Dear old Wiggles," she sobbed, and then—"I'm sorry to be stupid."

"It's all right; don't mind. Try not to think about things yet."

He slipped the string once more through Wiggles' collar, and looked at her with solicitude. "You are sure you can walk?"

"Of course I can!" indignantly. "Please don't tell Barbara I cried. It's only—if you knew what it was—"

"I know. Not many girls would have shown such pluck," and the admiration in his voice brought a smile to her lips. "You were splendidly brave. Of course you are shaken now. Suppose you try to make Wiggles understand that we want to go home."

This acted as a diversion, and she was soon her usual self, though pale. Giles explained how it was that he had come to Midfell; and Wiggles proved a reliable guide, so that in no long time they reached the farm, where they were glad to get rid of encasing mud. A man was despatched to bring clean clothing for both, and later they reached Burn Cottage, where extreme anxiety had reigned.

The old lady listened in agitated thankfulness to the tale of her grandchild's narrow escape; and her gratitude to Giles knew no bounds. She held his hand in her soft withered palms, tears in her eyes, words trembling on her lips. She folded her restored darling in a close embrace—no common action for one so undemonstrative—and prayed and wept over her. Phyllys shed tears also, and realised how dear the old grandmother was, despite certain misunderstandings.

What Barbara felt at this outcome of her scheming did not so fully appear. A word of blame with regard to Phyllys' "stupidity" in not keeping clear of the bog received settlement at the hand of Giles.

"Phyllys ought not to have been allowed to go at all," he said; and Barbara understood. She fumed, but was silent.

This event put the presence of Giles in Midfell on a new footing. The cousin to whom Mrs. Wyverne owed Phyllys' life could not be held at arms' length. Let his opinions be what they might, he had earned a right to come in and out. For once, Barbara and Miss Robins were powerless to touch the old lady's determination. Her thankful joy was too deep not to find expression.

During his week at the Inn, he made the best of his opportunity. He and Phyllys strolled about the fields together, had long walks together, talked together endlessly,—though in such talks hers was the lion's share, and he acted the part of charmed listener. He was not a man of many words.

These days of intercourse settled the question for him. Before the week ended, he loved Phyllys, loved her with his whole being. She was not, perhaps, his first fancy, but she was his first true love. She might be his last.

He had no thought, however, of showing in haste what he felt. His attentions were simple and cousin-like in kind; and no one guessed the truth. He knew that he had to win Phyllys, and that the winning might not prove easy.

She was friendly, even affectionate, and delighted with his companionship. He could see that she never forgot what she owed to him; but he had no wish that she should marry out of gratitude; and he would not take her at a disadvantage.

With all her frankness, Phyllys was not easy to read. The very readiness with which she had taken to him, and the easy gladness with which day after day she met him, were, he knew, not hopeful symptoms.

Had she been more shy, less responsive, he might have felt more sanguine. Hopeful he did feel, but hardly of immediate results; and his chief fear was lest he should be drawn into a too hasty betrayal of his love.

That she liked him as a cousin he saw. Whether she would like him equally as a lover was another question. He had to proceed cautiously.

CHAPTER XI

CASTLE HILL PERPLEXITIES

AT the appointed hour for Phyllys' arrival, Mrs. Keith went to the station.

And together they drove through the town, the elder lady exchanging bows with acquaintances by the way. Phyllys took everything in with interested eyes.

Leaving Market Oakley behind, they bowled swiftly along the smooth high-road till Castlemere was reached; then by a lodge-gate they entered the private grounds leading to Castle Hill.

Once indoors Mrs. Keith unbent. Thus far she had merely made herself agreeable. Now her gloved hands held those of Phyllys, and she looked tenderly in the girl's face. After a momentary hesitation, real or assumed, she bent for a kiss.

Phyllys was touched, and a wonder stirred within her. Why should Mrs. Keith be so affectionate? That Giles should have liked to know her had seemed natural, since he was near of kin; but that Mrs. Keith should care was puzzling.

Then she recalled her late peril, and the fact that Giles had rescued her. This might give Mrs. Keith a peculiar feeling. Or perhaps Mrs. Keith was so fond of Giles as to be gladdened by anything that gave him pleasure. Phyllys smiled over the latter solution, and Mrs. Keith kissed her again.

"My dear, I am delighted to get you here. We have wanted it for years. Giles particularly."

"It is delightful to come."

This little scene took place in the ante-room, between hall and drawing-room; and as they entered the latter a slight gasp broke from Phyllys.

It was large and many-windowed, with nooks and retreats, a ceiling artistically designed and coloured, fine paintings on the walls, a broad general harmony of outline and tinting, and a delicate beauty of contrast in details, which at once appealed to Phyllys. She thought of the prim little sitting-room at home, its stiff squareness, its ponderous furniture, its framed texts.

"Ah!" murmured Mrs. Keith.

"I never saw anything like it!"

"Unusual, is it not? I am glad you can appreciate. Now you will like some tea. Where can Colin be?" She rang the bell. "Tell Mr. Keith we are here," she said to the butler.

"Mr. Keith desired not to be disturbed, ma'am. Tea was taken by his wish to the studio."

A fretted look came, and one cup clicked against another. "Nonsense! What nonsense!" Mrs. Keith's brows drew together.

"Does Colin paint?" asked Phyllys. "Mr. Keith, I mean."

"He is 'Colin,' not 'Mr. Keith,' to you, my dear. Yes, he dabbles in painting; and lately he has taken an absurd fancy for messing with wet clay, trying to model. Sheer waste of time, for he has no gift in that direction."

The resentful tone in which she alluded to Colin's pursuit was in contrast with the note of her next remark.

"Such a pity Giles is still away. Yes,—" seeing with pleasure Phyllys' disappointment—"he was to have got home yesterday. But the friend with whom he has been shooting in the Highlands fell ill, and cannot travel."

Giles has stayed to take care of him. So like Giles! Always thinking of others before himself! And I know what a disappointment it must be to him. Till he arrives, you must put up with Colin and me."

Phyllys tried to hide what she felt. This was indeed a "Waterloo without a Wellington." She hoped she had succeeded, but was not sure. Those fine restless eyes seemed to see a great deal; and so surely as she glanced up she met them. The scrutiny was kind, however, and conveyed approval.

This first evening at Castle Hill was very unlike what Phyllys had pictured. One figure, large and quiet, with straight gaze and few utterances, had never been absent from previous visions; but while others, hazy in anticipation, were taking shape, that was the one lacking.

Not for long! She found consolation in this thought, and also in Mrs. Keith's assurances that her disappointment was shared by Giles. She could not know that he had given Mrs. Keith no right to make such an assertion, for she had yet to learn the liberal manner in which her hostess was wont to draw upon a vivid imagination.

She did find, to her surprise, that nothing was known by Mrs. Keith of her bog adventure or of the part played by Giles. She told the tale simply not without a shivering aversion which she could not yet conquer. Mrs. Keith showed excitement.

"My dear, what an awful thing! Too dreadful! If Giles had not been near! Yes, he saved your life! How thankful he must have been! No, he said nothing in his letters. But he would not. That is Giles all over—never speaking of what he has done himself. But you and he will never forget. It seems quite a link between you." She shot a glance to see if this was appreciated. Phyllys took it quietly.

Till the dinner-gong sounded, nothing was heard of Colin. Then the butler announced, "Mr. Keith is sorry not to come to dinner."

Mrs. Keith made a sharp turn. "Why?"

"Mr. Keith does not wish for any dinner, ma'am."

"Absurd!" she muttered. Then to Phyllis, with a constrained smile, "You and I must make the most of each other. Colin is treating us cavalierly."

"He must be very fond of modelling," the girl said, as they went through the hall.

"A great deal too fond. Such a waste of time."

"Do you think so? My father used to love it. They said he was a born sculptor."

She had an odd impression that her words had administered a blow. Tightening lips and drawn brows showed strong feeling. Not till they were seated did a reply come, with evident unconsciousness of the interval.

"There are so many things better worth doing."

Phyllis wisely resolved to avoid a discussion.

Mrs. Wyverne, despite opposition from Barbara and exhortations from Miss Robins, on the score of encouraging vanity, had taken care that her grandchild should not do her discredit. Phyllis had one evening frock, which she wore now, pretty, and in good taste. Perhaps she felt its prettiness a trifle thrown away under present circumstances; yet she enjoyed herself.

The great dining-room, with its ancestral portraits, its heavy silver candelabra, its antique furniture, its well-laid table, its flowers, its butler and footman waiting in deferential silence, all laid pleasant hold upon her. She had no sense of embarrassment. Everything seemed natural and as should be. Travelling abroad in childhood, and being much among grown-up people before the age of thirteen, had given her an ease which she could not have acquired in Midfell alone, despite the old lady's excellent manners.

Great as was the contrast between Castle Hill arrangements and those of Burn Cottage, she behaved as if all her life used to the former. Mrs.

Keith, narrowly observant, was more and more satisfied. The slight upset to her equanimity, whatever it had meant, passed off, and she talked continuously.

When they returned to the drawing-room, Mr. Dugdale appeared, making at once for Phyllis.

"I knew your father well," was his first remark. "Wyverne and I were friends. He was one of the best men it has ever been my good fortune to come across."

Had Mr. Dugdale set himself to win her liking, he could have chosen no wiser method. For years she had lived among those who condemned her father—Barbara "in toto;" the old lady, not without deep motherly love, yet with grief and regret, because on certain religious points he had not seen with herself. And here was one who had known him, had understood him. Her heart went out towards the elderly man, with his cool cynical manner. Let him be what he might, he had cared for her father. Mr. Dugdale adjusted his pince-nez, and examined her with interest. Then Colin came in.

"Sorry to have been so unsociable. I hope you forgive me," he said, as he shook hands with Phyllis. He spoke in a low dragging voice, and found a seat where his face was in shade.

"Why did you not come to dinner?" his mother asked in displeasure.

"I thought you would excuse me for once,"—cheerfully.

"And of course you have eaten nothing since luncheon. Just like him—" turning to Mr. Dugdale. "Colin never can do anything in moderation. This fad of his will undo the whole good of his time abroad. It is ridiculous."

"Fad!" repeated Mr. Dugdale, with meaning.

Colin fenced quietly, beating off the attack with a half languid but graceful good-humour, which Phyllis thought charming. Then attention was distracted, Mr. Dugdale falling into a discussion with Mrs. Keith on

some trivial point of difference. Colin moved to a chair near Phyllis, and she had for the first time a distinct view.

Unlike Giles, certainly. He looked very tired, and there were purple shades below the eyes, which had a fixed inwardness of expression. A hand was lifted between them and the nearer lamp.

"So Giles stole a march upon us, making your acquaintance in the north."

"If he had not, I should not be here now." Somehow she did not at once feel at home with Colin as with Giles. He awakened a shy side of her, seldom visible. Giles from the first had drawn her out. Colin unconsciously repressed her. It might have been his ease of bearing, his calm aloofness. Giles possessed a cultivated ease; but Colin's was an intrinsic ease, which perhaps nothing could disturb. In Giles it was an acquired possession; in Colin it seemed to be a part of himself.

"Ah, then we must be grateful to him."

"I think I am." She tried to speak naturally. "Pity he cannot get home yet."

"Yes; I'm sorry." A pause, and Phyllis pulled herself together. The feeling of bashfulness was absurd. "Mrs. Keith says you are fond of modelling."

A shade of interest dawned. "Do you know anything of it?"

"My father used to model in clay."

"Then you understand the grip it takes upon one."

"Yes; I used to see that. He was a busy clergyman, and had very little spare time. But when he could get to it, he was happy. I was only ten years old when he died; still one doesn't forget."

"Perhaps you will take a look at my studio to-morrow."

"May I? That will be delightful. Are you doing statues?"

"Busts chiefly. I may take to statuettes by-and-by. Portrait-sculpture seems to be my line."

"My father did only small things. I used to stand and watch him, and the clay looked so tempting! I longed to try. They were afraid it might make me rheumatic."

"No uncommon result. So far I have been lucky."

"Have you worked hard to-day?" she asked, noting that he talked mechanically, like a machine wound up.

"Rather."

"Till after dinner?"

"I gave in before that."

"You look as if—" She hesitated, doubtful how far she might venture. The doubt had not assailed her with Giles, yet of the two, Colin was the more gentle. He responded to what she had not said.

"One can't stick to work without paying for it; but the game is worth the candle."

"I wonder if it is!"

The heavy blue eyes, still with that curious oppressed "inward" look, met hers, but could not gaze. "You are a trifle too keen-sighted. Don't betray me, please."

"Wouldn't it be better for you not to talk?"

He took her at her word, and soon beat a retreat.

The others did not notice until he was gone; and Mrs. Keith drew her lips together. "At it again!" was written on her face.

"Had she really not seen?" wondered Phyllys.

CHAPTER XII

COLIN AND HIS WORK

COLIN did not appear next morning till breakfast was ended; and a cup of tea met his wants. Mrs. Keith was short in manner, as if still offended; but her vexation seemed powerless to ruffle him. Phyllys wondered whether he felt it more than he showed.

She scanned him with interest. A gift to delve below the surface was hers, but as yet it had not been developed; and while he interested, he baffled her.

Everything in this new world claimed attention: Colin not least. The contrast was great between his slender outlines and dilettante ease, and the muscular vigour of Giles. That she would like Colin she felt sure; not as she liked Giles, yet perhaps not less. The intellectual development of his face, the dreamy abstraction which seemed a part of himself, laid hold on her imagination. He resembled no one she had hitherto come across. It would be difficult, she thought, to view him with indifference. He might be liked or disliked; he could not be ignored. Her eyes were again and again drawn in his direction; and each time she found herself to be the object of his study.

The night before he had seen a pretty girl in a neat frock, hazily indistinct. Things were apt to grow hazy, when overpowering headache had him in its grasp. He would often talk on, while unable to see across the room.

To-day, though not at his best, he could use his faculties, and he recognised that Phyllys was out of the common. The rounded outlines of her slim figure, the flow of hair about her well-shaped head, the subtleties of moulding in cheek and chin, the sweet expressiveness of eyes half hidden under dense fringes, the changeful suggestions of light and shade—these found their way to his brain, touching him as artist, not as man. He scrutinised her, not as a girl of flesh and blood, but as a subject for statuary.

Breakfast over, he strolled through the French window, and indulged in a cigarette; but when Mrs. Keith disappeared, Phyllys heard at her side the soft dragging voice, which at first she had supposed to mean physical weakness, but which she found to be habitual.

"Will you come with me?" he said.

On reaching the room, lately transformed into a studio, she gave one of her little gasps of pleasure. It appealed to her artistic instincts—hers by inheritance and early cultivation, not slain by ten years of systematic asphyxiation.

Two skylight windows had been made, with arrangements for modifying light from either, and a heavy curtain was partly drawn across the side-window. Near the stove at one end of the long room, on a square of carpet, were a sofa and an armchair. The space remaining was boarded and bare. At the centre stood a modelling-stand, heavy and four-legged, with a revolving top, upon which was something hidden by cloths.

Framed photographs of antique sculptures adorned the walls, varied by fine bas-reliefs. Several statues occupied small pedestals; and on a side-table lay plaster casts of limbs and hands, together with odd little wooden tools, which she touched with pleasure, for they recalled old days.

"And this?" she questioned, pausing beside a closed door. "Is this part of the studio?"

"If I should take to plaster-casting, that will be my casting-room. At present I use it for odds and ends."

He opened the door, and showed a large wooden box, lined with zinc and half-full of damp clay, prepared for use; also a water-tap with its sink, and a watering-pot with a fine rose. "One must have everything ready."

"You don't do the casting yourself, then, or cutting in marble?"

"I have tried my hand at both. Here—" as they returned to the larger room—"a bit of low relief, for practice. Not worth much. Carving in marble is slow work. At present I give my attention to modelling in clay."

He took her round, pointing out some casts that he had brought from Italy, imitations from historic masterpieces. They lingered over a bust after the Venus of Milo; then over the copy of an ancient dilapidated torso, which Phyllis surveyed with dubious eyes.

"I don't think I care about that. It might be anything."

"Ah, but it is grand. The work of a great sculptor. See the moulding, how squarely it is put in. Look at those flat surfaces, and the relation of each to the whole. The main question in sculpture is not so much what a man works at as how he works at it." Then a pause, and a slow smile. "For the matter of that, the same may be said of all Art—painting, music, writing. Now I will show you something that you will appreciate."

He lifted down a bas-relief in pure white plaster, a reduction from Donatelli's S. Cecilia, exquisite in delicacy of modelling.

Phyllis clasped her hands with a gesture of delight, pretty because unconscious, as she drank in the beauty of that refined angelic face.

Colin altered the slant of it. "See—if the light falls in a full glare you hardly make out anything. Now, if I put it so that shadows are thrown, you have the effect—you get the soul of it."

He held the thing motionless, till with a sigh she murmured, "It is 'too' lovely. I'm sure of one thing—it can't be wrong to love what is beautiful."

He looked at her curiously.

"Barbara and Miss Robins say it is wrong to care about looks—any sort of looks—things or people. They say it is vanity and waste of time."

"But true beauty is Divine."

"Is it?" wistfully. "They say it is a snare."

"Do they? Perhaps they have not eyes to see. True beauty is uplifting; but only when one has power to see its inwardness."

"I'm glad to think it is not wrong," she murmured. "I do love things that are beautiful. Won't you show me something you did yourself when you were abroad?"

"I left all behind me. Nothing worth bringing. Here is one attempt since my return."

He led her to a corner of the studio, where stood in shade a head of bronzed plaster upon a stand.

"Giles!" was her exclamation. "How like! Oh, how like!" She viewed it from different positions. "It is his very self. And how wonderfully you have given the look in his eyes. Only a little hollow for each eye—and yet they are 'his!'"

"Sure proof that character and expression reside more in the surroundings than in the eyes themselves."

"And you did this since you came home?"

"Yes. I'd awfully hard work to get him to sit; but he gave in now and then. When he went north, I had to do my best with photographs. No, I didn't attempt the moulding."

Phyllys' next move was towards the centre modelling-table. She had noticed that he kept clear of that, and her curiosity was roused. "May I see what you are doing now?" she asked.

And after a momentary hesitation, he removed the damp cloths, laying bare a child's head in clay, life-size, nearly completed.

It was a lovable little face, half-sad, yet with a tender shy peace. The luxuriant hair was cut low on the forehead, and fell around in heavy waves; and the effect of dark eyes was admirably given, under drooping lids.

"Who is it?"

"Elsye Wallace. She died many years ago."

"You have done it from memory?"

"Partly from memory. Partly from an oil-painting and some photographs."

"I heard a Dr. Wallace spoken of yesterday."

"He is our medical man. Elsy was his only child."

Phyllis gave her attention to the bust, scanning it from various directions. "I like it!" came at length. "I can't tell you how much I like it. Of course I don't know—I'm no judge—but she seems almost to 'live.' You make me love her, as if I had known the real Elsy. Were you fond of her? Do you mind telling me?"

"Yes; we knew her well."

Phyllis looked up. "You ought to go on," she said earnestly. "You 'will' go on?"

"You are encouraging."

"But you don't want encouraging. You know you can do it."

"Nobody knows it always."

"You won't let anybody make you leave off?" She was thinking of his mother.

"No. I shall not be stopped."

A chair was near, and Phyllys sat down, resting her cheek on one hand, gazing earnestly. A smile broke over her face.

"You little darling!" she murmured.

Colin stood back, his attention diverted from his own work to Phyllys. A longing seized him to make a sketch in clay of that pretty girl-head. His fingers ached to reproduce the soft flow of hair, the delicate moulding of brow and lips. She had the precise pose which he would want; and he hardly dared to breathe for fear of making her move. He was trying to learn every curve by heart, that he might be able to replace her. When, in response to observation, she turned, she caught a gleam of that gaze from under the penthouse of slender fingers.

He at once explained. "I am wondering whether you would let me make a study of your head."

"Mine But why? Yes, if you like. That would be rather fun."

"You promise?"

"I should like it if—Will Mrs. Keith mind?"

"I want an unconditional promise."

Phyllys looked troubled.

"She has always opposed my modelling. I think you will admit that a man must choose for himself?"

"Then it is not a new idea?"

"Nearly as old as I am myself."

Phyllys wondered, recalling contrary assertions.

"I promise," she at length said. "But why should Mrs. Keith care?"

"Can't imagine. Neither can Giles."

He was replacing the wet cloths, and she said, "You won't try to work at that to-day? You know you can't."

He finished what he was doing, then replied, "But when Giles comes home you must please see less. I don't betray myself to him, if I can help it."

"Why should he not know?"

"It bothers him. My stupid headaches are a hindrance to work, and he knows how much I want to get on. So please don't draw his attention. That is all. And—" after a pause—"don't name to him this bust."

"I won't, if you would rather I should not."

"I would rather you should not. Now, shall we go?"

In the hall they were joined by Mrs. Keith, who showed some annoyance on hearing where Phyllis had been.

"I have hunted for you all over the house," she complained.

"Phyllis is going to let me make a model of her head."

Mrs. Keith's movement was of protest. "You won't do anything so ridiculous!"

"I can hardly imagine anything less ridiculous."

"Phyllis has come here to enjoy herself."

"But indeed I shall enjoy that," urged Phyllis. "I love anything to do with modelling."

Mrs. Keith's face darkened. "I would rather it should be given up," she said.

Colin made no verbal reply. The gaze of mother and son met, and Phyllys was conscious of a trial of strength between the two. Mrs. Keith's restless dark orbs stared into the quiet blue eyes, which, with all their courtesy, spoke absolute non-submission. Silence lasted hardly three seconds, but in that space he rose superior.

Phyllys was startled by his look of invincible resolution. Had it been Giles she would have felt no surprise. But Colin—the embodiment rather of charm than of strength—that in him should be found, underlying the charm, a force of will which, though endlessly gentle, would have at all costs its own way, she had not expected.

Mrs. Keith's eyes sank, and she spoke sullenly. "Of course you will do as you choose. 'My' wishes are of no importance."

"Of very great importance; but one has sometimes to follow one's own judgment. Some day I hope you will see with me. Shall I show Phyllys the church this morning?"

"No. She is coming with me."

"Then I will go for a ride—" in unruffled calm; and he vanished.

"A great pity! He will only make himself ill again," said Mrs. Keith. "I have such a dread of another breakdown. He is a dear fellow." She glanced quickly at Phyllys. "But I must have you appreciate Giles also."

The girl smiled—a small subtle smile. She did not count that she was in danger of undervaluing Giles. Already she had told herself that she disapproved of Colin's manner to his mother during those three seconds. To anybody else it would not have mattered; but to his mother! She was sure that Giles would never so have contested in Colin's place. None the less, she liked Colin, and she could not see why Mrs. Keith should so persistently oppose his favourite occupation.

CHAPTER XIII

THE OLD VILLAGE CHURCH

NEXT day, being Sunday, brought to light fresh aspects of the new world in which Phyllys was plunged.

To her the change had come as a veritable plunge, involving such sensations of shock and breathlessness as a dip in the sea will produce. The novelty of it all gripped her imagination. After years of repression, of squeezing in a Procrustean bed, she found herself in an atmosphere of ease and refinement, in a house where beauty was valued, contrasting with the home where only abstract principle was exalted, and things lovely were eschewed as evil. Something of intoxication was the outcome.

Her hour in the studio had awakened new thought, new feeling. The masterpieces shown by Colin had touched her more deeply than might be understood by one possessing no love of art. In Phyllys this love was inherited, and in childhood it had received careful cultivation.

All the ten years at Midfell, though trained to outward submission, she had fought against the dictums which went in the teeth of her parents' teaching. To some extent she had been moulded by persistent pressure, had taken shape and colour, as a plant under training can be educated into new forms. But, like such a plant, she had a strong tendency to "revert" on the first chance; and here was her chance. The spell of present surroundings was great, and she "reverted" quickly to experiences of earlier days, never forgotten, though of late pushed out of her mind.

Colin fascinated her. His personal beauty—a type of beauty due less to outline of feature, though that outline was fine, than to expression—and his "apartness" from common life were both so unlike aught she had ever come

across that she could not dismiss him from her thoughts. And even though she had not quite approved of his manner to his mother, yet his serenity under that mother's resistance to his cherished aim won her admiration.

"I like him," she said to herself more than once. He was different from Giles; and Giles was her friend. Colin might in time become her friend; but this she doubted. She could not get to know him so quickly as she had got to know Giles.

As they walked to church on Sunday morning following the private short-cut, where sunbeams made a swaying pattern of leaf-shadows on a mossy carpet, her attention wandered to him much. She listened for what he might say; she watched for what he might do. Each word and action on his part, though subdued, had in it something suggestive. Giles had not affected her thus. When with Giles she was mainly conscious of her own power over him. When with Colin she was mainly conscious of his power over her.

Midfell Church and its services were plain, almost with an excess of simplicity; less from any wish on the part of Mr. Hazel than from a need to avoid startling the unsophisticated Midfell intellect by "innovations," a word which held terror for the Wyvernes and their coterie. Had such simplicity not been maintained, Phyllys would not have been allowed to enter the porch.

Here things were otherwise, and she was carried back to childhood's days—to her father's church. Here was precisely what old Mrs. Wyverne had dreaded for her grandchild, and had condemned in her son. Not only an aged historic building, great in architectural beauty; but also more of completeness, more of cultivated perfection of form and sound, more of that which for years had been decried in the hearing of Phyllys as unsound, unspiritual, a form of godliness without life, perilous to true religion.

Did it indeed mean peril? Was it perforce mere form, without life? Did no reality underlie the beauty of structure and of sound?

Beauty there was; a perfection of rendering seldom reached in a country village; a well-trained choir; an organ of mellow tone, finely handled. There was, too, the outward seeming of deep reverence, in hushed

stillness, in heads bowed reverently during prayers, in low voices joining in the responses. No hurried slurring on the part of Vicar or congregation, no shrill shouting on the part of the choir. All was controlled and appropriate, a worthy expression of the Church's adoration of her Divine Master. The Vicar, a college friend of Giles Randolph, seemed to be a man of unusual intensity of feeling, if the bent head and earnest face spoke truly.

Who would venture to say that in the plain services of Midfell Church, love and devotion and reverence were less than here, though differently shown? But also, who should dare to assert that love and devotion and reverence here were less, because allowed fuller expression? Only, surely, a Barbara Wyverne or one like-minded would roughly thus tread on holy ground, would carelessly so condemn. The Father of all, looking into each heart, reads and values at their true worth the love, the devotion, the reverence, whether uttered in this manner or expressed in that manner before His footstool.

To Phyllys, the surroundings, the spiritual atmosphere, the solemn hush, the stirring music, appealing to her impressionable nature, meant joy and comfort and a new realization of the Divine Presence. That Presence is made known to men through many different channels and by various modes. For years Phyllys had not felt her father and mother so near, because for years she had not felt God so near. Their nearness was involved in His; for they were in Him, with Him. Tears filled her eyes as she knelt. She knew that this Church might be to her as a gate of heaven.

Her late terrible experience on the moor had deepened the sense of spiritual need, and here might be what would satisfy that need. "O I am glad to have come," she whispered.

Presently, standing up, she noted Mrs. Keith's manner as peculiar. Those fine eyes, troubled and restless, were gazing at the east window, as if in protest, and the lips moved beseechingly.

Did this mean prayer? Something had stirred the elder woman, as she had been stirred; only in Mrs. Keith it looked like sorrow, not joy. But what could Mrs. Keith have to grieve her, in her beautiful home, with the most

winning of sons, with Giles as a second son ready to give all she wished?—Except indeed in so insignificant a desire as related to Colin's modelling.

Phyllys floated into a train of thought, which landed her beside a chestnut-tinted stream, with golden glimmers in white wavelets, and Giles by her side. Thence by a transition she was in the bog, sinking, horror-stricken, in black slime, and once more she felt the grip of his hand. "But for him—!" she whispered.

Twenty minutes later she and Mrs. Keith stood in the empty church, Colin having gone home.

Architecture claimed attention, and Mrs. Keith pointed out the Norman arches, the solid columns, the stalls and their carved canopies, the aged rood-screen, the new seats of dark oak throughout the building.

"Giles had it restored as soon as he came of age," she said. "It was his first thought. Before that we had a three-decker, and hideous galleries, and pews one could hardly see over, and whitewash everywhere. He had the roof opened out as you see it now, and everything put right. His whole heart was in the work. No, there is very little old glass. The east window had been added early in the century, and it was too frightful for words. So Giles gave this and one other. Lovely, is it not?"

They passed to the "one other" in the north aisle; a memorial window, exquisite in design, the central figure that of a child borne up on angels' wings. The child's face drew from Phyllys an exclamation.

Mrs. Keith made a sound of inquiry, but Phyllys drew in. It might be that Colin would not wish his mother, any more than Giles, to know what he was doing. She went near, and read, "In Memory of E. W."

"Dr. Wallace's child. She died when the boys were sixteen. An occasional playmate." Mrs. Keith spoke coldly.

"And she was—how old?"

"About thirteen. When the church was restored, Giles put this to her memory. Unnecessarily, I thought."

"She must have been lovely. Was Giles fond of her?"

"She was pretty. Both boys liked her. She died very suddenly."

"And her father is your doctor?"

"He is everybody's doctor. I do not care for him. I am afraid my dislikes are as pronounced as my likes."

"So many years ago?" thought Phyllys. And an "occasional playmate" only! Both Giles and Colin must be very unforgetting. She decided that a friendship with the former might last a lifetime.

CHAPTER XIV

SCULPTOR AND SITTER

FOR two hours daily did Colin lay claim upon Phyllys, and she granted what he asked, albeit not easily. Mrs. Keith had ceased from protestation, but many obstacles were put in the way, though in a fashion hardly to be defined.

Phyllys found her first morning in the studio enchanting. Colin was at his best, ready for talk and quietly gay. She had begged to watch the process from the beginning; and she gazed with delight at his deft handling of the clay, as he filled in and covered over the light framework of lead piping, shaped roughly the shoulders over cross-pieces of wood designed for their support, and added lumps which with firm touches he formed into nose, chin, ears, giving each in turn a general resemblance to her own. It seemed

that his task would be a bagatelle, he advanced so fast. When she said so, he broke into a laugh.

"This is preparation, not work. If you had not asked to come, it would have been done before I troubled you."

He went to and fro between the large and small room, bringing handfuls of the moist clay, remarking once, "A great sculptor would have a boy to keep him supplied."

"You will be a great sculptor some day," she declared confidently.

The opinion had no weight, yet he smiled. He was in a frame to be easily pleased. For one thing the sun shone; for another, he was free from headache; for a third, he felt that his sitter would bring inspiration. With all his outward placidity, Colin was an artist in temperament; a weather barometer; a creature of moods.

"Do all sculptors work as fast as you?"

"There are different modes. Not only one excellent way. Some do it slowly, adding pellets, not lumps. Each has to follow the method by which he can produce the best results. The broader and quicker method suits me."

"You seem to build it up," she murmured.

"That is the essence of clay-modelling. It is a literal building up. In marble sculpture one has the reverse—carving away material, and leaving the figure exposed."

"You mean it was there all the time, shut up in prison, and it had to be set free," she suggested, with a happy little laugh.

That brought his eyes upon her. "Precisely. But only a sculptor can see it there, before he cuts away the mass that hides it."

Colin had made a rough clay sketch of Phyllys in the attitude which first attracted him, and this rendered it easy to place her anew in the same position. She had to gaze at a bust, and could no longer watch his

manipulations: so time passed slowly. A quarter of an hour seemed like a full hour; and to maintain the position was difficult. She tried to find entertainment in chatting about Midfell, but his murmurs of assent acted as a check, and she sank into silence, which soon meant an expression utterly "dead."

He had to arouse himself that he might arouse her.

This day all went well, and he proved merciful, allowing frequent rests.

In days following the work advanced more slowly; nay, even stood still. He could not satisfy himself.

He would stand, doing nothing, gazing at his sitter, with an air of calm aloofness, as if trying to read her soul. The aloofness prevented self-consciousness. Sometimes she wondered what it was that he saw or wished to see. Sometimes she had a sense that he saw deeper than other men—than Giles, for example. But all the while she recognised that she was his "sitter" pure and simple. He was studying a model for artistic purposes. He was not troubling himself to know Phyllis Wyverne for her own sake.

Then, when fifty minutes of endurance were ended, he would move, would hope she was not tired, would offer her the armchair, would ask whether she minded a cigarette, would change in a moment from the artist to the host. She found in him a dual nature; not like that of Giles, simple, homogeneous, the same throughout. One hour he was sculptor; another hour he was man.

Perhaps she admired him more as sculptor, and liked him more as man; but the combination had power.

By the fifth day things were going ill. Colin was not pleased with his work. He foresaw that this bust would be less of a success than that of Elsie Wallace; and the harder he toiled, the less he got on. He was gaining a worn look, his features becoming sharply drawn. Phyllis longed to advise a day's holiday, but did not venture.

A rap at the door made him lift troubled eyes, and a box was brought in from the moulder, containing, as he knew, the cast of Elsy.

"Put it down," he murmured, and bent anew to his modelling. It was characteristic that he should bestow his whole energy on the task in hand, and should have no thought to spare for that last completed. But presently, finding his sitter hopelessly "flat," he suggested an adjournment, and took out the cast.

"It's lovely," Phyllys said. "Are you not glad? Don't you feel proud?" She stretched her arms and sat down, while Colin threw himself into the armchair. "Isn't it perfect?"

"I don't know."

"Ought you to do any more to-day?"

There was a brief laugh. "Certainly I ought—if I can. That's the question."

"It seems getting on so nicely," she ventured.

"It's a dead failure," he replied shortly.

"I suppose people don't know their own faces. It seems to me all right."

"It's not you! I can't get at yourself."

Phyllys smiled, not ill-pleased. "But you don't expect to put my real self straight off into a lump of clay?"

"If not, I'm no sculptor."

Phyllys' next remark was commonplace. "You've got my nose and mouth all right."

He laughed again. "If that were all! The veriest tyro could do so much. An artist aims higher."

Her eyes questioned him.

"True Art means more than a copy," he murmured. "It means interpretation; not copying. There's a lack of soul in what I have done. You have an elusive personality. I can't get at your true inwardness. Yet I'm not usually a duffer at character-reading."

"That reminds me—" and Phyllys spoke eagerly—"I wanted to ask you, what did you mean one day by the 'inwardness' of beauty? Do you remember?"

She had to recall to him what had passed.

"I meant the 'soul' of it. There is a soul to every outward form of beauty."

"I don't think I understand."

He roused himself to explain. "In Art each body has a soul. That is to say—in Nature, with which Art deals, which Art interprets. One has to get at that soul, before interpretation is possible. A superficial resemblance is nothing. Every thought of man may find outward expression, in word or in shape; and the outward expression is the body; the thought from which it sprang is the soul. Every thought of God may—perhaps must—find expression in word or in form; and there again, that which is manifest is the body, but the Divine underlying thought is the 'soul' of that which is manifested. If once you realise this, I don't think you will be in danger of undervaluing beauty."

"I don't think I am," she said. Then, smiling—"I'm glad it isn't easy to know me at first sight."

"Much of you is easy; but you have many facets. When I think I have reached the true Phyllys, I find myself mistaken. One day you are one thing, next day another. My aim is to get to the background."

"I wonder how you mean to do it," she laughed.

She had recalled him to his purpose. He leant forward, examining her with a penetrative gaze. She met it firmly, determined on resistance. She would be as elusive as she chose.

But those blue eyes had power. They differed from Giles' eyes; and they were reaching deep. If this was a trial of strength, she knew that he was gaining the mastery. She could not veil from him what he meant to see. Despite her will-refusal, he was getting into touch with her "inward" self. He was stronger than she. She knew it and resented the fact, yet was oddly glad.



"A HARSH VOICE BROKE THE PAUSE. 'SO—USING PHYLLYS FOR A MODEL.'"

**A HARSH VOICE BROKE THE PAUSE, "SO—USING PHYLLYS
FOR A MODEL."**

An abrupt consciousness dawned that this meant more than artistic interest. The indifference, the "apartness" had vanished. Her eyes fell before his.

Colin had never seen her thus, though he had for days analysed every line in her face.

This was no matter of lines; and though as sculptor, he thought less of colouring than of form, yet the pretty flush, the troubled curve of coral lips, the sweetness of downcast eyes, laid hold upon him. If she was a being of many facets, he was the same, and a facet of hers touched squarely a facet of his that moment.

"I have come upon the real Phyllys at last," he was saying; and his joy was only in part artistic.

Phyllys said nothing. She knew that he was reading her still; and she could not meet his gaze.

A harsh voice broke the pause. "So—using Phyllys for a model! How is that, pray?"

Phyllys looked up in amaze. This—Giles? This—her Midfell friend, her rescuer!

He went across to shake hands with her, absently, as if the act were mechanical; then stood between them, facing the fireplace, his back to the long room; tall, solid, upright. His hands were clenched, and the blaze of yellow light on his eyes was like that of a wild beast. Wrath transformed the whole face. Its deep red was exchanged for a mottled pallor.

Phyllys stiffened into girlish dignity. If Giles felt no pleasure at seeing her, she would show no pleasure at seeing him; and what could make him behave in such an extraordinary way?

Colin's first movement had been a start, but he replied in his lowest, most dragging voice—

"Yes; I'm making a study of her head. Not a successful one, I'm afraid. You didn't let us know you were coming to-day."

Giles turned from the speaker with a passionate movement, towards the bust of Elsy Wallace.

Phyllis recalled Colin's not wishing her to know of its existence; and she wondered—had he seen it on his first entrance?

But no! This evidently was his first glimpse; and the surprise was not a pleasant one. He stood gazing, his hands still clenched, his face set as in iron.

"That was not to have been seen," observed Colin.

The words, meant in explanation, put a finish to Giles' anger. He swung round, and strode blindly away, knocking against the heavy modelling-stand with such force that the bust of Phyllis was hurled to the ground. But he made no pause, and his step could be heard retreating along the passage.

Colin sat down, resting his brow on both hands.

"What an awful dunder I am!" he murmured.

"But nobody knew Giles was coming," ventured Phyllis.

"One might have expected it."

"I don't see why he is vexed."

Silence replied. She knew that, whatever there was to learn, she would not hear it from Colin.

"You won't work any more now, will you?"

"I don't think I can."

Another break.

"Had I better go? Mrs. Keith said she would want me."

He stood up to open the door, relieved, she thought, at the suggestion. Outside, remembering that she had left a book, she went back, to find Colin flung prone on the sofa. The bust still lay where it had fallen.

"Couldn't I get anything for you?" she asked. "Your head is bad!"

"Rather! No, nothing I want, thanks. Is that your book? I'll have a lazy hour."

Phyllis went again, feeling flat. This was not the manner of meeting with Giles that she had pictured. She was disappointed by his indifference; and his display of temper left an unpleasant impression. Could it be that he objected to Colin making a model of her head? But that would be childish! Why should he mind?

CHAPTER XV

AN INADVERTENT DISCOVERY

IT was one of those links in the chain of life, which present themselves unsought, which at the moment seem unimportant; yet which have a grave bearing upon one's after happiness.

Phyllis had no thought of making any discovery; indeed, she did not recognise it as such. Her mind was bent upon the disappointing nature of human friendships; though she did not use such phraseology, but only said

to herself that things were "horrid." She was perplexed and uncomfortable; wondering what could have so upset Giles; wishing he would behave like his former self.

Little had been seen of him since his arrival. At luncheon he was sombre, and Phyllys treated him with dignity. Colin looked ill, ate nothing, and talked like a machine wound up; and since luncheon he too had been invisible.

Between five and six o'clock Phyllys was alone with Mrs. Keith. Rain fell heavily, keeping them in, and keeping callers away. Mrs. Keith knew nothing of the studio scene; but she had noted with dismay Phyllys' bearing at luncheon, towards both Giles and Colin, and she used this opportunity to descant on dear Giles' fine character, the beautiful devotion between him and Colin, and the manner in which, years earlier, he had been wont to deny himself amusement that he might spend hours beside Colin in a darkened room, making time pass for the invalid.

"If you had any idea how Colin used to suffer, you really wouldn't wonder at my anxiety," she observed. "For days together he could hardly endure a glimmer of light. One dreads what might bring that back. And Colin never can do anything without working himself into a state of excitement."

She reverted to the merits of Giles.

"There is something about him so grand, so unlike the common run of men. He has such control over himself. Colin is a dear fellow too; still, his is the smaller and weaker nature."

"I shouldn't have thought so; he seems to me anything but weak."

"That may be hardly the right word; and if he is small, it is only by comparison with Giles. Almost any man seems dwarfed beside him. Yes, even my own boy. Is that odd? Why should love be blind? I do not see Colin's faults the less, because he is dear to me. As for Giles' faults, really I find it hard to say what they are, except a hot temper, conquered long ago."

Phyllys was silent. Morning recollections supplied a commentary.

"Dear fellow, he is so unselfish," went on Mrs. Keith. "So wonderfully kind. Giles' wife, by-and-by, will be the happiest of women. As for Colin's wife, it is to be hoped that she will not mind his moods and trying ways."

But if Mrs. Keith wished to turn Phyllys from Colin to Giles, she went to work in a wrong fashion. Talk presently branched to Kathleen Alyn and her father, and Phyllys felt this to be a safer topic. She was learning caution.

"Kathleen is a fascinating woman," averred Mrs. Keith, beginning to outline an elaborate pattern upon a square of silk. "Everybody likes her. Mr. Dugdale can be disagreeable when he chooses."

"I should think most people could." Phyllys liked Mr. Dugdale.

"Tiresome!" muttered Mrs. Keith. "This silk will not do. I must get the other piece."

"What piece? Can I find it?"

Mrs. Keith raised absent eyes. She was thinking what a pretty tractable wife Phyllys might make for Giles. For reasons of her own, unknown to other people, she had set her heart on this consummation.

"Thanks very much, if it will not be a trouble. I don't want to disarrange these things by moving. It is a square of crimson silk, and you will see it on the shelf, just inside one of my black oak cabinets. There are two in my room, you know. The one that is unlocked, on the right side as you go in."

Phyllys ran upstairs, thinking still of Giles, and suddenly found herself face to face with him. He looked so solemn that she could not resist a smile, and his face relaxed.

"I have seen nothing of you yet," he observed. "But to-morrow—"

"Are you going out now?"

"I am obliged, unfortunately. But, if I might count on you in the morning for a walk—would you come? We have no fells or mountain streams; still, you shall see something pretty."

Phyllis demurred, for she had hitherto devoted the better part of her mornings to the studio. It would not do, however, to be at the beck and call of Colin. Her proud spirit rose in protest, all the more because she had felt his power.

"I should like a walk," she said demurely; and Giles' face, growing rigid under her hesitation, lighted anew. She could not but see the change.

"Then I may reckon on you," he said, and his look was eloquent.

Friends still! That was what it uttered.

She gave one slight flash, and ran off. With regard to him, as with regard to Colin, questioning arose. Was it with the one only artist-interest? Was it with the other only friendship?

Phyllis made no attempt to find a reply. She knew that it was delightful, after years of snubbing, to find herself the object of so much attention.

Reaching Mrs. Keith's bedroom, her recollections were confused. A black oak cabinet, unlocked—so much remained. Turning to the left, she pulled the door of the cabinet on that side, and it opened. Within she saw no crimson silk. A pile of shawls and cloaks had been heaped together in the space below; and she disturbed the pile, pulling it out, searching for the silk. So doing, she came on something behind; a half-length portrait in a black frame. A pair of blue eyes, dreamy, observant, met her own. "How like!" she exclaimed.

The style of dress belonged to a bygone period, and the face as a whole was hardly that of Colin. It was a resemblance less of form and colour than of the spirit which gleamed through.

"Some near relation," she conjectured. "But why keep it hidden here?"

Convinced that the silk was not within the cabinet, she restored the portrait, piled the clothes as before, and tried to shut the door.

Then she saw that it had been locked, and that the hasp had failed to catch. No key was visible. She recollected Mrs. Keith's words, "On the 'right' side as you go in." This cabinet stood on the left.

She went to the second cabinet, found that to be genuinely unlocked, and saw the crimson silk. She caught it up and ran downstairs.

"I'm sorry to have been so long," she said. "I opened the wrong cabinet by mistake. Somebody had locked it in a hurry, and had not shut it first. I forgot all about right and left, and wasted time hunting. I could not help noticing the oil-painting under the things. It has such a look of Colin. A young man, in a queer old-fashioned dress. I wondered whether it might be Colin's grandfather, and whether he was dressed for theatricals." She stopped; for Mrs. Keith's face had grown colourless.

"Are you faint?" she asked. "May I get anything for you?"

"Thanks, no; it is nothing. I shall be all right. So stupid of me!" And Mrs. Keith smiled. "I have had three or four such turns lately. I shall have to ask Dr. Wallace for a tonic; only I do so dislike the man. Well—" and she pressed her handkerchief to her lips—"now I am better. What were you saying, just before the faintness came on? Something about—how absurd of me to forget! My head is confused."

"Only about that old painting in your cabinet. I thought it must be some relative, because of the likeness to Colin," She would not suggest Mrs. Keith's husband, though the idea had occurred. A wife would hardly bury her husband's portrait beneath a pile of old clothes.

"Ah, to be sure—yes!—I remember. An old painting of my brother Jock—Colin's uncle. Not so old, of course, as it looks. The artist had a fancy to do it in that style. You are right about the dress. It was for theatricals. He was good at acting—very much in request. You found the silk?"

Phyllys gave it, remarking, "I had not heard of your brother."

"Really! But you would not. Jock has been so long in Australia, never coming home, that friends forget his existence."

"Had you not better rest?" asked the girl, pitying her blanched lips.

"It really is of no consequence. I am used to these turns, and I think nothing of them. One word, before any one comes. Phyllys, I am going to treat you as a friend."

Phyllys waited, and Mrs. Keith's lips worked nervously.

"That old portrait—no one except myself knows about it, and I 'particularly' wish that others should not know. There are reasons which I am not able to explain. It has—painful associations. The very sight of it makes me miserable for days."

"But Colin—" the girl said.

"Colin has no idea of its existence."

"Of course I will say nothing."

"That is what I was going to ask. If you had kept to my directions you would not have opened the wrong cabinet. Under the circumstances, I have a right to ask you never to mention the portrait. It would mean no end of talk and explanation—and pain to myself, which really I cannot stand. Will you give me your promise, on your word of honour?"

It seemed to Phyllys a considerable fuss about nothing; but she readily made answer, "Yes, of course. I promise never to say a word to anybody about the painting unless you give me leave. I'm sorry I went to the wrong cabinet."

"That does not matter, my dear. All I wish is to avoid tiresome and useless discussions. But I know I may depend upon you, and now we can dismiss the subject. I think I must have some sal volatile after all—I feel so

queer still. Thanks, no—I had better go myself. It will do me good to move."

She mounted the wide staircase, stepping languidly till within her own room. Then her manner changed. She bolted the door, and went to the left-hand cabinet, finding it as described by Phyllys.

"How insane of me!" she muttered. She began to pile more clothes over the picture, but stopped.

"No; now it has been seen, it must not stay there."

Her eyes wandered round questfully, and she went to a large cupboard, within which was a heavy wooden box. This with difficulty she drew out. It contained several summer gowns of thin materials, too old-fashioned for use. She had a weakness for storing away disused articles of dress.

In the bottom she laid the portrait, face downward, finding just sufficient space. Over it she spread a woollen shawl; over that the gowns neatly folded; then she shut the lid, turned the key, and pushed the box to its former position.

Somebody was tapping at the door. She straightened herself, hid away the box-key in an inner drawer of her writing-table, locked the left-hand cabinet, and resumed her languid air before admitting Phyllys.

"Can't I help you?" asked the girl, with astonished eyes. "I came to see if you wanted anything—and I heard you pulling something heavy about."

"I had to look for a business letter. Nothing of importance; but it was rather out of reach. Thanks, no; I do not want anything. I am much better—quite myself again."

Phyllys was perplexed, remembering the energetic sounds which had drowned her raps.

CHAPTER XVI

LEVEL PLAINS

KATHLEEN ALYN, though not given to fancies, had taken a fancy to Phyllys. She had a large circle of acquaintances, but did not make friends.

Not that hers was a cold nature. On the contrary, she was famed for universal cordiality. Any human being who came was secure of a welcome. "Dear Mrs. Alyn is so sweetly affectionate," her lady admirers declared. "Kathleen is always interested," her father often said.

She would appear to each in turn, as if that person were the one being in the world for whom she cared; no whit the less one hour with Mrs. Brown, than the next with Mrs. Green. "Such a 'dear' woman!" would be said by the departing caller.

Some, of more critical tendency, noting the universality of her friendliness, questioned its worth, since that which is given to all loses its value for the few. Yet even they could not but admire the self-mastery which showed equal warmth to the acquaintance of to-day and the friend of years.

Only—as above said—she did not make friends. That discovery came next; and a step farther would convince the observer that Mrs. Alyn had no heart.

Had she not? Kathleen could be as "elusive" to the world as Phyllys to the sculptor.

"My daughter is one of the most fascinating women that ever trod this earth," Mr. Dugdale had been known to observe. "None the less, she is a humbug. A delightful humbug, I grant. She has cultivated the giving of sympathy, till she has reduced it to a fine art; and that which is Art ceases to

be Nature. She has developed into a patent machine, warranted to produce so many gallons of sympathy per hour. Nothing can be more satisfactory—for those who are content with sympathy by the gallon!"

Despite this judgment, which he would have been the first to repudiate from any lips but his own, he went to her as often as he wished for an agreeable listener, which was not seldom.

Towards Phyllis she was disposed from the first to show an interest differing in kind from that paid out by the gallon. Phyllis had her faults, but she was true and dependable; and perhaps it was mainly this, combined with originality and charm, that appealed to the young widow, who gave much and received little, and who was at heart lonely, despite her popularity.

For if Kathleen were a humbug, she was so unknowingly; and beneath a stratum of unreality lay a heart which had loved and could love, though few came into touch with it.

She was feeling her loneliness the morning after Giles' return, not knowing of that return; and she sent her small boy, Gordon, to Castle Hill with a message, "Would Phyllis come to luncheon and spend the afternoon with her?"

Gordon arrived in time to hear that Phyllis had started with Giles some time before. He was a young man with independent views for his limited age, and he promptly resolved to follow them up, breathing no hint of his intentions, since he would certainly be forbidden. Having in a casual fashion asked the walkers' direction, he strolled out of sight, presumably on his way home, and then started at a trot.

But his legs were very short, and the chase proved a long one.

No question had arisen that morning as to studio-work, for Colin had not appeared. "One of his worst headaches," explained Mrs. Keith. "His own fault entirely, poor boy! If only he would have the sense not to be always at that ridiculous modelling!"

Phyllis fired up in his defence, with a promptitude which for once rendered Mrs. Keith dumb. Giles' face had darkened at the news of Colin's state; and he now looked at her strangely. She was soon ashamed of her little outburst.

What most vexed her was the calling of Colin "poor." Whether she liked him or Giles the more she could not decide; but no question existed about her admiration for Colin, whom she regarded as one gifted beyond the common run.

No more was said, and the walk came as a matter of course. It was a perfect morning, and she might have congratulated herself on being in the open air, instead of having to sit for two hours like a waxen image—only such congratulation seemed unkind to Colin. She felt it to be hard that whatever he set himself to do should be hampered by ill-health, and opposed by the one individual of whose sympathy he ought to have been sure. Giles had everything—good health, vigour of mind and body, wealth, position, and the favour of Colin's mother. And yet—Phyllis felt that, had the choice been offered to her whether to possess Giles' many gifts or Colin's one gift, she would have had no hesitation in choosing the latter.

"Anybody may be strong and rich," she thought. "But to have genius!—that is best of all—that is above everything." In her girlish judgment no doubt existed that Colin's power held the Divine spark which means so very much more than mere talent.

Presently she woke to her own abstraction, and consequent silence. A side-glance revealed the gravity of her companion's look. Their eyes met, and he said—

"You are thoughtful to-day."

She would not let slip her thoughts. He and she were friends; but she had her reservations. Who has not, with the dearest of friends? Two days earlier she might have chatted frankly of Colin and his pursuit; but now she was not able. She could not forget the experience of the day before, and Giles' anger. The latter had made her afraid of a false step; and she was still

more afraid of awakening in herself renewed sensations of consciousness. It was safer to keep to the surface.

So she launched into light chatter about Castle Hill and Midfell; making little jests, laughing, and doing her best to make him laugh.

For the moment she succeeded. Her winsome ways captivated him anew; and his very silence, the reluctance of his smile, his absorption in what she said, all drew her out, making it easy to pour out her thoughts.

Yet she was keenly alive to the contrast between this morning and previous mornings. Being with Giles after being with Colin was like walking on a level plain after climbing a mountain peak. The simplicity, the whole-heartedness, were refreshing; but she found herself longing for the mountain-heights.

The two men were different in mind as in body. With Colin she had a sense of inferiority; a consciousness of being pulled to a higher level. She was fascinated, and afraid; not sure how far she understood; eager to understand more; delighted when he responded; ready at any moment to fall flat, if he treated a remark with indifference.

With Giles she had no especial sense of inferiority, unless in respect of muscles. She was aware of her power over him, aware that she could make him like her—perhaps as much as she willed. She knew she could touch his happiness: and she was dimly conscious now that something connected with herself made him unhappy.

Once, Giles had had the feeling that he could do what he chose with Phyllis. That had been a momentary sensation, true, but fleeting. In the studio, on his entrance, he had known that "Colin" could do what he willed with Phyllis; and the mad pain and wrath which carried him away would have opened his eyes, had they not been opened already, to the nature of his love.

To-day it was Phyllis who felt that she could do what she desired with Giles; that she could twist this powerful man, if she would, round her slim little finger.

The sense of command was delicious, as it generally is. And yet! When a vision arose of the studio, and of Colin's delicate absorbed face, with penetrative eyes searching her soul, she knew she would rather be there than here, even though she had no such sense of control over him, and could no more twist him round her finger than she could turn aside the winds of heaven in their paths.

Not that she preferred Colin to Giles. Giles was her friend. Colin had not even sought her friendship. But to some natures there is an even greater charm in the sense of being controlled by the personality of another, than in having control over another. And Colin attracted her. She wanted to watch him again at his work, to study his curiously dual nature, to learn from his murmured suggestions, to grasp his ideals, to breathe the mental and spiritual atmosphere which he breathed. Giles awoke in her no such cravings. She was not sure that he would understand what they meant.

Phyllis pulled herself up. This was heterodox. She remembered all that Giles had done; not only saving her life at risk to his own, which probably any man passing would have tried to do; but in cousinly kindness, day after day. She was forgetting anew to talk to him. Pretty apologetic eyes went in his direction.

"I am afraid you are tired," he said.

"I! I'm never tired!" she declared.

"We are there now, and you will be able to rest," he said, with a smile of melancholy.

He had promised "something pretty," and he kept his word. The spot to which he led her was beside a river, broad and swift; not chestnut-hued or broken by stones with swirls of white foam and gleams of golden light; yet a most fair scene, after a more ordinary type. An arched stone bridge spanned the stream; cows clustered under its shadow; and on the other side flags grew in abundance. On their own side of the water, which faithfully reflected the tint of heaven, a clump of willows sparkled in sunshine.

This was what Giles had pictured beforehand; and Phyllis exclaimed in admiration. He found her a seat, and she sank into silence, forgetting to talk, her cheek supported on one ungloved hand, her lashes dropped till they half-veiled her eyes.

It was the attitude which had inspired Colin's artistic sense. It inspired another sense in Giles.

He could not turn his gaze from her. Not that he was seeking, like Colin, to penetrate her soul. He was only enchained, taken captive, at her mercy. He was not analysing his own feelings. He was not good at self-analysing, and words never flowed with him, even in the secret chambers of his mind. But without words, without verbal definition, he realised to the tips of his fingers that to have Phyllis thus was happiness; that to have her always would be heaven. And then with a throb of pain, he realised that not to have her, never to possess her, would be—

He dared not face that possibility. It was enough to unman him. Cold drops broke out.

What was she musing about, as she sat there, sweet as a rosebud, not dreaming the passion of longing which shook the strong man at her side? She was not occupied with him. Yet his gaze drew her attention, and she looked up, with a sigh of pleasure.

"People who don't love beautiful things must lose a great deal of happiness."

Giles thought so too, feasting his eyes on a beauty which was not of inanimate Nature.

"Colin says beauty is Divine," she murmured; and the words gave him a shock. Though taken less by surprise than on the day before, he felt a flame of wrath through his frame.

He thought he had known before! Now he knew that he had only conjectured. It "was" then—Colin! Colin had stolen her from him. Colin—

his more than brother! A wave of resentment rushed into the affection which had bound those two since infancy.

"Don't you think so?" she asked, turning towards him.

The smile died out. He could not control his face, and what she saw startled her.

"Are you vexed with anything I have said?"

"Never!" He strove to clear the thickness from his voice. "I never could be vexed with you. It is—only—" He had difficulty in speaking, and she looked with perplexed eyes. "Only—a passing thought—a recollection. If I was vexed, it was with somebody else—not you!" Then he mastered himself. "You were saying something about beauty being Divine. Colin's idea, was it not?"

"But you did not like that, so we can talk of something else," she said, with a touch of reserve which wounded him to the quick.

"I should like you to explain."

"Colin could explain better. You should ask him. Why—there is Gordon!" she cried. "Here we are, Gordon! Come along."

Gordon marched composedly up, with failing legs and his most aggressive six-foot air.

"I say, you have brought me an awful long way," he declared. "Mother says Phyllis has got to come to lunch with her to-day."

"Of course I will, and if we start directly, we shall be in time." She jumped up, almost too eagerly.

The sense of relief was patent, and it meant a fresh stab for Giles. He walked to the water's edge, to recover himself.

Gordon surveyed his broad back, then turned to Phyllis.

"I say—have a bite?" He extended benignly a red-cheeked apple, dented on one side.

"No, thanks. What made you come all this way, Gordon?"

"Mother wanted you. Course I came," said Gordon.

CHAPTER XVII

DUTY VERSUS DESIRE

GILES had not meant to ask Phyllys for that walk.

After the studio scene, he had felt that his duty was to wait, until he should know which way lay Colin's intentions. But when he met Phyllys on the stairs, when he read pleasure in her smile, his resolution melted like ice in sunshine, and the request slipped out.

Though he realised what his action meant, he did not draw back.

The evening passed unremarkably. Mr. Dugdale and his daughter came to dinner; Colin could not appear, and the conversation was general. Giles made futile efforts to hold aloof from Phyllys, and only succeeded in seeing nobody else.

Through the night following he had no sleep. Two wakeful hours he spent in bed; then he got up and dressed, and let himself out of the house to walk fast and far in moonlight, fighting a tough battle.

He had to come to a decision. The earlier intention held now no force; and its failure only served to show more truly how things stood.

On arrival he had made his way into the studio, as was his wont, expecting to find Colin absorbed in his beloved occupation, caring for naught else, wrapped up in the effort to reproduce in clay some form of beauty. He had been told that Mrs. Keith was out; he had taken for granted that Phyllys was with her. And when he stood within the studio door it was to see—not Colin only, but Phyllys also; the two seated together; Phyllys with downcast eyes and soft flush, and a look upon the sweet face which "he" had never been able to evoke; while Colin's gaze, and the light in those blue eyes, told the worst!

At the instant Giles' one sensation had been of furious wrath against Colin for daring to interfere with "his" love—wrath that he would have felt towards any man. Already in his secret soul he looked upon Phyllys as his own.

But, in the silence of his room before luncheon, far more in the dimness of the moonlit lanes at night, other counsels succeeded. Other elements would not be defined. It was no simple matter of two men, both in love with one girl, waiting to see which she might prefer. The question really was—if Colin had set his heart on Phyllys, ought Giles to seek her at all? Ought he not at once to give up the thought?

As an abstract question this carried no difficulty. To his mind the duty was plain. If Colin loved Phyllys, the right step for him was to leave the coast clear.

Years earlier, under peculiar circumstances, he had made a definite resolve never to stand in the way of Colin's happiness; never to allow himself any good which might react in the form of pain for Colin. He had registered this vow in the recesses of his heart. It rose up and faced him, while he hurried through lonely lanes, unable to see his way. Cold moonlight, flooding fields on either side, seemed alive with one word, "Remember!" Black tree-shadows, lying in patches at his feet, echoed "Remember!" The creak of an elm-bough, swayed by the breeze, groaned "Remember!" The cry of an owl sounded the same solemn "Remember!"

He did remember. He would never forget the heartbreaking misery, the awful load of woe, which had culminated in that resolve. If life should last a hundred years, each incident of those days would remain vivid to the last.

That he should ever in years to come, under any provocation, be betrayed into wrath with Colin, had seemed to lie beyond possibility. And until the day just ended he had not only shown no anger, but had never been tempted to show it, towards Colin. He had found it easy to preserve his self-control.

Now the testing-time had come. Now, in one moment, his resolve had broken down. He had under stress given way to violent anger; and he found

that past resolution opposed by the full force of his will.

He was free to draw back. He had not yet avowedly sought Phyllys. Thus far he had been, to the best of his knowledge, no more than cousin and friend. Whatever he had felt at Midfell, he had not shown it. He would do "her" no wrong by retiring, by giving to Colin the first innings. He would wrong no one but himself. And, in the light of his past, he knew it was right—a matter of simple justice—that he of all men should refuse to stand between Colin and happiness. The question was not "Ought he?" but "Could he?"

As he walked he made up his mind that he would do the thing that was right; that he would carry out his early resolution; that he would endure the cost.

Thus, during hours of moonlight, followed by darkness. But in the chill light of dawn, as he tramped wearily to his room, tired, not with bodily exertion but with mental strain, another spirit took possession.

Ho had meant to get off his walk with Phyllys. Better for him, safer and wiser, not to go. Yet, when it came to the point, he made no effort. He let things drift. He had the walk.

Then, for yielding, he was the weaker, as for yielding, one can hardly fail to be. A paralysis seemed to lay hold upon him, though his had always been reckoned a manly will. And when he sat by her side, on the river-bank, he knew that, even for Colin's sake, he could not give her up. He could not! There was a limit to what might be expected of a man; and this reached beyond the limit.

In so short a space she had grown to be everything to him; to be his love, his life. One month before she was but a name—Phyllys Wyverne, younger grand-daughter of his old great-aunt, living in the wilds of Yorkshire. He was vaguely interested in her, and he supposed that one day they might meet again: but whether he saw her or not was of no particular moment. Then they met; and his life was changed. Now nothing in the world was of moment except the overwhelming desire to win her.

Give her up! See those two husband and wife! Her sweetness, all for Colin! Her love, Colin's right! Himself, in measureless desolation!

He could not do it! The thing was impossible. The idea was preposterous.

Colin had been dear to him; more dear than a brother. But besides this new passion, that quiet affection became as naught. Not that he did not care for Colin still, but that Phyllys was everything to him: Phyllys was his world, his universe.

True, even if he held aloof now, she might in the end reject Colin; and he would then be free to seek her. But of this he had small hope. Colin had seldom, if ever, sought to win affection, and sought in vain.

He felt his own position so far not unhopeful. Phyllys liked him; she was cousinly, even confiding. To persevere might mean success.

And if success for him meant unhappiness, despair, for Colin! Again the past rolled up. Again he saw his own resolve, and the causes which had led to it.

"One may have strained ideas of duty," he muttered. "There is such a thing as common sense in the affairs of life."

Yes; and there is also such a thing as putting self aside for the sake of another.

This, too, he knew. But he saw once more her sweetness, and resistance collapsed. He acknowledged himself beaten.

CHAPTER XVIII

A PAST EPISODE

"YOU are staying for some time at Castle Hill?" observed Kathleen Alyn, with her air of interest.

They were under a tree on the lawn; Mr. Dugdale having retreated to a basket-chair and a book within earshot. Giles had walked with Phyllis and Gordon to Brook-End Grange, and had stayed to luncheon. A business engagement then claimed him, and Mrs. Alyn would not hear of Phyllis going before six. Since Phyllis welcomed the delay, nothing remained for Giles but gloomily to depart alone.

"I'm afraid not. Mrs. Keith did ask me to stay longer, but Grannie gave leave only for three weeks." Phyllis did not hear her own sigh. "The days are going so awfully fast."

"You don't begin to feel home-sick yet?"

"No. Ought I?"

"It is natural that you should enjoy change. Midfell seems so out of the world."

"It 'is' out of the world. It belongs to two centuries ago. Everything and everybody is asleep."

"So even quiet Castle Hill seems gay by contrast."

"No, not gay, but awake—alive. One sees and learns here."

"You begin to know Giles and Colin by this time. I wonder which of the two strikes you, on an early acquaintance, as the finer character?"

"Is it an early acquaintance?" Phyllis felt as if she had known them always. "They are so unlike. One can hardly compare them."

"Colin is popular."

Mr. Dugdale was peering over the edge of his book. "So is Giles, among his own set. Which does Phyllys say she prefers?"

"I didn't say either," laughed Phyllys. "I like both—each in his own way."

"One feels so sorry for poor Colin," remarked Kathleen; and, as before, the word annoyed Phyllys.

"I can't see why one should be sorry for him. He is to be envied—not pitied. He is so much above ordinary men. I think he can afford not to be so—so—"

"Muscular," suggested Mr. Dugdale. "I see you rate a man's intellect above his biceps."

"Wouldn't you?"

"Some don't in this athletic age."

"But I do," decisively. "And Colin is a genius. That is a thousand times better than being able to walk thirty miles without feeling tired."

"Colin is to be congratulated. He has found some one to fight his battles," Mr. Dugdale lowered his book, and scanned Phyllys with quizzical eyes. She stood her ground.

"I mean it. I would rather be a genius than anything. Much rather than just be rich and strong."

"Not that Colin falls short in the length of his walks," murmured Mr. Dugdale. "It's rather in the extent of his mental exertions."

"That was what I meant—that he cannot use his powers," put in Kathleen. "He has always been hampered by ill-health, since he was sixteen."

"Not before?" asked Phyllys.

"No. He was delicate-looking, but wiry, and up to anything. Giles was the more robust, but Colin could outdo even Giles in endurance."

"Giles was not the more robust in their infancy," declared Mr. Dugdale.

"He was when I first knew them, father. But Colin had such spirit. He never flagged, and nothing ailed him till that unhappy accident."

"What was the accident?" asked Phyllis. "No one has told me."

"Your grandmother must know. You will hear no mention of it at Castle Hill. Mrs. Keith dislikes the subject; and neither Giles nor Colin allude to what happened. They were so devoted to poor little Elsie." A word from Phyllis made her add—"Did you not know Elsie Wallace was killed then?"

"No. Please tell me about it."

"She and the boys were always together. It was pretty to see them—she like a little queen, and they her devoted knights. A lovely child, full of fun, yet with that pathetic look in her eyes which you see on the memorial window. Quite unnatural, for there never was a happier being."

"But what was the accident?"

"They were at the seaside. Elsie had been poorly, and Mrs. Keith took her away for change, with the boys. Rather unusual, for she never liked Dr. Wallace, and I do not think she cared for Elsie. Still, it came about somehow—perhaps brought on by Giles. He was masterful even at sixteen, as you may imagine."

Phyllis assented.

"And he worshipped Elsie. It was adoration. Colin was fond of her, but not in the same vehement style. One day they were on the cliff, and I suppose were playing too near the edge. Nobody ever seemed to know how it happened, but Elsie and Colin fell over. There was a rough shingle beach below, with rock-boulders lying about. Elsie, I believe, slipped, and

dragged Colin with her—and Giles was too late to save them. Elsy was undermost, and she never regained consciousness. Colin's head struck on a rock, and he was stunned; but at the time they did not think him so badly hurt. Everybody's attention was taken up with Elsy. She breathed for an hour or two, but died before her father could arrive."

"How dreadful for them!"

"It 'was' dreadful; all the more because one could not help feeling that the boys ought to have been more careful. When I saw them a fortnight later Giles seemed to have grown into a man—so grave and silent! Colin looked awfully ill, and we thought it was Elsy's death. But in time it came out that he was suffering fearfully from his head, and was making a fight to keep about as usual, that nobody might know. He soon had a breakdown, and was worse than if he had been taken in hand at first. He had fallen with the back of his head against a boulder, and the doctors said that the front part of the brain had been badly jarred against the skull by the concussion; so there was double injury. For more than two years he was ill; often kept for days in a dark room. The boy's patience was wonderful, and the pluck with which he would struggle to be well, the moment he was easier. Of course school was out of the question. He was hardly allowed to look at a book. Giles used to read to him when he could bear to listen—which was not for a long while. The marvel is that he has turned out so well, considering his disadvantages. Still, there always is a something about him not like other men. He lives a life of his own. And he is so dreamy—so mystical, if that is the right word."

"He is a genius," remarked Phyllis, as if that explained everything.

"Public school life would have done his genius no harm. I wish he could have had it."

"He didn't model—then?"

"Mrs. Keith snubbed him if he began. He always was trying. Of course, as a boy, he could not take his own way. She tried him at times—made him ill, when he might have been fairly well. The least worry brings

on his headache, and she can't help worrying. Colin somehow excites her, while she never minds anything done by Giles."

"My dear, she is a woman with a temper; but her prosperity depends on keeping straight with Giles," said Mr. Dugdale.

"Yet I have seen him furious with her, for Colin's sake."

"Is Giles a man with a temper?" asked Phyllys.

"I should hardly call him so," Mrs. Alyn replied. "He is not touchy about little things—not quick to imagine slights. But if once he 'is' upset—"

She made a pause. Mr. Dugdale's book had risen to its former position, and he looked over its edge.

"My nephew Jack was at school with Giles. He once remarked that it took a jolly lot to put Giles into a wax; but when, by combined efforts, that feat had been accomplished, Jack's expression was, 'My eyes! We fellows take care to be in the treetops out of his reach.'"

"Yes; I suppose he 'could' be angry," murmured Phyllys.

"But never with Colin," added Kathleen.

Phyllys was silent. She knew better.

CHAPTER XIX

A VANISHED PORTRAIT

"ARE you really better? I'm glad."

Phyllys spoke warmly. Dinner was over, and she and Mrs. Keith had quitted the dining-room, leaving Giles with Mr. Dugdale, this evening, as often, a self-invited guest. Mrs. Keith was gone to her boudoir, and Phyllys found Colin in the drawing-room.

He had been three days invisible, prostrate with headache, and she had been told that he could not appear this evening. Here, however, he was, in the deep armchair, close to the oriel window. He stood up when she came in, despite an eager "Oh, don't!" but was glad to go back.

She sat down and scanned the ivory-tinted face.

"Ought you to have come down?" she asked, as one hand was pressed slowly over the fair hair, its slender fingers perceptibly thinner for three days of starvation and intense pain.

"Thanks, I'm all right now."

She glanced at a book on his knee, half-open, his hand between the leaves. "Have you been trying to read?"

"Not much. There's a paragraph by Kingsley that I thought you might like."

"May I see it?" She took the book and read eagerly the sentence indicated:—

"Never lose an opportunity of seeing anything beautiful. Beauty is God's handwriting; a wayside Sacrament. Welcome it in every fair face, every fair sky, every fair flower, and thank for it Him, the Fountain of all loveliness, and drink it in simply and earnestly with 'all' your eyes. It is a charmed draught, a cup of blessing."

Phyllys's own face was very fair with thoughts evoked.

"I'm glad you've shown me that. It is just what one wants to feel—to do. If beauty really is—that—one can't be wrong in loving it."

"One might rather be wrong not to value it," he suggested.

"But—" and a pause—"there are ugly things in Nature."

"Many things that we stamp as ugly are not so. Part of our condemnation is conventional. Part is due to imperfect sight. We don't detect the exquisite finish—or the balancing of parts. What looks to us like ugliness may belong merely to roughness of outline, due to our blindness. Then, too, we fail to make out the true inwardness. The beauty of Divine handwriting may be there, yet the key is wanting, and we can't translate into the vernacular."

"You wouldn't say that there is beauty in everything!"

"No. But there is an enormous amount more of it than men see. It needs a trained eye and a brain awake. Form and colour are lost upon those who are Nature-blind and Art-blind. And for the most part you will find unlovely outlines—hardness, stiffness, angularity—in human conceptions, not in Divine."

"You like flat surfaces in sculpture," she suggested with quickness.

"Flat surfaces in sculpture—and in Nature—don't mean the rigid flatness of a sheet of iron. There are delicate mouldings—roundings—the melting, so to speak, of one surface into another. Nature's divisions, like Nature's tints, merge by gradations. You don't find squares and oblongs. In a rainbow no man living can define where one colour ends and the next begins."

She smiled acquiescence. Colin's words had power to set her thinking. She did not know how rarely he opened out like this; how studiously his true self was hidden. In Giles she saw the reserve of a man habitually silent; but she had not divined in Colin the deeper reserve of an apparent frankness which told nothing. Once in a way he was really frank with Phyllis; but she

was almost the sole exception. He could seldom bring to the surface those things for which he most cared.

He murmured another quotation:

"'Nature is a poem written by God; and Art is man's translation of it!'

"I forget who said that. But if Nature is a Divine poem, the least we can do is to try to read it."

Phyllis repeated the words to herself.

"I wonder whether all sculptors feel as you do?" she questioned.

"I was not speaking from the sculptor's point of view." His voice had altered, becoming indifferent. Without looking up Phyllis knew that he and she were no longer alone.

Mrs. Keith had appeared, and was in one of her restless moods. She had not known that Colin meant to come down, and the fact seemed to annoy her. She could not sit still, but fidgeted from chair to chair, talking without a break.

There was a draught from the oriel window, and would Colin mind its being shut? No, she really couldn't have any window open. It was so chilly. If he wanted more air, why did he not stay in the study? Mr. Dugdale would be in directly, and Mr. Dugdale was such a fatiguing person, particularly if one was ill. But Colin never took advice, as all the world knew—much better for him if he would.

All this and more was endured with a calm which Phyllis had once taken for unshakeable serenity. She knew better now. She had learnt to decipher the dent in his forehead, the compression of his under-lip, the increased slowness of the dragging voice; and this evening his self-control was more severely tested than usual, from weakness.

But Mrs. Keith, whose one aim was to separate those two, to have Phyllys as a "close preserve" for Giles, saw nothing. She fidgeted and fussed till the door opened.

"Here they come!" And she started up. "Now we must have some music. I want Phyllys to play the Moonlight Sonata."

Giles interposed in curt tones, "Not to-night. Colin can't stand it."

Colin frowned slightly. "Pray make no difference for me," he said. "If you do, I must decamp."

"But we don't want music. Nobody wants it. We all want to talk," urged Phyllys.

She greeted Giles with a smile, and he came to her side, not speaking. Mrs. Keith was insisting energetically on music. Phyllys played so well, and she and Giles loved listening. Colin would not mind, she knew.

"Of course not. Shall I get the sonata?" asked Colin.

"Nonsense!" There was a roughness in the "timbre" of Giles' voice which Phyllys had heard before, and it always surprised her. "You must keep still."

Phyllys gave the speaker a reproachful glance; then turned to Colin. He submitted, but not as if obliged to do so. She noticed a curious reticent dignity in his manner. She met his eyes—blue depths, full of expression—and wondered whom he recalled. The hidden picture flashed up before her mind, and she forgot the question of music, gazing at him.

Somebody else gazed also. Mr. Dugdale's remark might have been an echo of her thoughts.

"Odd! That look again!"

"Isn't he like?" Phyllys all but said. The words were on her lips when she remembered that she had undertaken not to allude to the picture, and

that nobody except herself and Mrs. Keith was supposed to be aware of its existence.

Yet plainly Mr. Dugdale was aware! What could Mrs. Keith have meant?

"Extraordinary!" continued the cool tones. "I've not taken a look at the old portrait for ages: but my memory is good. Colin brings it back."

"I don't understand," Colin said.

"The old painting in a corner of the gallery—used to hang in this room. You've developed an astonishing resemblance to it."

Mrs. Keith stood listening, her face hard set; her fingers clutched about her fan.

"You had that fancy before," she said. "Utterly ridiculous!"

For once she made a mistake. Had she acquiesced, the matter might have dropped. Opposition made Mr. Dugdale eager to prove his point.

"We'll compare him with the original. Come, Colin."

Colin did not stir. "Another time," he suggested.

"Oh, ah! I forgot your head. Well, I'll take a look myself. Never can imagine why that picture should have been banished to the darkest corner in the house!" he muttered as he went—not the first time he had made such a remark.

He was gone for some time, and Mrs. Keith moved restlessly, as if unable to sit still. Phyllys thought her looking old and haggard, and her mouth had a drawn look. No further mention was made of music; and when Mr. Dugdale returned, he said bluntly—"Been moved again! Where, pray?"

"The portrait not there?" asked Giles in surprise.

"Not that I can discover. I've looked all round."

"But of course it is there!" exclaimed Mrs. Keith, facing him indignantly. "It has not been moved."

"Not taken from the corner!"

"Certainly not! Unless Giles—"

Giles made a negative gesture.

"Of course I could not tell. Giles might have moved it, unknown to me. I have had no authority here for years." She spoke with a hard laugh.

"It was in its usual corner not long ago," observed Giles. "I remember seeing it."

"It is not there now," stated Mr. Dugdale in his most dogmatic manner.

"You are sure you have not overlooked it!"

"Come and see for yourself," and the two went off.

Mrs. Keith sat down. "How hot it is! I should like the window open."

Phyllys started up, but was forestalled by Colin. He remained at the casement, as if thankful for outer air.

Mrs. Keith moved again, wandering to the further end of the room.

And Phyllys asked in an undertone, "Why should Mr. Dugdale want to prove that you are like that picture?"

"I don't know." Colin spoke wearily, as if the discussion tried him. "Having once made the assertion, he sticks to it."

"You don't care whether you are or not!"

"Not a fig! Anybody may be like anybody." She could not rival his indifference, and waited in suspense till the two came back, Mr. Dugdale saying triumphantly—"Just as I told you! Vanished!"

"The picture gone! You really mean to say that it is not there!" Mrs. Keith drew near with amazed looks. "My dear Giles! You must be dreaming. Not there!"

"It is not in the gallery."

"But where 'can' it be?"

"That is the question. We have to find out."

"Certainly you must find out," broke in Mr. Dugdale. "A valuable painting can't be allowed to disappear."

Mrs. Keith gave an odd laugh. "But, Giles, it is impossible. The thing can't have walked off of itself."

"No. To-morrow morning I must question the servants."

"The servants would not dare! And they could have no object in moving it."

"They might know its value. Not that I suspect them. It is rather a question whether any one has been in and walked off with it."

Her face lighted up. "Giles! I remember now! That evening, when we heard steps about the house—you can't have forgotten! When we thought a thief might have got in."

"I found no signs of one."

"So you said; but one does not know. The picture was in its place before. I am sure, because that was the day Colin came home. Mr. Dugdale said something of the same sort about Colin's face, and before going to bed, I took a look at the portrait—out of curiosity. The likeness I found to be purely imaginary!"

Mr. Dugdale grunted dissent.

"Purely imaginary," she repeated. "Still, the painting was safe then. An hour or two later we heard sounds about—footsteps—what I always shall believe to have been a thief. Now we know what he carried off."

Giles seemed half convinced.

"I've never noticed the painting since that day—and it seems that you have not either," she added.

"I have not looked for it."

"It was in its place before. It is not in its place now. What other explanation is possible?"

"If it was taken then, I can't understand its not being missed sooner," objected Mr. Dugdale.

"Why should it be? Nobody has given it a thought."

Giles was silent. His glance had wandered to Colin, who seemed trying to decipher Phyllis. She looked up, met his eyes, and blushed. Giles' sombreness increased.

"Great mistake its ever having been removed from this room," Mr. Dugdale declared.

"A mistake possibly, but a natural one," protested Mrs. Keith. "The picture was out of its place. Well enough in a study or a gallery; but not in a drawing-room. Mr. Penrhyn did not mind."

"Mr. Penrhyn never minded anything."

"At all events, I acted for the best. One can't do more. Of course I never dreamt of thieves."

"I shall not rest till it is found," said Giles.

In Phyllis' mind a thought suggested itself. Could Mrs. Keith be a trifle "peculiar" mentally—a degree "touched in the upper story?" Did she

suffer from delusions? Had she herself hidden the lost picture, honestly believing it to be, as she had stated, the portrait of her own brother? Or were there two portraits: the one of Giles' ancestor stolen by a thief; the other of Mrs. Keith's brother, its existence unknown? It would be odd that Colin should resemble both portraits; yet less odd than might appear at first sight, since one of the two was a likeness of his own uncle. Whichever might be the explanation, Mrs. Keith showed eccentricity.

"Poor thing!" mused Phyllys. "I dare say that is why Giles hardly ever contradicts what she says. Perhaps it is why Colin sometimes has to get the upper hand—not to give in too much."

The butler brought in a telegram addressed to herself, and she opened it in trepidation, telegrams at Midfell being rare.

"Grandmother ill, come home to-morrow by early train," she read.

Her face changed, and she saw those around change also.

That of Mrs. Keith might have expressed relief. Giles had the look of one who has received a blow. Colin—was it her fancy that his pale face grew paler?

Then she knew that Mrs. Keith was talking—was exclaiming, inquiring, advising. Perhaps there was some mistake. Would Phyllys like to telegraph inquiries? It seemed such a pity to cut short her visit. She had intended dear Phyllys to stay at least another six weeks. One never could tell what telegrams meant—they were so curtly worded; still it might not be anything serious.

"Grannie must be very ill, or Barbara would not send for me," Phyllys said. "Could some one tell me the first train?"

"The 7.10," Colin observed gently.

"Is that too early? Thanks—then I will go by it. I had better put up my things to-night." She glanced from one to another. "I am so sorry. It has

been a very happy time; and you have all been so good to me! But of course. I must leave."

She went upstairs, and Mrs. Keith followed immediately.

"Giles is looking out particulars," she said. "He will go with you to the Junction, and will put you into a through carriage for the north. Your packing shall be done for you, my dear. It is early still, and you can come down for another hour, perhaps—but of course you must get to bed in good time. We are all so sorry. I had written to Mrs. Wyverne to beg for a longer stay. No—I did not tell you. But you must come to us again, some day."

Phyllis tried to listen. She felt numbed; whether more at her grandmother's probable danger, or at the abrupt need to leave Castle Hill, she hardly knew. The former she did not yet grasp. The latter was a pressing pain. She wondered why the pain should be so acute.

Mrs. Keith moved about the room, restless still.

"About that picture," she said. "Odd— isn't it?" She broke into a laugh.

"I could not help remembering," murmured Phyllis. "Of course I said nothing, as I had promised."

Mrs. Keith wore a look of astonishment.

"You could not help remembering—what?"

"The portrait I saw in your cabinet—the one so like Colin! Don't you know?"—as Mrs. Keith seemed puzzled. "When I went to look for the piece of silk."

"My dear, how droll!" Mrs. Keith laughed again, rather loudly. "That you should think of the two together, I mean. It is quite comic. I am glad you did not say what you thought—though of course you could not, because you had promised."

"No—I remembered."

"Besides—that is my own concern—the likeness of my brother. Dear harum-scarum old Jock—how long it is since I saw him! But, as I told you, nobody knows of that picture, and it is worth nothing to anybody. This disappearance is another matter. The picture we cannot find is a family heirloom, by a famous artist, and is of great value. Mr. Dugdale's notion of its being like Colin is ridiculous. There is no resemblance." Her cheeks had red spots, as if she were angry. "He is such a fanciful man—always imagining things. The likeness that you saw is real enough—only what one might expect! But this notion of Mr. Dugdale's—if it were less absurd, one might be annoyed."

She stopped for a moment.

"The loss of that picture is a real misfortune. Giles will never rest till he has found it. He has all the persistency of the Randolph nature. Not much chance of his succeeding, I am afraid, for the thief has had plenty of time—most likely has sent the picture to America. But if you should be questioned, my dear—which is not likely, as you do not even know the painting—if you should be, please remember that there is no connection between the two things. You must guard yourself, in talking about the family heirloom, not to allude to my little affair—not to break your word."

Then she moved towards the door. "Now we will go down, and have a last chat."

CHAPTER XX

REVERSION TO A RUT

BARBARA PRINGLE stood outside a garden gate in Midfell, interviewing Miss Robins.

A black hat of no particular shape was jammed low upon Miss Pringle's forehead, and a brown blouse of no particular cut "topped" a short skirt of uncompromising apple-greenness. Miss Robins, standing hatless within the gate, had clothed herself in dust-colour, apparently with the aim of matching her own complexion, an aim in which she had succeeded, without resulting loveliness. But what signified looks to one at Miss Robins' mental altitude?

Past this cottage, as past Burn Cottage, swept the busy stream, rustling musical murmurs, telling things unspeakable by human tongues, though not unreadable by human ears, if those ears are attuned and attent. The ears of Miss Robins and Miss Pringle were neither attent nor attuned. Each good lady was too well occupied with her own and her neighbours' concerns to listen to Nature's whispers.

"No time to waste in such dawdling!" they would have said.

"Too much time wasted in gossip for leisure to study the Divine poem!" would have been Colin's version.

So widely different is the view taken by different people from different standpoints.

Behind and before, within sight of both ladies, lay long lines of moor fells, reaches of moorland, across which battalions of cloud-shadows travelled fast and heather-bloom mingled with the greens of grass and bracken. But they did not feast their eyes on Nature's tinting.

"I felt it my duty," Barbara remarked, and she spoke with a grim resolution which squared her jaw, and perhaps angered uneasiness below—"I felt it my duty to act. My grandmother has not been herself for some time; anybody must have seen. She has fretted ridiculously about Phyllis; not about her being away, but about the influences under which she is thrown. No doubt there is self-reproach. The child never ought to have gone. And really—the coolness of that woman—Mrs. Keith, I mean—asking if Phyllis might spend another six weeks at Castle Hill! The idea! Of course Phyllis put her up to it. That was what made my grandmother ill yesterday. I told Mr. Jones, and he said it was enough to account for her

attack. He agreed that the wisest plan was to have Phyllys back; so I telegraphed on my own responsibility. I felt it to be my duty."

"Unquestionably; unequivocally!" purred Miss Robins. "And really, poor dear Mrs. Wyverne was very far from well; you could not have done otherwise."

"Yes, it was quite a sharp attack—she is not given to faintness. And at her age, you know! The fact is, one never knows what that sort of thing may mean. One has to be on the safe side." Barbara seemed to be carrying on an argument in defence of herself. "I did not mention to my grandmother what I had done till this morning's telegram arrived, saying when Phyllys would come, and by that time she was on her way."

"So she could not be stopped. How sensible of you! And Mrs. Wyverne was pleased—gratified?"

"She seemed worried lest Phyllys should be vexed. That shows the position of affairs," added Barbara with vagueness. "But as I said to her, 'What does vexation matter so long as we do what is right?'"

"Very true! Very true indeed!"

"Things will settle themselves when Phyllys is under proper control. I shall take care that she does not go to Castle Hill again in a hurry. One can see that her head is completely turned. She will come home able to think of nothing but her looks. I wish I could have gone to meet her myself to put things in a right light. But it was impossible, and when Mr. Hazel said he was driving over, and would bring her back, I had to agree. Mrs. Hazel says he hadn't thought of going till he knew about Phyllys." Miss Pringle drove the point of a protesting umbrella into the earth. "The way everybody jumps to do any earthly thing for that silly child—really it is too much!"

"She has a wheedling way with men," suggested Miss Robins, who, though a man-despiser, was not above a touch of jealousy towards a woman admired by men.

"Three other people have offered since to fetch Phyllys, and I wish any of them had spoken before Mr. Hazel. The Hazel influence for Phyllys is objectionable."

"The man is more than half a Jesuit at heart," declared Miss Robins.

"The most extraordinary thing is the way Giles Randolph has managed to wheedle my grandmother," said Barbara, frowning. No one but herself would have applied such a word to Giles. "He seems to do whatever he chooses with her."

"Fascination—captivation," murmured Miss Robins, in her favourite sing-song voice. "Your grandmother is so truly excellent a woman, it is inconceivable that she should have given in to the wiles of an unprincipled man, without regard to the welfare of Phyllys, but for some occult influence on his part. Really, no other explanation is possible. I only trust we shall not find Phyllys' character completely deteriorated through the baleful associations of Castle Hill and the contaminations of irreligious society."

Miss Robins was a lover of polysyllabic words.

"Not much chance, I'm afraid. The girl has no strength of principle; she cares for nothing but admiration. Well—" with a solemn satisfaction in her own forebodings—"we shall see. My own belief is that they have got hold of the girl, and that nothing now will break her loose. But I shall do my best."

Meanwhile Phyllys, reaching Garfield Station, nearly ten miles distant from Midfell, looked out for some familiar face. If no "lift" were to be had, a cab would be there; but this expense was, when possible, avoided, and those who owned vehicles seldom failed to place them at the disposal of others less well off.

Nor was she disappointed. As the train steamed in she caught a glimpse of the Vicarage pony-carriage; then found herself face to face with the Vicar. His ruddy face was framed in soft grey hair; a shapeless wide-

awake sat far back on his broad head; tan gloves of unknown antiquity were gripped in one rugged veined hand; the other was outstretched in welcome; and a beaming but embarrassed smile lit up his features.

"Well, little Pride of the Morning," he said, "so here you are! Bright and well, eh? We are glad to have you back."

"But Grannie?" she questioned anxiously.

Mr. Hazel, recalling his wife's injunctions—injunctions primed by Miss Pringle—but forgetting what he had been told to say, smiled perplexedly.

"Oh! Ah! Yes; to be sure, yes! She was ailing yesterday; upset and out of sorts. They had to send for Mr. Jones, and he thought her—" The sentence died into a mumble. "But she is all right again to-day, so no need to worry your little head." The very remark which Barbara had stipulated should not be made. "Now for your luggage," and to escape questioning he marched to where her trunks lay. The smaller could be carried with them; the larger had to be sent next day. Mr. Hazel gave directions, and Phyllis stood by in silence.

She understood; his words had brought the truth before her in one sinister flash, and she grew white to the lips.

It was Barbara's doing! Barbara had summoned her home without cause. Barbara had cut short her happiness. But for Barbara she might still be at Castle Hill.

She saw the whole; yet at first she said nothing. She dared not let herself go. So strong was the wave of resentment which rolled up, that it all but had the mastery.

But she held herself in, following the Vicar, hearing his orders. She went out of the station, listened like one in a dream to his remarks, and patted kindly her old friend the Vicarage "pony," so-called—really a fine cob—who lifted his head in pleased response. And all the while that great wave was surging to and fro.

It frightened her; she had never felt so wrathful. Hers was a quick temper—quick to take fire, quick to burn itself out.

"A flash in the pan," her father had called it.

She had many a time been annoyed with Barbara, but never to this extent.

As they drove through the small town, calling at one or two shops, she was silent still, feeling rather than thinking, for her thoughts were in a maze. It seemed hard that she should not have had to the end her time of pleasure; the visit had meant so much.

And to have her joy cut short for nothing by Barbara's interference—she hardly knew how to endure it. Again and again passionate resentment all but mastered her.

Mr. Hazel, busy with reins and shopping, did not at first notice what was wrong. Gradually it dawned upon him that the bright smile was lacking, the merry voice still.

He waited, as it was his way to wait. Not till they had left the town, and had begun the first long ascent after, did the storm that was raging find expression. He put some question, and she turned a rigid face to him.

"Then Barbara has cheated me out of my pleasure! Grannie has 'not' been ill! There was no need for me to come home!"

CHAPTER XXI

THE THINGS THAT ARE

BETWEEN the claims of truth and a desire not to compromise other people, the Vicar was in difficulties. He gave a jerk to the reins, and murmured indistinct words.

"Barbara is not nervous." Phyllys caught the suggestion, only to repudiate it. She sat bolt upright. "Barbara is never nervous."

Another murmur. This time she heard "mistake."

"No; there is no mistake. It is on purpose. She knew how happy I was—how I wanted to stay. And she loves to make me miserable. It is 'her' doing."

The Vicar made no rejoinder. He cast a concerned glance at the set face; commented to himself on the thunder-cloud overshadowing his "Pride o' the Morning;" and chirruped to the cob. A fresh pull carried them faster, till the increased gradient made slowness a necessity. Then he jumped out, lightly for his years.

"Take the reins, child."

"No." She was already by his side. "Cobweb has weight enough with my box."

He offered no protest, and they mounted a stiff rise in silence, the Vicar keeping up an easy long-limbed swing, born of habit. No quickened breath troubled him; and the reins hung loosely over one wrist, or were flung upon the cob's back.

Phyllys, deep in thought, showed no signs of fatigue, though this came at the end of a long journey. As they ascended, the widening view of distant moors, the rich tints of the fell over which their road led, spoke with the calming power which Nature has over some minds. Three times she forgot herself, standing in contemplation. Each time the Vicar halted, as if for Cobweb's sake; and the look which crept into her face gladdened his heart. A fourth time this happened, and she glanced towards him, smiling.

"I didn't know how lovely it was!" she said. "Must we hurry? I didn't know how dearly I loved it all. Those wavy lines against the sky! And the purples and greens—and the bracken!"

She remembered Colin's quotation,—"*Drink it in with 'all' your eyes,*"—and into the words new meaning dawned. Eyes of the body; eyes of the mind; eyes of the spirit. Through the eyes of the body, to the eyes of the mind; through the eyes of the mind, to the eyes of the spirit. Had Colin opened for her those inward eyes? She saw with them as never before. Nature around was as it ever had been; but for her it held fresh perfection, fresh meaning. She was enchained by the mouldings of the hill-sides, the delicate fadings of one tint into another. Each hummocked fell demanded hours of study. She would be able to give the hours; and Colin had taught her how to use them.

Through the railway journey her thoughts had been much with Giles, and the look in his face when they parted. Sorry as she had been to leave, her sorrow was of a composite nature, made up of many elements. She began to see a contrast between him and herself; to realise the homogeneousness of his mental make. She wanted many things,—Castle Hill, Colin, Art, freedom, fresh ideas—as well as Giles. He wanted one thing—herself. She perceived this, after a fashion, without grasping that his "want" meant something infinitely beyond mere "friendship." She had a sense that Giles was giving her more than she could give him. Her feelings towards him were mixed. His towards her were unblended.

Now, instead of thinking about him, she was thinking about Colin, recalling what Colin had said, studying old scenes in the light of Colin's teaching, wishing she could be in the studio with Colin. As at this moment she might have been—but for Barbara.

Uprolled another wave of anger; and the Vicar saw. He had known it must return. She was not yet victor.

She met his glance. "Why are people allowed to do such things?" she asked abruptly. "Such a beautiful world!—And 'such' people in it!"

"Try to be fair," he said; irrelevantly some might have thought.

"But it is she who is not fair to me. She never was fair. It isn't that I'm sorry to come back to you and Mrs. Hazel—or to Grannie! It is the being made like this—forced!—without any choice. She has no right. I am not a child now. And I did so count on the next few days—if it might not be more, just those days. I was learning so much that was new and lovely!"

"Yes. But the lessons we want to learn are not always those that the Great Teacher sets us." He spoke in an everyday tone, not as one preaching.

"It isn't—'that?' It is Barbara!"

"It is always 'that,' my child—no matter how the disappointment comes."

"If she had explained—if Grannie needed me. It is the being made that I hate. Wouldn't you, in my place?"

"Yes," he said, and her face grew softer.

"I'm glad. Then it isn't altogether wrong to be vexed."

"No; perhaps not. But if I were you, I wouldn't waste too much time over your cousin's share. If she has wronged you, she has to be forgiven; and it is more dignified not to show offence. People make foolish blunders; but one may credit them with a right intention."

"Ought one? Only, I'm sure she did mean unkindness." Then, with a laugh of apology—"Perhaps I am as unfair to her as she is to me."

"Good!" They were now moving on. "To see in oneself that possibility is a first step towards a right spirit. Nine-tenths of the disagreements in this world arise from a want of fairness in judging others. We have too often one rule for ourselves, another for other people." He flipped off a dandelion-head with the tip of his whip. "One should be fair towards everybody—" and he could not resist adding—"even Miss Pringle."

Phyllys' eyes twinkled. She knew that her cousin and her cousin's friend were thorns in the Vicar's side. Whatever he did they opposed;

whatever he said they contradicted. But he met their opposition in a large and manly way, and laughed at their contradiction. It was more serious when they systematically upset his influence among the cottagers; yet even there the Vicar was reasonable. He insisted that though their methods were, from his point of view, entirely wrong, their aims were good; and he would allow no wholesale condemnation. Phyllis, aware of all this, realised the force of his advice.

"I'll try," she said. "Only Barbara isn't fair towards 'them!'"

"Towards—?"

"Giles and Colin—and Mrs. Keith. She thinks unjustly. She says they are bad."

"And you have found them good?"

"Yes!" emphatically. Then, "Yes," more slowly. "I suppose there are different sorts of goodness. I don't mean that they are—perfect."

"We need not expect from others what others don't find in us."

"Mrs. Keith puzzles me; still, in a way she is religious. I am sure she is. And Giles—he doesn't say much, but I couldn't tell you how kind he is, how he thinks of everybody. Of course—" and a fresh pause—"he has faults."

"So have we!"

"Yes. And then—Colin—when he talks it isn't like anybody here. Not like Miss Robins, one 'least' little bit. Or like—. No, I don't think he says things in the way you do. Only you would like him. Colin feels and understands. He is different from other people. And I think his goodness—his religion—somehow has to be different, to fit his mind. If I were to say that to Barbara, she would think it wicked. Is it? I can't help feeling so when I'm with him."

"There are many developments of Christ-likeness."

"You don't think he must be wrong because he says things in a different way from—what you would?"

The Vicar's smile was beautiful. It showed a new side of him. She wondered—had Colin opened her eyes with regard to human beings as well as inanimate Nature?

Mr. Hazel made another halt, letting the cob browse. He led Phyllis to the edge, where a steep slope fell away towards a wide extent of country, bounded by hills. Across the plain meandered a river, shining like silver in sunlight. There were green meadows; and in one direction lay ploughed fields. He drew her attention to each.

"The same sun shines upon all. But not all surfaces can respond equally to his shining. Is it the fault of the brown earth that it remains dull? He who made water and grass made earth also. Will He be unfair in His expectations? Will He blame the soil because it cannot respond to His light with green beauty like grass, or gleam and flash like water? Would it be right of the river to condemn the grass because it does not shine? Or of the grass to declare earth a failure because it is not green? Or of the earth to condemn grass and water for giving a different response from its own? In each case the maker has much to say to results. And—God made it."

Phyllis' face grew radiant.

"I never saw that before! Why did you not tell me? It would have been a help."

"You were not ripe for it earlier. This visit has brought you on. You are older." Then, after a break, "But to decide which of those about us is, in the Divine sight, as earth or grass or water, lies beyond our power."

Phyllis blushed. She had already been thinking that Barbara was like dull earth.

"I'll try to be fair," she replied, and when they reached the Cottage no trace remained of past billows. Barbara had expected a storm, and though

she would not admit the fact, she was a trifle relieved, even touched, by "the child's" forbearance.

CHAPTER XXII

THINGS THAT SHOULD BE

IF Giles had lived through years in a week when he awoke to his love for Phyllis, Phyllis lived through months in three weeks, while striving to reduce a chaos of new ideas to what has been called "a workable philosophy of life."

Not that she, in so many words, put this before herself. She only tried "to get things straight," and even in that she failed. She was too young, life was too new, the "things" in question were too large, for immediate success. She did not yet know herself; and till we know ourselves, we cannot know those about us—those who make our "world"—or grapple with the problems of their and our existence.

From an artistic and contemplative atmosphere, from a home where the cult of beauty ranked foremost, from a new breadth of view and a new rush of thought, she was plunged in the old narrow circle, where what she best loved was condemned, where beauty was regarded as a snare, where the love of Nature was a synonym for wasted time, where Art was a delusion and a plaything for a dying world.

The contrast tried her. With the unbalanced eagerness of youth, she expected to find all good on one side, all evil on the other; and, like a child, impatient of consideration, she was as ready to condemn Barbara, Miss Robins, even her grandmother, as they were to condemn her friends.

Yet she had begun to see with wider eyes,—to realise that others too found difficulties, and that the same clues do not serve for all minds. She had begun to feel the need in herself of a kinder and fairer spirit. She had begun to appreciate the saintly goodness of her stern old grandmother, to perceive the true beauty which underlay superficial blemishes.

"It is all bewilderment," she had often said. But step by step she was being led to levels where she could look over dividing walls which once had shut her in.

She was gaining glimpses of the true unity which underlies diversity—that unity which meets in Christ. She was dimly seeing that all ideals of beauty centre in Him; that the highest types of beauty are reflected from Him. So these weeks meant much to her. She was learning tolerance from the bigotry of others, and sympathy through her own struggles. Such lessons once mastered, differences of opinion on lesser points fall into their right positions, and the pursuit of beauty rises to a higher level.

The old Vicar saw, and he would not meddle. He had faith in the Divine training of individuals; and he had learnt something of that quality, rare in human beings,—Divine patience. He would not hurry her faster than she could go safely. A word here, a sentence there, gave the needed touches. They were oftener together than in past days. Phyllys' absence had made a difference, setting her more at liberty. But the ruthless condemnation of people and things went on as of old; and Phyllys was far from having Divine patience.

Barbara, Miss Robins, even Mrs. Wyverne, with all her single-hearted devotion, knew nothing of the many-sidedness of truth. The simple fact that Christ is truth, and that in possessing Him a man possesses Divine truth, they recognised verbally; but the Impossibility that any human mind should grasp truth in its completeness, because no man can grasp God, they did not see. It was with them as with Giles on the foggy moor. Each walked in her tiny circle of mist, perceiving a patch of grass, a bush; while of the world, the Universe, beyond, nothing was visible.

Giles had known, though he could not see, that a world, a Universe, did exist. They, walking in their foggy circles, did not believe in aught

beyond.

Yet, despite these limitations, Mrs. Wyverne lived a life which many of loftier conceptions might have envied; for it was a life of personal knowledge of God, of personal intercourse with her Heavenly Father, little hindered by the narrowness of her theories. The theories were on one plane; the life lived was on another. She fell into the error of severely judging those from whom she differed: yet even this she did as a high Christian duty, "verily thinking that she ought," and not from lack of love.

"They won't see! They won't understand," Phyllis one day broke out.

The Vicar, in his shabbiest coat, tended a large rose-bed, his pride and delight. Some fine blooms lingered still.

"I would put a 'can't' for the 'won't,'" he suggested.

"Barbara says there is no such thing as 'fineness' in human nature. I said Giles had a fine character. And he has! And she said that was wrong, for human nature is all failure and wickedness."

"Ah, we learn to know others by ourselves. She finds it so, does she?"

Phyllis laughed. The Vicar always brought her round.

"And when I told her that he was a really good man, she was horrified. She says no man is good."

"Miss Pringle is wiser than her Bible. She should hunt out the word with a Concordance."

"And she says the idea of singing prayers in Church is foolish—nobody can pray, singing. It is all outward show."

"Doubtless Miss Pringle cannot!" The Vicar chuckled, recalling grim sounds wont to issue from Mrs. Wyverne's pew. "She is not precisely musical."

"You don't think that?"

"Certainly not. Music, like any art, may become an avenue to higher things—but only with those capable of using it. To my mind, the highest uses of music are for the noblest purposes—above all, for God's children, addressing their Father in concert. But, my little girl, you can't make everybody see as you see. Some can pray, singing; some can only pray, speaking. Some can speak to God in poetry, some only in prose. Our Father in heaven hears all, understands all. No use to try to stuff our own opinions down other people's throats."

"Only, if one knows they are wrong—!"

"For the matter of that, Miss Pringle knows you are wrong."

"Must one never persuade them to think differently?"

"I've no vast faith in the power of argument." The Vicar stood, hoe in hand, looking down on his companion. "The great foundation-truths of Christianity have to be fought for. But breath and temper are often wasted on non-essentials. People have to work out doubtful points for themselves."

"Only Barbara 'was' wrong!"

"So are you and I on a hundred points. We hope to be set right in time; if not in this life, then in the next."

"Then oughtn't one to try to understand now?"

"Try your hardest; and be ready always for fresh teaching. But try much more to do, to be, to live! It signifies less whether you have a great deal of light than whether you make the best possible use of such light as you have."

She murmured a "Yes."

"Beyond all, don't condemn others for seeing on these lesser questions not so clearly, perhaps, as you are conscious of seeing yourself. They may be all the while more fully after God's own heart. An ounce of true humility

is worth gallons of excellent opinions. A cupful of Christlike self-abnegation is worth an ocean of correct definitions."

He went back to his weeding, and presently a sound made Phyllys turn.

"Oh!" she exclaimed.

Colin stood on the gravel path with lifted cap and a light in his eyes.

"I have come to finish the bust," he said.

CHAPTER XXIII

COLIN'S CONQUESTS

COLIN conquered them all, "straight off," as the Vicar said, though with variations of speed, and apparently without effort.

First to succumb was the Vicar himself. He gave unqualified approval to the delicate-looking young fellow, whom nobody would have taken for more than two or three and twenty; and the Vicar's wife followed suit.

"He's the sweetest boy I ever saw," she declared with an enthusiasm which made her husband laugh.

"Giles knows nothing about my coming," he said. "I'm supposed to be in the Highlands, abjuring work. Don't betray confidence, please. I wrote yesterday, and needn't write again."

Phyllys supposed that he was under orders not to model, and that he intended to disobey.

Mrs. Wyverne next fell a victim. She was fascinated at first sight, like the Vicar. She had given in to Giles, partly out of respect to the head of her family, partly as a result of pains on his part. Colin took no pains. He was introduced, smiled, announced that he had come to complete a work of art, Phyllys being the subject, and opposition collapsed like a pricked bubble. The old lady could hardly take her eyes from him.

"I suppose you are counted like your mother," she said in unbelieving tones. "Not like what she was when she and I met; but, perhaps—"

"My mother says I am like everybody in turn, which is much the same as being like nobody."

"You certainly remind me of some one."

Phyllys wondered, but would not suggest—was Mrs. Wyverne conscious of his resemblance to the lost painting? She might have spoken her thought but for a second question—could Mrs. Wyverne have seen that other picture, hidden in the cabinet, if, indeed, it was another?

She took an opportunity to inquire whether the lost portrait had been found, and Colin replied in the negative. He showed little interest in the topic.

Barbara yielded more slowly. Colin was a man, and she detested men; he was an artist, and she despised Art. The bust aroused her righteous indignation; not altogether righteous, since jealousy of Phyllys had a share. Though not great in self-knowledge, she perhaps knew this. But she gave the reins to what she felt, and ruthlessly stigmatised sculpture as worldly, wasteful, an encouragement to vanity; not sparing words, till silence on his part grew impressive, and she met those blue eyes, looking not "at" but "into" her, with a depth of understanding which brought her to a dead halt.

"Yes," he said slowly, and waited.

She had no more to say. Did he read to the ground of her motives? Was she to him a transparency?

Then came his winning smile; a smile which few could withstand. It took her captive on the spot.

"Try for yourself," he said sweetly.

And the household stood open-mouthed to see Miss Pringle seated before the improvised modelling-stool which, with Mrs. Wyverne's permission, had been set up in the study. She clumsily fingered a lump of clay; she submitted to be lectured. The results of her fingering need not be described. The results of his manipulation were that he thenceforth dragged her, a helpless victim, at his chariot wheels.

"It's too comical for anything," declared the Vicar, his shoulders shaking. "Miss Pringle, of all people! That lad could make the trees run after him if he chose."

How much Colin laughed privately no one knew. He maintained in public his gentle and detached demeanour.

Difficulties were cleared away so far as might be from his path, the household uniting to supply his wants. He had the exclusive use of the little back-room; and a water-tap was outside his door. Phyllys was allowed to sit to him for two hours each day, Mrs. Wyverne being present with her knitting, while Barbara came in and out, hanging round in wordless admiration, never dreaming how her fidgety movements and creaking shoes tried the young sculptor.

She did not agree with his views; she counted still that Art was a delusion. But Colin Keith she confessed to be the one really agreeable man whom she had met on the face of the earth.

For a week all went well, and the bust made progress. Colin was unusually vigorous; perhaps from the light moor air which seemed to keep headache at bay. "I shall know where to go next time when I want change," he said. He looked his best; active, joyous, full of delight in his task, full also of bright expectancy in another direction, which the Vicar saw with gladness, and Mrs. Wyverne with anxiety.

Phyllys enjoyed having him. She delighted in his artistic talk; she chatted freely as she sat for her clay portrait; and the hours slid by. It was reflection of Castle Hill happiness.

But after days of work and intercourse, a change dawned. Mrs. Wyverne had one morning been called away, and Phyllys occupied the usual position.

"I've had to write at last to let them know where I am," he remarked. Then—"You are tired. Take it easy for five minutes. You must rest."

She had found it out herself earlier. A weariness had taken possession of her, a longing for something, she could not define what. All this seemed not worth while. She stood and stretched herself while he turned to do something with one of the little wooden instruments.

And the thought came—if Giles had been there instead of Colin!

It was like a wave of understanding poured over her. In a moment she saw that she was tired of having Colin only in place of Giles. She liked him, admired his gifts, enjoyed his conversation. But her real want was for Giles. She wanted him, not for his mental gifts, not for aught that he might say or do, but for himself. She wanted the strong manly presence, the intense devotion. "Was" it devotion? Did he care for her further than as a friend? How was she to know?

Colin by comparison was nothing. Suddenly she had grown satiated with Nature and Art, with his thoughts about both. He had fascinated her, and he might fascinate her again; but he could not give all she wanted. Not Nature, not Art, still less theories about either, could meet her claims. It was love that she needed; Giles' love.

To her artistic, her intellectual, her imaginative sides, Colin appealed. But these were not the whole Phyllys. A more powerful claim rose up and would not be silenced. Her inner self cried out for Giles—Giles with his faults, his temper, his difficulty of expression, his silence—just Giles Randolph as he was. When she could escape, she went to her own room, recognising that Giles was more to her than any other in the world. The

discovery brought something of dread lest her love should be unreturned; yet it shed a new radiance on her life. She had not known the strength with which it was in her to love. A pent-up flood had burst its barriers, flowing in a rush throughout her being, and the loosened waters freshened everything they touched, glorifying the world around. All had become beautiful. Colin had poured new meanings into Nature and Art. But Giles had poured new light, new love, into the very springs of her existence. Life was transformed by this new knowledge. Even if he should never return what she felt for him, nothing could rob her of the power of loving.

Did he care? She put the question many times. A few days earlier she had believed herself to be more to him than he was to her. But in the light of this realisation, she saw him and herself from a fresh point of view. His reticence made it difficult to gauge what he felt. Yet things might be as she hoped.

There was a glow in her eyes that evening which awoke hope in Colin, and aroused Mrs. Wyverne to uneasiness.

She came late to Phyllys' room, and found her at the open window, her candle out. The old lady closed the window, sat down, and smoothed the soft hair with unwonted tenderness.

"Thee should be in bed, my child," she said, with her occasional reversion to the old-fashioned Quaker speech. "Thee should be asleep."

"Very soon, Grannie. The stars are lovely."

Mrs. Wyverne spoke abruptly. "Colin Keith is a pleasant youth; but I fear I have acted with imprudence. He and thee are friendly."

"Oh, very," assented Phyllys. "I like him so much. He is delightfully artistic."

"He is winsome, but, I fear, a man of this world only."

"No, indeed, I don't think that. He doesn't talk—men don't, you know. They are so afraid of saying what might be taken for cant, and they hate to

make a show of goodness. He 'does' think of—that sort of thing. I am sure he is good; truly good."

Mrs. Wyverne shook a decisive head. Her rules were arbitrary, and would not include Colin.

"I should fear greatly for thy future, Phyllys, should he and thee desire to marry."

Phyllys's colour went up in the darkness.

"Oh, not the least chance!" she said. "We are only a sort of cousins. Not that kind of thing at all. He would not wish it, any more than I do."

Mrs. Wyverne's uneasiness was deepened, rather than mitigated.

Next day, to the astonishment of everybody, Mrs. Keith walked in.

She was in York, having arrived three days earlier, and she had been taken by surprise at the news of Colin's presence in Midfell, forwarded from home. It was extremely wrong of Colin, just when he had been ordered complete rest. He would suffer for it, &c.; and she had come to see about things herself.

That Colin showed gratification at her advent could hardly be said. He was, as always, courteous; but her arrival broke into a plan of his own. Last touches having been given to the bust of Phyllys, he was on the point of proposing to make a cast of Mrs. Wyverne's fine old head. Now he waited for developments.

They soon appeared. Mrs. Keith was primed with a scheme to circumvent him.

The friends with whom she was staying in York—an old school-chum and her husband—had lately bought a chalet on the borders of Lake Thun, and had asked her to return with them for a month. She brought also an invitation for Phyllys. Would Mrs. Wyverne spare her? Expense should be

Mrs. Keith's concern; she promised every care; the excursion would be enjoyable for Phyllys; and for herself it would mean gain in the added cheerfulness of a young companion.

So much passed in public; and Phyllys' hopes of being allowed to go were faint. But a few words in private settled the question.

"No—not the least chance of Colin joining us," Mrs. Keith said, in response to a query. "He is due in Scotland; and the Forsyths scarcely know him."

This induced the old lady to give in, despite Barbara's remonstrances.

CHAPTER XXIV

A FAMILIAR HANDWRITING

PHYLLYS sat alone in the garden of Châlet S. Jacques, intent on the scene before her. Ah, but it was lovely!

Had she never come across Colin Keith, it would have been less to her than now; yet the underflow of her mind was towards Giles, not Colin. Which seemed, perhaps, ungrateful.

Ten days earlier she and Mrs. Keith, travelling with Mr. and Mrs. Forsyth, had reached this villa or "châlet," lately purchased as a summer resort by Mrs. Keith's friends. Here they would remain another ten days. After that, possibly, Mrs. Keith and she might move to another part of Switzerland before returning home.

The wailings of an ill-handled violin from the châlet behind disturbed her musing. Mr. Forsyth, kindest of men, never dreamt that his tuneless

dirges could affect others unpleasantly. He was always happy, violin in hand. So was his wife, while she could talk. A ceaseless murmur travelled through the open window, underneath that which held the violin. The two elder ladies had been at work for an hour, discussing the latest fashion in toques and bodices; one of the two with her back to Nature's sublimity, the other with eyes on her knitting. Of course they had both looked out, and had said how pretty it was.

Phyllis was content to be left to her studies of that sublimity. They were always fearing she would be dull, with no young companions of her own age. She laughed at the notion. Dull!—with this to look upon! Dull!—with Giles to think about!

It could hardly be called a "lawn" on which she sat. It was more like a field, sloping downward. Two small trees sheltered her head; below the garden lay more grass-land; then the road which skirted the lake; then some rough wooden structures and a vegetable garden; then the lake; then the mountain amphitheatre.

Prominent in front, across the translucent blue-green water, stood a mountain of pyramidal shape, by name the "Niesen"—a useful friend to the neighbourhood, acting as weather barometer by the simple process of putting on and pulling off his cloud-cap. He had slipped it on and whisked it off three or four times this day, as if unable to make up his mind. A range of half-cumulous clouds was creeping along the sides; and above towered the hoary mass of the Blumlisalp, one keen-cut edge over a dull barrier of rock glowing like a piece of white enamel.

Far away to the left stood forth the three chief giants of the scene—the mighty Jungfrau, sharply outlined, pure and snowy, with grey hollows and shades; the white Mönch; and the rocky Eiger.

Phyllis drank it all in, finding each minute some new beauty, some fresh dent or fold, some perfect moulding, some wonderful contrast in light and shade, some unexpected harmony of form.

"One would never get to the end," she whispered; "not in years and years."

Doleful sounds ceased, and hardly had she congratulated herself, before she found Mr. Forsyth at her side; an elderly man, scarcely taller than herself, with eyes full of kindness and full also of anxious worry, echoed by horizontal lines on his retreating forehead. Not that he had anything to worry about, but that he never could resist worrying about nothing. He suffered from nervous depression, and found chief solace in his violin.

He came with a cautious step, as if picking his way; yet when he spoke, words tumbled fast, one upon another.

"Well, Miss Wyverne, tired of sitting here all alone! Pretty view, eh?—very pretty! I've been trying that tune over again—you know it."

Phyllys had vainly sought to pin a name to the concatenation of wails.

"Couldn't manage it yesterday. Goes better now. Just a matter of practice. We'll try again after dinner?"

And she smiled assent, though with an internal shiver at the prospect.

"First-rate thought of my wife, hiring that piano. A little music, always cheerful. Would you like a run into Thun—get tea, and come back for dinner?"

Phyllys jumped up. A "run" to any part of the lake was charming, and in a few minutes they were off, hurrying through the village of brown and yellow châteaux, with their verandahs and overhanging eaves. It was about ten minutes' walk to the boat-station, and they were in time for the next steamer, zigzagging from side to side of the lake, in progress from Interlaken to Thun. She had been to the quaint old town more than once, but one could not go too often, and Mr. Forsyth made an excellent conductor. They wandered through the streets, visited the castle, admired the views, and enjoyed themselves.

"Pity Randolph refuses to come out! Great pity!" remarked Mr. Forsyth.

Phyllys had not heard this.

"Mrs. Keith was sure he would come. Can't understand it! She didn't want her own son—odd, rather!—come to think of it. Bent on having Randolph. My wife and I quite willing, of course—room enough for both. Mrs. Keith seems to have urged it—but letter this morning decisive. No—yesterday, was it? I've no memory. Says he has too much to do—can't get away. Mrs. Keith will have told you."

"No. Was I meant not to know it?"

"She told us—spoke openly. By-the-by—that wretched memory of mine!—she did say she wanted his coming to be a surprise. But now of course—no matter, since he can't come."

"It would have been nice if he could," she said.

A shadow had fallen; for this might mean much. If Mrs. Keith had tried to persuade Giles to join them, and had urged in vain, it looked as if he did not greatly care to see more of Phyllys. Was he so overwhelmingly busy that he could not spare a few days? She found it hard to believe. He was his own master.

"Getting tired, eh?" demanded Mr. Forsyth.

"O no," and she roused herself. "But ought we not to go back?"

He assured her there was no hurry, and they started for a fresh tramp. She did her best to seem interested, and to laugh at his little jokes; but the strain became severe. Soon she could not hide that she really was tired—with a heartsickness which he did not suspect. He grew concerned, and took her to the nearest inn, insisting on a fresh supply of tea, though they had had some earlier. She remonstrated in vain. He wandered into the passage, and came back, laughing.

"Now how is that?" he asked, holding out a letter. "Sent to this inn, of all places! 'To be kept till called for.' What chance that Mrs. Keith ever would call?"

Phyllys' heart gave a throb. "From Giles!" escaped her lips.

"Giles Randolph?" Mr. Forsyth examined the envelope. "Now you mention the fact, I 'have' seen his hand. Characteristic! But I say—" turning the letter round—"if so, he is in Switzerland. The postmark is Swiss—Interlaken."

Another throb, this time of hope.

"But you said he would not come."

"So Mrs. Keith assured me—yesterday—or was it the day before? I'm wretched at dates. He may have changed his mind. Though why he should stay at Interlaken, and should address a letter to Mrs. Keith at a Thun hotel beats me!" Mr. Forsyth passed a puzzled hand across his forehead. "Beats me!" he repeated.

Phyllys' colour was bright.

"Beats me utterly!" he said a third time. Then—"Fine fellow, Randolph."

"He and Colin are both nice."

"Well, yes—Colin rather handicapped, poor chap. But Randolph—very fine fellow. Good landlord—good shot—makes himself liked."

Phyllys had lost her tired look, and was eager to get home. They went to the boat-station, and caught the next steamer.

"We'll have a little fun with her," suggested Mr. Forsyth, as they mounted the hill. Phyllys smiled, full of the thought that Giles was near—perhaps already on the way to join them. He would come that evening. No doubt he meant to take them by surprise. On arrival, her colour was commented on by Mrs. Keith. "Swiss air is doing you good," she said.

"By-the-by, did you say Randolph was still at home," asked Mr. Forsyth—"not able to come out?"

She glanced towards Phyllis. "I hope he may join us—but yesterday I heard he was too busy. I have another letter to-day, saying the same." She tapped the floor with her foot. "I don't mean to let him off."

"What would you say—if he is already in Switzerland?"

She looked in astonishment. "Giles in Switzerland! Certainly not."

"But he must have come! He must have changed his mind,"—and Phyllis laughed with happiness. "He is at Interlaken."

"Nonsense. Why are you trying to take me in?" with a suspicious glance.

"We are not so unkind," Mr. Forsyth protested. "It is the oddest thing—we happened to go into an inn at Thun, and we found a letter for you, waiting. 'To be left till called for.'"

She made a movement—and tried to smile.

"I must have given the wrong address to some friend. How absurd!"

"But Giles knows your address." A strong sense of Mrs. Keith's untruthfulness took possession of Phyllis. She could conjecture no reason for false statements, yet that something of falsity underlay the other's last utterance was evident.

"I was not speaking of Giles—of course—" hurriedly.

"And this letter is from Giles. It is his own handwriting; and it has the Interlaken postmark. Giles must be at Interlaken."

Mrs. Keith received the envelope from Mr. Forsyth—turned it over—looked at the postmark—muttered something indistinct—then, to the amazement of all present, she fainted dead away.

CHAPTER XXV

GILES OR SOMEBODY

"MY dear, it is absolutely unimportant. You make such a fuss. I have told you before that I have a weak heart; and I must expect attacks of this kind. The fact is, I ought to be more careful; and these steep hills try me. I shall get a quiet day to-morrow."

Mrs. Keith spoke in feverish accents, her lips working. She seemed entirely unstrung. She had rallied from the faint, and had insisted on going to her own room, carrying the unopened letter, begging to be left alone. Phyllis, anxious and perplexed, crept in later, and found her on the sofa. A whisper of inquiry brought remonstrance.

"The attacks seem to come without cause, so I shall have to be more particular."

"Had" there been no cause—no connection between Giles' handwriting and the swoon? Yet, why should Giles' presence at Interlaken startle her, when she so wished him to come?

"And really," she went on, "they are of no consequence, so long as I do not over-exert myself. But I feel that I 'must' have a day of real rest, all to myself." She sighed, as if oppressed. "These dear good people are most kind, but I get so worn out with the perpetual talk. I want you to help me, dear. If you could contrive to have them off my hands for a day, it would be a mercy."

She fixed troubled eyes on the girl.

"I don't think they would like that."

"They would not mind. I have thought it out. We will persuade them to go to S. Beatenberg to-morrow; and at the last moment I shall slip out of it. You must give them no hint. I hate the idea of that funicular railway."

"But—if Giles were to come—only of course you will be here, so that will be all right."

Mrs. Keith seemed amazed. "Giles!" she said. "I wish he would."

"Perhaps he will look in to-night—if he is still at Interlaken." The other's bewildered face made her add, "The letter we brought from Thun—don't you remember? In Giles' handwriting."

Mrs. Keith broke into a loud laugh; then put her hand to her head.

"These fainting-fits leave me so confused. Yes; now I remember. You did say something of the kind. But, my dear, that is a mere business epistle—from 'quite' another quarter. A man with an altogether different name."

Phyllis felt sorely disappointed; and Mrs. Keith, pulling herself up, brought from her pocket a torn envelope.

"Now you can see. Not Giles' writing at all, though I grant there is a resemblance. One of those accidental likenesses, which have nothing to account for them. Giles is at home still, and the tiresome fellow seems determined not to come out. I am beginning to think—" and she smiled—"that my best plan will be to cut short the Swiss trip, and to take you there. Would you like to see Castle Hill again? Ah, I thought so. I have you for a month, and I do not mean to be cheated out of any part of it. We shall see to-morrow. These attacks leave one hardly fit for anything but home."

Castle Hill—and Giles! Had it not been for the thought of Giles, a cutting short of the Swiss trip would have meant dire disappointment. Things being as they were, Phyllis only hoped she did not betray too much gladness. She lowered her eyes for an examination of the envelope; and again the strong resemblance to Giles' writing impressed her. Certain letters were differently formed; but the remainder she could have declared in a Court of Justice to be his.

"A mere chance likeness, you see," Mrs. Keith said lightly; and Phyllis forebore to contradict.

The proposed excursion was taken up by their host and hostess, though not without hesitation on the score of Mrs. Keith's unfitness. It was a shock to Phyllis' sense of honesty, when the latter cheerfully assured them that she was "perfectly well," that "nothing would do her so much good as a trip up the mountain," and that she was "longing to try one of those charming mountain railways."

Next day proved fine, and Mrs. Keith went so far as to dress for the start. Not till the last moment did she draw back, sinking into a chair, faintly professing herself so much fatigued, that she hoped they would excuse her. No—she would not let Mrs. Forsyth remain at home. Rather than that, she would go, though it might mean another fainting-fit. All she needed was a quiet day on the sofa.

Reluctantly the Forsyths yielded, left her in charge of the Swiss maids, and went without her.

Not, however, to S. Beatenberg. No sooner were they on the steamer, than Mrs. Forsyth suggested a day at Interlaken, deferring the S. Beatenberg excursion until Mrs. Keith could form one of their party. She had so wanted to try the mountain railway!

Mr. Forsyth agreed, and it was not Phyllis' place to set them right. So instead of landing below S. Beatenberg, they steamed to the farther end of the lake, amid a goodly number of excursionists, though not so many as a few weeks earlier. It was a cool autumn day, and the woods were gay with red and gold.

At Interlaken they wandered along the Barnhofstrasse, poked in and out of shops, and picked up presents for friends at home. It was all too smart and fashionable, Phyllis decided, and not to be compared with the village where they stayed; yet she enjoyed it much. The Jungfrau, solemnly overlooking the town, had not here the aspect of a white guardian angel as when viewed from Châlet S. Jacques.

"More like a lump of chalk," suggested Mr. Forsyth, and though Phyllys repudiated the suggestion it recurred to her mind.

One way and another the hours slipped by. Late in the afternoon they had tea outside a shop, then went to the chief Promenade, the Hoheweg, where they encountered English friends. Mr. Forsyth disappeared with the gentleman of the party, and Mrs. Forsyth sat down for a talk with two elderly ladies.

Phyllys joined in for a while, then wandered a short distance, and gave herself up to the study of the Jungfrau. No look of "chalk" now! Something in the state of the morning atmosphere must have caused that aspect. The mountain-mass reared its mighty head in majestic style, and broad reaches of snow descended low like trailing skirts of white. Higher peaks were partly hidden by drifting clouds, but one and another appeared in turn: and each moment the mountain altered, the shapes of rifts and hollows changing as she gazed. A clear basin of snow, for a time visible, vanished utterly.

She watched with interest the Schynige Platte, where the Forsyths had promised to take her. In the far distance she could make out a tiny mountain-train creeping slowly up the steep sides, carrying a minute cloud of steam.

Glancing to make sure that she was not wanted, she received a nod from Mrs. Forsyth; and she wandered farther, getting among trees. It was evident that her friends were in no hurry to move. Suddenly her heart gave a throb, stopped, then beat furiously.

Could it be—Giles?

A big man, broad-shouldered, sat alone at a small table; his face turned half away. The shape of his powerful shoulders; the attitude; the manner in which he leaned his head on one hand; the grave immobility—all indicated Giles. He seemed to be deep in thought; lost to his surroundings.

She was not near enough to make out more. She stood partly behind a tree, gazing. Whether or not in consequence of her gaze, he turned, and she had a glimpse of his strong sunburnt profile.

"Giles!" she whispered.

Why had Mrs. Keith denied his presence?

But the face looked older than when she had seen him last; not thinner; not paler; only markedly older. She almost thought his hair had gained a touch of grey. Could he have been in some terrible trouble lately? Was there some mystery about him, hidden by Mrs. Keith, sufficient to account for his refusal to come to S. Jacques?

It was all bewilderment; and she began to wonder if she were dreaming. She put her hands over her eyes for three or four seconds. When she looked again, the figure was gone.



SUDDENLY HER HEART GAVE A THROB.

She went slowly back, in a dazed condition, questioning whether it had been a trick of the imagination. She wished now that she had gone nearer, to make sure. Yet, no! For if Giles were there, and chose to avoid her presence, it was not for Phyllis to go after him.

To the Forsyths she said nothing of what she had seen or imagined.

On arrival they found that Mrs. Keith had retired to her room. "Madame" had been a long time away, the Swiss girl said, when questioned.

She had twice been out in the morning, and had received two telegrams; and then she had said that she would get fresh air on the lake.

She had returned but lately—by the boat preceding that which had brought back Monsieur and Madame and Mademoiselle. Yes, surely, Madame had returned by that boat, for she would not all these hours have walked about Hilterfingen and Oberhofen, not once entering the ch  let.

Mrs. Forsyth and Phyllys made their way to the bedroom, to find Mrs. Keith hard at work, packing. Her cheeks were flushed; her manner showed excitement.

"Yes, I went out," she said. "I thought it might do me good. My nerves seem all to pieces, and I could not keep still. So I took the boat to Interlaken and back—for the sake of the air. You there—too!" with a start. "Then you gave up S. Beatenberg. What a pity! No, I did not see you. I was—no time ashore. Just for a cup of tea."

"I think you would have been better quiet," remarked Mrs. Forsyth.

"Perhaps. It may have been a mistake. But something in Swiss air does not suit me. I seem to be a wreck of myself—" and she laughed nervously. "So I have decided to go home. To start to-morrow. Phyllys will not object—and you must not think me ungrateful. I have made up my mind."

Had she seen Giles? Phyllys all but asked the question; and then something in that unhappy face, with its haggard flush, held her silent. As once before, the wonder arose—"was" Mrs. Keith perfectly sane? Could it be that her brain was ever so slightly "touched"? Phyllys decided not to risk exciting her further.

CHAPTER XXVI

AN UNQUIET MIND

NO persuasions would induce Mrs. Keith to put off her departure more than one night. The Forsyths had a fight to gain that concession.

"But I must and will have a clear day for the Schynige Platte," Mrs. Forsyth declared to her husband. "Phyllys has been promised that excursion from the first."

She gained her point; though, probably, if Mrs. Keith had guessed what her consent would involve, it would not have been granted. When she was further enlightened, too late to draw back, she hotly combated the plan, then insisted on being one of the party.

Phyllys was allowed no voice. She still kept silence about her supposed glimpse of Giles; and Mrs. Keith talked confidently of finding him at Castle Hill. Phyllys had begun to distrust her own eyesight. If he were at Interlaken, he would surely have appeared. If, on the contrary, he were at Castle Hill, she could not regret going there—unless her appearance would be unwelcome; but as she recalled the past, she could not believe that. Her "friend" would not be untrue, though he might never be more than "friend." She was gaining hope.

A lurid sunset made them anxious about next day. Heavy clouds clothed the mountain tops; and the Niesen had donned a dark cap and short mantle. But the sun shone brightly over Thun, and shed crimson upon the lower slopes and lake. Strangers could not decipher what this meant.

Phyllys, an early riser, did not fail next morning. She sprang out of bed and went to the open window, with chestnut hair falling loose over her frilled nightdress.

It was a sight worth waking for—the pale lake lying in shadow, the pyramidal Niesen mass rising darkly beyond. Further shone the snow-peaks of the Blumlisalp and tips of the Jungfrau range with a silver glow from the coming sun. The tint could hardly be otherwise described. It was not rose or gold, nor was it ordinary "cold" silver, but a pale rose-silver, if such a colour exists. She watched breathlessly, kneeling, lost in admiration;

unknowing whether the sight appealed more to her artistic or her spiritual self. It made her think of Colin and his ideals. It made her think of Giles. It lifted her heart to the Divine Source of all earthly and heavenly beauty. She whispered her prayers softly, looking with bodily and mental eyes on that indescribable light, while her spiritual eyes were uplifted to her Father in heaven.

Then the ascending monarch of day crushed out the delicate tinting, and flooded heights and vales with gold.

By half-past six Phyllys was down to breakfast, as was Mr. Forsyth, but the elder ladies were later. Had they not arranged to drive to the boat-station, they would have failed to catch the steamer.

A sharp air assailed them on the lake, and Mrs. Keith looked blue, by no means in condition for exertion. She held to her point, however, and refused to turn back.

Phyllys could have been in dancing spirits. The beauty of lake and mountain, the charms of the coming ascent, the prospect of Castle Hill, the hopes that her fears would prove groundless and that Giles would be in the future all he had been in the past—these buoyed her up; and the one wet blanket was Mrs. Keith's unhappiness. As they neared Interlaken, she did indeed force a cheerful manner; but when they landed her eyes were everywhere, nervously on the look-out. Phyllys could not but notice this, could not but conjecture explanations.

From Interlaken they went by train to a station at the base of the mountain, where they entered the tiny mountain-train.

Mrs. Keith would not be hurried, and they nearly lost their first chance. Though late in the season, enough tourists appeared to fill the train—but they managed to pack in; Mrs. Keith close to a window; Phyllys beside her; the Forsyths in front, whence they could lean back to talk. As the gradient became more steep, the engine puffed vigorously.

"Schynige Platte—not far from seven thousand feet high," announced Mr. Forsyth, dividing his attention between his Guide-book and Phyllys.

"Subtract from that the eighteen hundred feet altitude of the lake—leaves a respectable amount still to climb! Engine worked with a cog-wheel—very safe—all precautions taken. Ascent lasts about an hour and a half—or less. I beg your pardon—" at a gasp from Mrs. Keith.

"I thought it lasted twenty minutes!"—in dismay.

"Dear me, no. You are thinking of S. Beatenberg. This is a longer affair."

"It won't seem any time at all—there is so much to see," murmured Phyllis.

As they rose, the landscape widened by leaps and bounds. From one side, then from the other, they gazed over a growing expanse. The Lake of Thun lay far beneath. The Lake of Brienz had shrunk to a puddle of greenish water. There was an overmastering sense of loftiness, as they looked into sheer depths, across valleys, over precipitous walls of rock falling from the very verge of the line on which they travelled. Moat of the travellers took the journey composedly. It was the correct thing to do; everybody did it; and nobody expected to be the worse. To Phyllis the outlook was too wonderful to whisper of fear. But she became aware that the lady on her other side was growing nervous, and that Mrs. Keith trembled like a leaf.

Three or four tunnels had to be gone through, and the breaking out from each into a broader world was grand. Ascent by rail has an unromantic sound; yet no man, climbing slowly on foot or on mule-back, gains these marvellous upward leaps.

The nervous lady fidgeted anew. "Well, one comfort is," she remarked, "if anything 'did' go wrong, it wouldn't be a case of getting mangled only. It would be—the end!"

"My dear, don't talk nonsense. Nothing is going wrong," a man's voice made reply.

Mrs. Keith clutched the window, and Phyllys slipped a hand through her arm. "It's all right," the girl said cheerily. "Nothing to be afraid of. These trains go all through the summer."

She met the haggard eyes, with a look in them which she would not easily forget. A look of shrinking dread.

"But—if it 'did'—" she heard.

They stopped at a small station, and Mrs. Keith started up. Phyllys caught her hand.

"This isn't the top yet."

"Sit down, Mrs. Keith. A little longer. We are two-thirds up," added Mrs. Forsyth.

But she dragged her hand from Phyllys, and pushed her way out. "I must—I can't stand this any longer," she panted. "It—terrifies me! I can't stand it!"

Remonstrances were useless. She stood on the platform, her face a mottled pallor.

"I can't—I tell you, I can't—I won't!" she declared. "I haven't the nerve for it. No use asking me. I'll never again get into a funicular train after to-day. You are all to go on without me, and you can take me up as you come back. I shall be all right till then. No, I won't have any of you. I won't allow it."

So imperious was her manner, that resistance was impossible. Mr. Forsyth had sprung out, but she almost pushed him back, with insistence, in the face of his polite desire to stay. He had to yield, and she was left standing on the platform.

Since she refused their help, all they could do was to put aside the thought of her, and to enjoy the views. Another tunnel was gone through; and as they emerged, the Jungfrau burst upon them in dazzling radiance.

The last station was reached, and a walk of twenty minutes took them to the top. A party of loud-voiced Germans, who had kept up a rattle during the ascent, now did their best to mar the solemn grandeur of Nature. Phyllis and the Forsyths moved to a distance, where they might study the scene in quiet.

Far below, branching different ways, lay the Lauterbrunnen and the Grindelwald Valleys; and in front, from right to left, swept a range of snowy heights and towering peaks, including the three giants daily scanned from Châlet S. Jacques—the Jungfrau, the Mönch, the Eiger—a lordly trio. These and other mountains of the Bernese Oberland seemed to have placed themselves in a stately order, on view. It was a perfect day; some clouds floating, but all the greater heights sharp in definition. Through a binocular Phyllis could see the very crevasses in the Grindelwald glacier, the châteaux dotting the Grindelwald valley.

When the time came to return, they kept a look-out for Mrs. Keith at the station; but she was not visible. Mr. Forsyth left the train to inquire.

"She has set off to walk down," he said on return, with a lined forehead. "Very unwise! Of course she's not equal to it. Over four miles! I must go after her. She might have a fainting-fit."

No time to discuss the question, for the train was starting. Mrs. Forsyth could not resist a murmur of—"Really too bad!"

The small engine, which had puffed and snorted on its upward way, kept silence in descent. Down and down they slipped—winding to and fro from edge to edge; the mountains gaining in height as they slid into valleys between; the distant views contracting, the horizon narrowing.

Nothing below was seen or heard of Mrs. Keith or Mr. Forsyth; and Mrs. Forsyth decided on going at once to Interlaken, there to await their appearance. It was surely impossible that Mrs. Keith could yet have walked the whole way.

The wait was a long one. Mrs. Forsyth and Phyllis had tea, then hovered about the boat-station, till patience was exhausted. When the absent

pair drove up, Mrs. Keith, drooping and feeble, seemed not to realise the trouble she had given. Mr. Forsyth had overtaken her not far from the foot of the mountain, and she had been so ill as to make a halt needful. She was barely able now to drag one foot after the other. They helped her on board—Mr. Forsyth moving away for a talk with his wife.

"Not at all grateful for my going after her, I assure you," he murmured. "You'd have been astonished if you had seen the pace at which she was going—before she saw me. After that, all weakness and faintness. My dear, your friend is rather—eccentric, to say the least! However, not a word of this. She is bent on starting for home to-morrow."

Phyllys had taken a seat close to Mrs. Keith, and the latter said, "You are a kind girl!"

"I am sorry you are feeling so ill. Would it not be better to put off our journey home?"

"No, certainly not. Everything is arranged. I cannot wait a day longer. My nerves seem all to rags!"—and she tried to laugh.

The laugh turned into a shudder. "Was that thunder? I have a horror of a storm in a boat—all the iron about!"

Phyllys had hoped that she would not notice. A change had developed after the brilliant day; and lurid cloud-masses covered the summits, broken by yellow streaks.

"I don't like that. How long shall we be? An hour? More than an hour! Ask somebody if the storm will hold off so long. Find out—pray!"

Phyllys went obediently, though aware that "somebody" was not likely to have positive information. She came back to her seat, remarking, "I dare say it won't be much."

"What does Mr. Forsyth think?"

"He says it looks rather threatening."

They ploughed their way, zigzagging from side to side of the lake; and the cloud-capped heights grew more densely black. Another rumble sounded, winning a shiver from Mrs. Keith.

"If it gets worse, I shall land. I won't be stopped."

But for a while the storm held off; and when it broke, she seemed paralysed.

The Niesen, always a prominent object, showed now no pyramidal form. From summit to base it was one mass of black vapours. From within that darkness rolled heavy reverberating peals, each louder and longer than the last, issuing with solemn echoes from the shrouding canopy. Thus far no lightning had been seen. The battle of forces was carried on behind a curtain.

Then a dazzling double-forked arrow leaped forth, with a crashing roar, which drowned Mrs. Keith's scream. She clutched at Phyllis' wrist, holding it with a force which gave pain. Mr. Forsyth came to ask if she would go into the cabin, but she shook her head, moaning.

"No, no! The boat may go down. We may all go down."

Another resplendent flash, lighting up the scene with rose-colour; and another burst of heaven's artillery. Mrs. Keith hid her face, while Phyllis watched, fascinated. The black-clothed pyramid, the issuing sword-flashes, the rolling peals, had an impressive solemnity, which brought to mind the giving of the law from Mount Sinai in days of old.

At a pause in the lengthened reverberations, she heard, "If only one could—!"

Phyllis slipped an arm round her companion.

"If one could live the past over again!"

Should she say anything? But—what to say?

"Phyllys,—if death came, would God have mercy? If one had not meant—"

"Had not meant to do wrong?"

"Yes. That is—had not intended. Circumstances sometimes—"

"But circumstances never can 'make' one do wrong," the girl said staunchly.

"In the past. I mean, in the past. One can't help the past."

"One may confess and try to make amends."

"Too long ago."

"I don't think it can be too long." Phyllys thought of Zacchaeus coming to the Divine Giver of pardon, with "fourfold restitution" on his lips.

Another dazzling sword of light; another echoing crash; and the reverberations rolled from mountain to mountain.

Mrs. Keith stooped forward, shaken by a sob.

"But if one cannot—cannot—confess—will He have mercy?"

"He knows if you really cannot. If it is for the sake of others—not your own sake—that you don't speak." Afterwards she wondered what made her say this. "I think one should always tell—if not publicly, at least to some one. And then one might be helped."

No reply came. Mrs. Keith remained in the same position till they reached their station. By that time the storm was lessening, and she walked from the boat with little help, her face averted from Phyllys. The girl wondered—had she given offence?

On reaching the châlet, a fresh effort was made to induce Mrs. Keith to put off her journey, but she was obdurate. She meant to go; she would go. She was fit only for home.

Then, in her own room,—“Did I talk nonsense in the boat, Phyllys? Lightning affects my head so strangely. I never know what I am saying while a storm lasts.”

Phyllys looked at her with serious eyes. “I don't know,” she said. “It didn't sound at the time like nonsense.”

“I've no doubt it was, if it makes you so terrifically grave. Well, thank goodness, this is nearly the end. I shall never attempt another funicular railway, and I have had enough of Switzerland. Now you must go to bed. Most of your packing is done, I suppose. You said you would see to it yesterday evening. That is right. I long to be safe at my beloved Castle Hill.”

And the next day they started.

CHAPTER XXVII

RENEWED FIGHTING

“IN the lives of most men there has been a week, at the memory of which ever afterwards a dark cloud comes down, and makes a possibly sunny world momentarily a place of gloom.” So says that forceful writer, “Linesman.”

Such a week had Giles known earlier; a week, followed by months of pain, but in itself sufficient when recalled to bring a cloud, making his “possibly sunny world a place of gloom.” The sorest loss, the most passionate remorse, though they may promise to shadow life's future, do from the nature of things, in the course of time, sink into the background, and fail to quench all hope; forming indeed a burden, yet one to which the

shoulders have grown used. But in the background the burden still is, at seasons making itself felt.

That week, the recollection of which could never grow dim, the results of which could never cease to be, belonged to boyhood.

Since then, recently, he had lived through another stringent week—in which he had awakened to his love for Phyllys, and to the fact that she was beloved by Colin. Which last discovery involved two other discoveries; first, that it was his duty to yield her up; and secondly, that he had not power to do so. In the strife, his sense of duty succumbed before the vehemence of his love.

But to be beaten is not always to be conquered. Nay, to be twice-beaten, thrice-beaten, may still lead to victory. With human beings generally, a defeat weakens the moral fibre, lessens the power to resist. Yet there does exist a stamp of soldier, notably in the British Army, with whom defeat seems to stiffen the moral fibre, to strengthen the will, so as to render more resistless his next onset.

Something of his struggle might have been visible to watching angels, themselves unseen of men, as Giles went to and fro those autumn days. He said nothing to anybody. It was not his way to talk about himself, to appeal for sympathy. He fought his bitter fight alone.

Not Colin, with his keen vision, not Mrs. Keith, with all her eagerness, could penetrate the surface, could lift the covering and gaze below. Colin might have begun to suspect, but that now he was much away. Though one outburst of wrath had suggested a good deal, passion thereafter had been held down, and even Colin was deceived by Giles' calm. He spent time as usual over the management of his property, rode and cycled, saw friends, was the busy country gentleman,—too composed, too solid and occupied, for those around to imagine that within was a long-continued conflict.

He had been worsted. He had retreated before the foe. Then, at a critical moment, Phyllys had been snatched away. He had time to recollect himself, time to be confronted afresh by his resolution. He took it up again, clenched his teeth, and—in Phyllys' absence—resolved anew.

This was not impossible, when her presence no longer enchained him, when Colin seemed languid, and Giles could conjecture why.

The thought of giving up Phyllys to another, though that other was Colin, shook him to the core; and it was a relief when Colin started for Edinburgh. Giles could get on better alone, thinking always of Phyllys, yet struggling not to think of her, striving to make up his mind that Colin should have the first chance.

A fresh shock came, in the shape of a letter from the latter, gay in tone, announcing that he had been at Midfell for a week, and had all but finished the bust of Phyllys.

"Not bad either, though I shouldn't be the one to say so!" he added.

He did not write like a lover; but of course he would not. His presence in Midfell spoke plainly enough.

Wrath again had Giles in its grip. To determine that Colin should be allowed a chance was one thing; to see Colin taking that chance, without a "with or by your leave," was another. He could face no human being that morning. He went off on his favourite horse for hours of misery; galloping across fields; refusing to think; conscious that he was once more overcome; yet aware that fresh power would dawn when he had rallied from the blow. He returned to dinner, a sombre meal, for Mrs. Keith was away; and so much the better. Her questions would have made the one straw too much.

At night he went out again, and paced the lanes till early morning, getting home in time for an hour in bed, whereby he avoided comment.

By post arrived a letter from Mrs. Keith, telling of her visit to Midfell, of her plan to take Phyllys abroad.

"I have a delightful suggestion to make," she wrote. "You must join us on Lake Thun. The Forsyths send you an invitation. Write and say how soon you can be there."

He understood, for he knew her wish, a wish which too well chimed in with his own desires. By this time he craved for Phyllys with a consuming passion. And Mrs. Keith, for reasons of her own, was bent on the same end. She cleared the path for him, and he had but to walk in it.

But, Colin! His past resolve!

He fought the battle again. He wrote to say that he would go, and he burnt the letter. Next day was a repetition. Another letter of acceptance was written, and destroyed. Then he achieved a third, declining the invitation. He sent this off, and felt that life held no more of joy.

Mrs. Keith cannonaded him with remonstrances, and he held to his point. He was too busy; a lame excuse; and he knew what Phyllys would think. Too busy! He spent hours, his head on his hands, thinking only of her.

Days passed thus, and a telegram arrived from Mrs. Keith, dated at Dover, saying: "Not well, will get home this afternoon, train arriving 5.5."

"In England!" Then Phyllys had gone to Midfell. Some complication must have arisen. The plea "Not well" made small impression. He was too much accustomed to hearing it. Mrs. Keith was not strong; but also she never hesitated to be "not well" for a purpose. She would look ill, no doubt, since she was a born actress.

Had she and Phyllys quarrelled? Impossible. A thrill tingled through his powerful frame. Was it possible that Phyllys might come too! He negatived this idea; nevertheless, he told the housekeeper to have the best spare room ready, just in case—But of course she had gone north.

When the hour came he was on the platform; and as the train drew up—as he glanced along the carriages—that tingling recurred.

For Phyllys was there.

CHAPTER XXVIII

NEW DEVELOPMENTS

WAS this to mean fresh defeat? With victory in view, was he to be hurled back?

Phyllys to stay a fortnight at Castle Hill! He to be, day after day, within sight, hearing, touch, yet debarred from winning her! Debarred by his own resolve in the past; by his fresh resolve in the present! If Colin failed, then would come his chance. But Colin would not fail. And meanwhile, a fortnight of this agony! To make matters worse, he read in Phyllys' face joy at their meeting. Despite Colin's absence, she was glad to be here.

Not glad only, but sweet to a degree which even he had not known in her before. She had developed of late. He saw this, as the old Vicar had seen it, though from a different point of view. He was conscious of something new in her; something which had not been there. He was also dimly aware of power; recognising as once earlier that he might do what he would with her, Colin being out of reach.

Giles was a strong man, a man of iron will, yet it might be questioned whether his strength would be equal to this strain. There are forces before which iron bends and snaps like tin. In her beloved presence he was weak, and he knew it. But in that very knowledge lay safety. Because he felt his own strength inadequate, he laid hold upon Divine strength.

These weeks of lonely battling had told upon even his powerful frame. Phyllys noted something unusual; a weight, a haggard look, recalling the imaginary Interlaken glimpse. Singular that he should then have appeared to her vision as she now found him, altered and aged. Though not indeed grey-haired, he was plainly in trouble. She had debated with herself whether to tell him of that fancy, and the first evening she said nothing.

She was up betimes next morning, and indulged in a ramble before breakfast. Coming back, she met him in a side-path.

"This is too soon after your journey," he said. He had no choice but to turn and walk by her side.

"I'm as fresh as possible. I don't think you are well."

"Quite, thanks."

"I fancied something might be worrying you, like Mrs. Keith. She so often seems worried. It's her way, is it not? But not your way!"

"Perhaps not."

"Was it not strange?—one day at Interlaken I thought I saw you. I could have declared it to be you! And you seemed bothered then too. You've not been in Switzerland, have you?—not even for one day!"

She put the question laughingly.

And he said—"No."

"It was droll; for we had found a letter for Mrs. Keith, lying at a little Thun hotel, in your handwriting. Not really, of course, but I felt sure it was yours, and it had been posted at Interlaken. And then—that I should seem to see you yourself there too—it was queer, as if chance likenesses were in the air."

Giles hardly followed her words. He was thinking of herself more than of what she said. She ventured another question:—

"I suppose Mrs. Keith has not some great sorrow; something that would make her unhappy?"

He showed surprise.

"She gets so easily upset, and sometimes it is as if she expected things to go awfully wrong. But you would know. I don't want to interfere, only I

have been so sorry for her."

"She is excitable by nature. Nerves," explained Giles. "Nothing to be anxious about. She could hardly have any serious trouble, unknown to me. There is—" and he hesitated—"a tendency to exaggeration—to exaggerated views. One must allow for that. I am sure she is not aware of it herself."

He changed the subject abruptly.

"Colin was with you at Midfell?"

"Yes, he wanted to finish the bust. It is said to be a success. He ought to become a famous sculptor some day."

"No question as to his having the gift. The doubt is, whether he has health to use it."

"Midfell suited him. He was well all the time."

"Because he was happy." Giles' glance added, "Because with 'you!'"

Phyllys kept silence, and in suppressed tones the other continued—

"He may have a career before him. He ought to have. But much depends on whether he marries the right wife. Sympathy in his work would mean to him—everything."

Did Giles wish her to marry Colin? Phyllys held herself in, and spoke with indifference.

"Do you think Colin likely to marry? I don't. Sculpture will always be first with him; and a wife shouldn't come second."

"Ah, you know only one side of him yet."

"I've seen pretty much!" she murmured.

But Giles paid no attention. He had made up his mind that something had to be said, and he went on in the same monotonous undertone—

"If he should wish to marry, there would be no difficulty as to means. He and Mrs. Keith talk as if he were a poor man, dependent on Art. It is not so, really. What belongs to me belongs to him. What is mine is his. I had a feeling that I should like to say this to you."

She made no remark, and he went on patiently, trying to explain—

"It is not merely that we were brought up together—that we have been brothers. It is more. Years ago I made up my mind that, whatever he should wish, if it were in my power to give, he should have it—even though it might cost me—might cost me—"

The hesitation, the suppressed suffering, told more than he knew, let slip what he meant to hide.

She kept her face turned away, and said gently—

"Yes, I see. I think it is quite beautiful of you."

"Not beautiful at all. You mistake my meaning. It is a matter of simple duty."

"For you—perhaps," she murmured. "But Colin would be wrong to let you."

"If you knew everything, you would not say so. I owe him all—more than I can ever pay."

They were nearing the house, and only a few seconds remained. Phyllis' heart beat fast; for now she saw, now she knew, that Giles loved her. But with the knowledge came a woman-like instinct to hold back, a rush of shy reserve. She would not too quickly betray herself. She wanted him to know that he was mistaken—that Colin never could, never would, be anything to her. But how could she say it? He saw only a lowered hat-brim.

"It's breakfast-time," she murmured, as they reached the door.

The hat-brim was slightly lifted, and he caught one tiny flash of blue from between curling lashes.

It meant—what did it mean? Giles stood motionless, white as chalk. A rush of new hope almost unmanned him.

"Phyllys—" his voice broke as on the day he had rescued her from the bog, and when he tried to say more, he could not.

She forgot herself, and looked wonderingly up, full at him.

Then he too saw, he too knew—and the strong man visibly shook.

The wonder in her eyes gave place to a tender concern.

"You will not—misunderstand," he faltered. "I had thought—if it were for Colin's happiness—"

She unconsciously shook her head.

"'He' has never given me to understand—but if it were so—A fancy of mine, no doubt." Giles was trying to shield Colin, while yet making sure. "It might have been right to give him the first chance—to—leave home myself —"

"Please 'don't!'" she whispered, and ran indoors.

Giles did not follow. He had to meet joy as he had met pain—alone.

CHAPTER XXIX

THE LOST HEIRLOOM

IN the gallery stood Phyllys, gazing at a vacant space once occupied by an ancestral portrait. She knew the spot, though during a former visit her attention had not been drawn to it. Colin, under pressure of modelling, had

failed to take her round. Then had come her summons home, with the discovery that the picture had vanished.

She hardly wondered that the loss had not been more quickly found out. The oak-panelled wall was so dark, the pictures around so resembled it in tint, the corner itself was so much in shade,—that the disappearance might easily go unnoticed. As she thus cogitated, a step made her turn.

"Fine afternoon," remarked Mr. Dugdale. "Kathleen wants you for a drive. She will call at half-past three."

He was cool, neat, precise as always, but in his face was a glimmer of something not often visible. He liked Phyllis as he liked few; partly for her own sake, partly for her father's.

"Swiss trip cut short in a hurry," was his next remark. "How came that about?"

"Mrs. Keith did not care to stay longer."

"So I hear. Can't discover any reason."

"I don't know why it was. She seemed upset—and one day she had a fainting-fit."

"Real?"—with a glance.

"Yes, quite real."

"She's given to nervous attacks," as if in apology.

Phyllis looked towards the corner. "That picture has never been found!"

"No. Extraordinary!" and he knitted his brows.

"But if the thief took it—"

Mr. Dugdale raised his eyebrows.

"Humbug!"

"You don't think it was a thief?"

He glanced round to see that they were alone, and lowered his voice. "That's all humbug. No more a thief than I am. I'd wager a hundred pounds it is Mrs. Keith's own doing. Don't repeat what I say. There 'd be no end of a rumpus."

Phyllys was startled, despite her own suspicions. "But why? What could make her?"

"Mrs. Keith has done many things for which reasons are hard to find. Odd woman—always was! Never could conceive what made Giles' father give him into her charge. Must have been demented."

"'She' must?" inquiringly.

He gave a short laugh. "I meant Giles' father. But she—well, you are not far out there."

"She has been a good mother to Giles."

"Taken care of his health. As for the lads' moral training, it's a marvel to me how they have turned out so well. Precept enough! But as for example!"

"What was the picture like?" asked Phyllys. She had often wished for an opportunity to ask this.

"Young fellow, in the dress of two hundred years ago. Pleasant face—blue eyes—look of Colin. That is why she has hidden it—if she has, which I, for one, don't doubt. Can't say this to Colin or Giles. I'm telling you in confidence." There was in Mr. Dugdale a feminine element, apparent at this moment.

Phyllys assented. He seemed to be describing the hidden oil-painting—the likeness of Mrs. Keith's brother.

"Why should she mind its being like Colin?"

"No accounting for feminine vagaries. But in this case a clue does exist. She has always set herself against Colin's modelling—no reason!—it's like the schoolboys and Dr. Fell. Since things are so, she detests being told that Colin is like the young fellow in the portrait, simply because 'he' was a sculptor—and a successful one in his day, though not of lasting fame. Which accounts for the resemblance—not so much feature as expression."

"The spirit of sculpture in both," suggested Phyllis.

"That may be! However, years ago she made up her mind that Colin should not model; and, having made up her mind, she sticks to it like a leech. Therefore, anything that encourages him in his love of sculpture she hates like poison. Consequently, when she detected a growing likeness, she banished the portrait from the drawing-room. Then, finding attention drawn to the resemblance, she made away with it. Bless you—no!—even she wouldn't venture to destroy it. But I haven't a doubt—not a doubt!—she's got it somewhere under lock and key. And what is more, I'm certain Giles suspects the same—which is why he refuses to have the police."

"Doesn't he want it found?"

"He doesn't want his private affairs to be the talk of the county. Mind, he says nothing. All this is conjecture. I'm telling you because—" and a pause—"I think you ought to know; and you might have influence with Mrs. Keith." His look said, "You know something already."

Phyllis admired his astuteness, but felt herself powerless. "It seems such an extraordinary thing," she said. "A picture belonging to somebody else."

Mr. Dugdale tapped his forehead with a forefinger.

"Is she—really?"

"That is my theory again. Nothing else explains."

"Explains—?"

"The muddle she makes of life. The way in which she snubs her own son, and fawns on Giles. The fact that not a word she says can be relied on. There's a moral twist in her. She will contradict herself a dozen times a day, if it suits her purpose. All the same, she knows what she is about. She's the oddest mixture I ever came across of cleverness and—really one might almost call it semi-insanity. Only there is method in the madness."

"What sort of man is her brother?"

"Jock Reeves? Never saw him. Rather a scamp, I imagine, in his youth—banished to Australia—family pleased to get him out of the way. So Mrs. Keith says. 'Dear Jock' she calls him. Never seems to write to 'dear Jock,' or to hear from him; and not the smallest anxiety to get him home."

"Have you seen a likeness of him?" Phyllys was picturing still the hidden portrait, declared by Mrs. Keith to represent her brother in theatricals.

"Good while ago. Big-made, substantial fellow, rather jolly-looking—not Mrs. Keith's style."

Giles approached in time for the last words, and Phyllys said, "We are talking about Mrs. Keith's brother. Did you ever see him?"

"Just before he went out. I remember a big man, as Mr. Dugdale says, with a hearty laugh. Very jolly, and good to us little fellows."

"Not at all Colin's style!" thought Phyllys.

She pondered much that afternoon and evening on the enigmatical ways of Mrs. Keith.

That the hidden portrait was the lost heirloom it was impossible longer to doubt,—that it was "not," as professed by Mrs. Keith, the likeness of her only brother, but of a young sculptor, ancestor to Giles, who had lived two

centuries earlier, and whose gift, resembling that of Colin, had apparently developed in him something of the same type of features and expression. Mrs. Keith's extreme dislike to the resemblance arose, doubtless, from her aversion to sculpture as a pursuit for her son. An illogical aversion, yet very real. Unreasonableness seemed in her to be a leading characteristic; perhaps connected with that touch of brain-weakness which Phyllis had begun to suspect, and of which Mr. Dugdale spoke frankly.

"A kind of brain-oddity!" decided Phyllis. "But what shoals of lies she has told!"

Then a rebound. In past days Phyllis had been weary of the little Midfell home. She had found Barbara unendurable, had craved escape from Mrs. Wyverne's narrow judgments. Now, in fuller understanding of Mrs. Keith, her mind leaped back to the grandmother, with a sense of repose in that strong solid goodness, in the certainty that she need never fear there to find aught of exaggeration, double meaning, falsity. She recalled, with loving respect, Mrs. Wyverne's sturdy truth and religious devotion—a devotion lived out in daily life, marred by no such terrible inconsistencies. Mrs. Keith made a show of religion, but did not live up to it.

At this juncture, the girl could almost have exclaimed, "Let me go back to the old life, with its limitations, and its reality!"

But other elements existed. She could never again live the old life as in the past. In many ways she had expanded beyond it. She might meet its limitations more patiently, because able to value more truly what it held of real worth; yet those limitations, the spirit of narrowness, the contracted outlook, would try her more severely than of old.

And—there was Giles! She could not put Giles aside.

Needless that she should, she told herself, smiling. Giles had his faults, but he was true! There was in his character a rock-like stability, good to lean upon. She recalled the grasp of his hand, as he drew her from the bog, and she recognised that grip to be symbolical of the strong upholding which might, perhaps, be hers for life should she one day give herself to him.

Midfell village with all its simplicity, the kind old grandmother with all her honesty and goodness, could not satisfy her deeper needs. Giles only was able, she whispered to herself.

And she hardly yet realised, though in a manner she had begun to know, that the deepest needs of her nature not even Giles could satisfy.

When she went to bed she considered all this over again, arriving at the same conclusions with respect to Giles; and dismissing Mrs. Keith as hopelessly eccentric. It was useless to try to understand her. What a mercy Colin had not grown-up like his mother!

She was dropping asleep, letting entanglements glide away. Giles' face came up, and she smiled. Then she forgot herself, and came to, and floated off again, when, like a flash of lightning, an extraordinary conjecture seized her.

It was a conjecture so vivid, so startling, so far-reaching, that in a moment she was wide awake, sitting up in bed.

"Nonsense! Nonsense!" she said aloud.

But the possibility grew. It laid hold upon her imagination. Looking back, she saw scene after scene, heard utterance after utterance, more or less perplexing at the time—all now met, unravelled, explained, by this scathing suggestion—all lending support to it!

"No, no, 'no!'" she said. "I'll never let myself think such a thing again! It's out of the question."

The resolve was powerless. She could not stop thinking. Again and again that dread possibility leapt up, and "would" be faced, "would" assert itself. It cast a lurid light on past, present, future! It made perplexities clear. It set her head whirling.

It could not be. It was too madly impossible. She said these words over and over, but they had no force. She could not divest herself of a growing

belief that things were so. And yet, to imagine that she alone should see, that everybody else had been blind! Preposterous!

She tried to laugh. "It's a nightmare! I'll go to sleep and forget!"

But sleep had fled.

CHAPTER XXX

MRS. KEITH AND HER CORRESPONDENT

TWO or three evenings later Mrs. Keith stood at her open bedroom window. Giles, before her return, had invited to dinner the Vicar and Dr. Wallace. She always set herself against attentions being paid to the doctor; but once in a while Giles put his foot down. He had done so now, and she had to give in. Mr. Dugdale also was coming.

She was in one of her restless moods; frequent moods of late. She had dressed early and dismissed her maid, planning a time alone. When successful, she wished she had failed.

Solitude was abhorrent to her; yet she did not go down. Difficulties had to be faced. At any moment they might assume an acute form, and it was needful to consider how she should meet the danger. She lived on the edge of a volcano.

After years of immunity from fear, of running away from conscience, of shutting her eyes to realities, she found herself in a net of her own weaving. Less and less, as weeks went by, could she see her way out. Knot after knot was being tied, so it seemed to her, by a relentless hand. More truly, she had herself fastened those knots in the past; and the net had ever

since imprisoned her, though so loosely that she could ignore its existence. Now that unseen hand was tightening it.

She could not escape. No loophole presented itself. One mode she did know—the mode of the "Gordian knot." But from that she shrank with loathing.

"I would sooner die!" she said, setting her teeth; and she failed to see, as in Switzerland she had seen, what such a death must mean. She clenched her hand. "He must not come! He shall not come!"

A letter had arrived that afternoon, not in the ordinary way, but forwarded under cover from her London bankers, being marked "Immediate." It was written by one whom she ought to have welcomed to Castle Hill; whom, for no fault of his own, she was determined to keep away. The writer, in a tone of grave remonstrance, argued against this resolve, trying to make it clear that she wronged herself and him.

"He shall 'not' come!" she repeated aloud, with energy.

She turned from the window, through which blew a cold breeze. There were lights on the table; and she drew from her pocket two envelopes. With impatient fingers she took out a sheet, found it to be the one she did not want, and drew forth the other, which she read, not for the second or third time.

"He ought to be sure that I would not act so without reason. He ought to understand. My motives are no concern of his! I told him it had to be; and that should be enough. After all these years, what can it signify? At any cost, stay away he 'must!'"

Standing before the mirror, in her brocaded silk, she knew what his arrival on the scene would mean. She saw him come in; pictured the faces around; heard the inevitable exclamations; realised to the tips of her fingers what would be felt, thought, uttered; and with that vision sick terror seized her. She leant against the table, on the verge of fainting.

"I could not bear it! I would rather die. The very idea is maddening. 'Right.' But right or wrong I could not! There are things too impossible. And after all—that 'one' false step should bring me to this! One step, which seemed at the time nothing! To have one's life ruined! It would be cruel."

She put up both hands to her throat, where a lump seemed to rise. If she sometimes pretended to be ill, she also suffered much from overwrought nerves. Crimson flushed her face, fading into pallor, and noises sang in her ears.

"Am I going off again?" she muttered. She had presence of mind to take the letter, which had fallen from her shaking hand, and to thrust it into her pocket. The second letter she put mechanically into its envelope, then it dropped from her grasp, and she staggered to the armchair, lying back with shut eyes.

A slight tap made her reply, "Come in."

And Phyllys appeared in a new frock of pale blue, a present from Mrs. Keith. There was a touch of constraint in her manner, though she tried to be as usual. She would not accept, but could not forget, that strange midnight suggestion.

"I want you to see how nice my dress looks," she said. "But you are ill."

"A touch of faintness. Not much. Some eau-de-cologne, please."

Phyllys went to the dressing-table, beside which lay on the floor an envelope. She picked it up and laid it on the table, with the addressed side uppermost: "Colin Keith, Esquire." Evidently meant to go by the evening post. Then she poured the liquid on Mrs. Keith's palm, and dabbed it behind her ears.

"You must keep quiet," she said. "It is early still. Nobody will come for twenty minutes." But contradicting herself—"Why, there is a carriage already."

She went to the window.

"Not a carriage, but a railway fly."

Mrs. Keith sat upright, and faintness vanished. If this were the worst, she would brace herself to meet it.

"Colin has come!" exclaimed Phyllis.

"Nonsense! He is in Scotland."

"I saw him plainly, in the light from the door."

Mrs. Keith leant back, shaking like a leaf. The momentary terror, courageously met, had been awful; and reaction was severe. She had felt certain that the deferred possibility of years, nay, of decades of years, was a present reality.

Another tap at the door was accompanied by a slow—"Mother here?"

Phyllis' "Yes" was prompt, and he entered before Mrs. Keith could speak.

"You did not expect me," he said. "Just in time for dinner." He kissed Mrs. Keith on a cheek coldly presented, and Phyllis wondered if he felt the lack of welcome. He said a kind word about her apparent exhaustion, though, as Phyllis could not help noting, it aroused no anxiety. Then, when she would have moved, he murmured, "Pray don't go. I'm off."

As he passed the dressing-table, he saw the envelope addressed to himself, and took it. "Save the postman that trouble! From Giles," he remarked, and drew the sheet out, as it happened with the fourth page towards himself. "No!" in surprise. "I could have declared it to be his writing. Oddly like!" He turned to the first page, and a singular expression came.

"What are you doing there?" Mrs. Keith asked irritably.

"This is yours; not mine," and he came nearer. "You must have put it by mistake into the wrong envelope."

"What?" The word cracked out like a pistol-shot. She jumped up. "What are you talking about?"

He placed the letter in her hands. "I saw the address, and took it—but it is for yourself. I suppose you have another for me."

She snatched and thrust it into her pocket; then turned upon Colin a look not to be forgotten. It seemed to be the concentration of hate.

"How dare you meddle with letters of mine?" she demanded furiously.

"I beg your pardon. I thought it was mine."

"And of course you have read it."

She could not face those quiet eyes.

"You do not really think so. I saw the signature, and that it was to you."

"Nothing more?"

"Is not that a needless question?"

She turned away, and said passionately, "I might be left in peace this one half-hour!"

Without another word he went, followed by Phyllis, who, in the passage, could not resist a glance of sympathy.

He said in an undertone, "Please forget. She means nothing."

"I suppose she can't help it."

"There's a good deal of nervous excitement," he said evasively.

"Do you think it is—perhaps—her head?"

"Giles and I have long thought so. People are apt in such cases, as you know, to turn against those who are nearest. This is between ourselves."

Phyllys, as she moved away, wished that she could have believed the same.

CHAPTER XXXI

GILES AND HIS HOPES

THE dinner, kept up to the mark by Mr. Dugdale, went off as small dinners commonly do.

Mrs. Keith was well-dressed, but she could not have been complimented on her looks. Her face was pale with a spotted pallor, drawn, and lined. Colin noted her appearance as unusual. His eyes travelled often in her direction, and his gaze showed only concern; but the concern terrified her.

Giles observed no difference, for his mind was occupied elsewhere. Since the first morning he had been much with Phyllys, yet he could not flatter himself with having made great way. For Colin's sake, as well as his own, now that he had gathered the other's supposed quest to be hopeless, he would fain have brought matters to a point. Phyllys, however, was in an "elusive" mood; entirely charming, but by no means to be promptly won. She held him at bay and fascinated him, at one and the same time.

Colin's return was unexpected. He had meant to stay in the north longer. The avowed cause, something to do with modelling, did not satisfy Giles, who suspected Phyllys to be the true reason. He seemed to be in good

spirits, but looked ill, as always after travelling. Phyllys ascribed his looks to his mother's reception, which reception now held in her mind a new and sinister meaning. That midnight suspicion haunted her.

Small-talk had not been included in Giles' composition; and the Vicar did not love chit-chat; while the Doctor was uncomfortably conscious of his hostess' dislike. But Mr. Dugdale kept the ball going.

Not long after Mrs. Keith and Phyllys left the table, they were joined by Colin; and when he appeared, the elder lady walked off, leaving him alone with the girl—an unusual move on her part, but she could not longer face his scrutiny.

"Have you come straight from Scotland?" Phyllys asked. "You look awfully tired."

"Dining-room atmosphere. No—I slept at York."

He seemed indisposed to talk, and she left him mercifully alone; but soon there was a murmured—"What brought the Swiss plan to grief?"

"Mrs. Keith wanted to get home."

"Any reason?"

She decided that Mrs. Keith's son had a right to ask, and she related to him, as to Giles, about the letter found at Thun, her supposed glimpse of Giles at Interlaken, and Mrs. Keith's fainting-fit. He listened with interest.

"I see you connect fainting-fit and letter."

"Mrs. Keith said it was not that."

"She must have advice. If one could contrive it, a London specialist."

"A specialist for—?"

"Brain—" very low.

"You think that explains all?"

"I'm not up to thinking anything definitely this evening." Then came a change of topic, and Phyllys found him to be speaking of Giles. "One of the best fellows that ever lived," he said. "Honestly, I believe there's nothing in the world he wouldn't give me if he could!"

Phyllys' reply was impulsive. "Yes. He said so. 'At any cost!' I wondered what he meant. He said he owed you so much."

She was aware of a drawing back. "Unfortunately the debt lies the other way."

"Giles must know," she insisted. "He told me he never could repay what he owed to you. He did not explain—and of course it is not my business." But it might be her business one day, she thought, if things came about as seemed not impossible.

"He likes to put things strongly. Sounds effective. Don't make too much of it." Colin's tone was evasive. "Some boyish escapade in his mind."

"It didn't sound so."

"Giles was talking nonsense."

Was he? Phyllys knew him to be a man not addicted to careless speech. What he had said he meant.

Perhaps Colin did not wish to be questioned further, for he moved away.

Giles was still a prisoner in his own dining-room. The Vicar and Dr. Wallace had plunged into a discussion, and, like most men not possessed of the faculty of small-talk, when they did set forth upon the waters of a debate, they floated far. Their host had to sit it out as best he might.

When at length freed, he found Phyllys alone with Mrs. Keith, and not till the end of the evening did he come across Colin, lying on the library sofa.

"Here—by yourself!" he said involuntarily. "Your head?" He shut the door and came near, looking down on the pale chiselled face. "What brought you back so soon?"

"Erratic disposition. If the moulding won't do!"

"You meant to stay longer."

"Perhaps—yes. Why don't you try conclusions with—" and a pause—"Phyllys?"

He was smiling with his most detached air. Giles remained grave.

"How long have you known?"

"Lately. For a time I was not sure."

"You think—there is hope for me?" He stood upright, waiting in suspense for the reply. Few looking on would have guessed the greater force of will and character to belong to that slight recumbent figure.

Colin laughed. "As if you didn't know! Go ahead, and don't shilly-shally! That's my advice. Speak out at once."

"Thanks. I will."

Giles went to his little sanctum, and Colin turned his face from the light, bearing pain quietly. Not pain of body alone. Giles had won his way earlier to victory through defeat; but in Colin's case there was no defeat, and no man knew of his strife. He loved; and at one time he had hoped; but when he read what Phyllys was to Giles, he drew back. He would not stand—if he might—in the way of Giles' happiness.

CHAPTER XXXII

A POSSIBLE COMPLICATION

ONCE more at her open window, gazing, not at dim fell-outlines against a starry sky, but into the darkness of a Midland garden, with ancestral trees under a clouded heaven, knelt Phyllis.

Another thought had come, another suggestion, touching her more acutely than the first.

That earlier flash of light on Mrs. Keith's past, lurid in aspect, had been a weight upon her spirits, the supposition burdening her with a fear lest one day it might be her duty to speak out. Still, she was with Giles; she was sure of his love; she felt confidence in his rectitude; she knew that, whatever might happen, he was dependable. Nothing, she had told herself, could shake that security.

And she had not dreamt of this new doubt.

The other suspicion had struck at the root of much in her future; but it had not affected her relations with Giles, had not threatened her happiness. This, if true, would sweep away the foundations of all that made for earthly joy.

If Giles went, everything went.

Hitherto no thought of blame to him had occurred. He was the unconscious partner in another's evil deed; no less ignorant than the rest of the world. Provisionally she had condemned one person, hoping that her conjecture was mistaken; seeking for extenuating circumstances should the conjecture prove true.

But if Giles were implicated, if for years "he" had acquiesced, there could be for him no extenuating circumstances.

Recalling her chat with Colin, she glanced to an earlier conversation with Giles, and words recurred spoken of Colin:—

"He and Mrs. Keith talk as if Colin were a poor man, dependent on Art. It is not so, really. What belongs to me belongs to him. What is mine is his . . . You mistake my meaning. It is a matter of simple duty . . . Years ago I made up my mind that, whatever he might wish, he should have it—even though it might cost me—might cost me—You would not think so if you knew everything! I owe to Colin all—more than I can ever repay."

He had spoken this earnestly—from his heart. And Colin could say he had been talking nonsense.

Then the new conjecture came, dagger-like—

"Did Giles know?"

Colin did not. No such suspicion had occurred to him. But was Giles in ignorance?

"What belongs to me belongs to him! What is mine is his! . . . If you knew everything! . . . I owe to Colin more than I can ever repay!"

Some boyish escapade to win words like these from a man of Giles' stamp! The explanation would not hold water. Another lay only too ready. Colin could make the assertion in all honesty; but Phyllis knew that Giles had not talked nonsense, had not alluded to some boyish folly. He had meant every word. He had not intended her to understand; but she did understand. She saw the whole, with daylight clearness.

She laid her face on the window-sill, clutching it in her distress. "Giles, you too untrue!" she whispered, and scalding tears fell.

Then the thought of her own future; the all but certainty that he would ask her to be his wife. How could she? Marry a man whose life was a lie,

whose career had been one long fraud, who for years had connived at that which stabbed the very soul of honour, nay, of common honesty!

"If" things were so! But it might be a mistake. His words might bear some different interpretation. Even though her first surmise should prove correct, "he" might have had no hand in it, "he" might be innocent. She resolved that, without ample proof, she would hold him incapable of such conduct. She would wait for further light; but she would not allow him to propose until she knew.

She would have to go home. She could not stay here, in hourly intercourse, loving and knowing herself beloved, unable to meet his advances. It would be hard to go, but from every point of view it would be safer.

With her early cup of tea was brought a letter from Barbara, the opening sentences of which read like a response to her resolution. Mrs. Wyverne disapproved of Phyllis being at Castle Hill without leave.

"If you care to know what I think, I say you ought to come back at once," tartly wrote Barbara. "You ought to consider grandmother's feelings. She looks quite worried, and we shall have her ill, at this rate."

The sharp words glanced aside, scarcely heeded. Phyllis welcomed the letter as helping her out of difficulty. At any cost—and the cost would be severe—she felt that she must put off giving Giles a decisive answer. She must allow no chance for a private talk. In view of Barbara's former telegram, she could not feel anxious; but the words would serve as a plea. To her dismay there was a postscript—

"After all, you can't come at present. Ben Lane is ill with scarlet fever, and Grannie will not hear of having you. So we must wait."

This made a complication. Phyllys went down to breakfast, pale, "distracted," unlike herself.

Afterwards she wrote an impulsive note to Mr. Hazel, asking him to bring about her recall.

"Don't tell anybody, please," she begged, "only if you could have me telegraphed for, it would be best. They are so kind here; still, just now I ought to get away, and I can't tell you why. Please help me."

She ran with the note herself, to catch an early post, and wondered whether she had asked her kind old friend to do a thing impossible.

"Good morning," aroused her from a dream, and she found herself looking at Colin. "Giles was hunting for you. He is called off for the day on business—awful nuisance for him. Would you like to see the cast of your head? You've not been to my studio yet."

She laughed. "Considering that you came home last night—"

"I forgot. Come now, if you have nothing better to do."

Phyllys complied, relieved to hear that Giles was out of reach. Anything to gain time.

The bust was on a pedestal, near that of Elsy, side by side with that of Giles. Phyllys noted the latter fact. She stood gazing at the successful reproduction of her own pretty outlines.

"Grannie would love to see it some day."

"You like it?"

"Yes. Didn't I say so? But I'm no judge."

"Some day if you will sit to me again, I'll do another for Mrs. Wyverne."

"Like this?"

"Too much to ask! It might be better—or worse."

"You could not make a copy, I suppose?"

"I'm no good at copying."

"And if you took me a third and fourth time—they would all be different."

"Yes. If you sat to a class of students, and a dozen heads were modelled, no two would be the same. Taken from the same Phyllys, at the same time, under the same conditions—several might be good likenesses, yet all would differ."

"Curious," she murmured.

"Each modeller sees with different eyes—according to his own capacity for seeing, and his own mental make. What we see is always in part a reflection of what we are in ourselves. A dozen artists copying you would see each a different Phyllys—all to some extent the true Phyllys, but no two the same. The Phyllys that I see is not the Phyllys that Giles sees. The Giles whom I see is not the Giles whom you see."

He was interesting her with his old power; and his words sent her in recollection to a chat with the old Vicar of Midfell.

"It's like the light on different surfaces," she murmured; and a word from Colin drew a fuller statement.

"That is just it." He grasped the thought instantly. "Different surfaces give forth what they are able to receive—what, in common language, they can 'see.'"

"Then, what one 'sees' one seems to others."

"That practically is the outcome."

"And people blame one another for not seeing more."

"Whence sprang the persecutions of the Middle Ages. The soil was for ever trying to smother the water, and the water to drown the grass."

"We don't persecute now."

"No. Modern martyrdom with us is a sorry armchair business. But we belabour one another with hard words—for not being able all to see Divine Light in the same fashion."

"'You' don't say hard words of others, even when you don't think like them."

He smiled, and murmured—

"Shall one like me—
Judge hearts—like yours?"

The response in her face made him turn to a table and open a small book, pointing to the page. She read—

"Time was when I believed that wrong
In other to detect
Was part of genius all a gift,
To cherish, not reject;
Now better taught by Thee, O Lord,
This truth dawns on my mind,
The beet effects of Heavenly Light

Is—Earth's false eyes to blind."

She murmured, "Ah!" Colin's quotations always seemed to be just the right thing.

CHAPTER XXXIII

COMING TO THE POINT

GILES had resolved to follow Colin's advice, and difficulties strengthened that determination.

All one day he had to be absent. Next morning he found himself eluded. He was aware of a change in Phyllis. She seemed constrained: no longer flushing with joy to see him. His hopes sank low; but he would not wait.

After luncheon she retreated to Mrs. Keith's boudoir, and busied herself with fancy work. Presently she glanced up—to find Mrs. Keith gone, and Giles in her place.

It was impossible to rush away, and he wasted no time. Before she could be sure whither his speech tended, he had offered her himself and all that he had. She whispered. "Please don't!" but the petition was vain. He had begun, and would finish. There was no outpouring. He never used twenty words, where ten would do. Yet, while saying little, he conveyed abundant meaning—pleading in short vehement phrases.

"Give me hope, Phyllis!"—for her face was almost hidden. "One word!"

That averted face struck a chill.

"Have I spoken too soon? Phyllis, tell me! This cannot be a surprise."

Still she would not or could not speak. The silence was more than he knew how to endure.

"It is life or death," he said hoarsely. "Life without you 'is' death. I did not know, till I saw you, what it was to live. Give me hope—if not now, for the future."

She had drawn her hand away, and he took it again! "Phyllis, my darling! My darling!—If you knew what you are to me! One word."

But when she lifted her head, she was joyless and pale, the cheeks drenched with tears.

"I 'can't!'" she said with a sob.

"Cannot—love me!"

"I can't say anything."

"You want time. Dearest, I will wait as long as you like. Only give me hope."

"No." She mastered herself. "It can't be. Not now."

"But—when you have had time. When you know me better. I can wait; if I may hope."

"I don't know. O I don't know. Don't ask me, please."

He sat beside her, dazed and pained.

"Please—try to forget."

"Forget you! Never!"



THAT AVERTED FACE STRUCK A CHILL.

He kept her hand and she did not draw it away.

"My darling, what can this mean? Not that you do not care for me!
That you don't feel you might some day—"

"I can't tell. Perhaps—but not for years."

"But why wait? Every day is a year till you are mine. Why wait—if you think you might learn to love me! Would it take long?"

She burst into such heartbroken tears that he could not misunderstand, and joy leaped into his face. "My Phyllis! My own! You do love!"

She put him off with both hands. "No, no, no! I can say nothing! It is impossible. You must not think of me. I shall go home, and you must forget."

"Never! I am bound to you for life—till death—beyond death! There is a love which death cannot touch. My love for you is that sort. It will live while I live—in this world or in a dozen other worlds."

A faint wonder passed through her mind. If her surmise were true, if indeed his was a life of fraud, could he cheerfully speak of death? But he was a man; of course he could. He would carry out his deceit consistently.

Her heart rebelled anew. It could not be! He was "not" that sort! She would not, did not, believe it. Through all doubts and suspicions, how she loved! How she longed to give herself over to him! Even—with this risk, to take him. But she could not marry one whom she might not respect. There was nothing for it but to wait.

"You must not think of me," she said, and she stood up. "I can't say more. Some day, perhaps, if you should want it still, I might be able then; not now. And you are free."

"Free! But this is awful. Free till when?"

She could only sob. He took a sterner tone.

"You have not treated me fairly. You have given me reason to hope."

"I know," she whispered. "And if I had seen—"

"Then you thought you could. You did not see earlier—this that stands in the way. It is something new."

"Yes."

"Since when?"

She made no reply.

"I cannot conceive what obstacle exists, unless—Phyllys, do you 'not' care for me?"

He said the words masterfully, and she was again silent. To give a decisive "Yes" or a decisive "No" seemed to be equally out of the question. He gathered a grain of hope.

"One thing at least you will allow. I may speak again. How soon?"

"Oh, not for a long while, please!"

He caught her hand, and covered it with kisses.

She burst into fresh tears, and hurried away.

CHAPTER XXXIV

A FLARE-UP AND ITS SEQUELÆ

LITTLE more was seen of Giles that afternoon. But distressed though he was, he could not be called hopeless; for at least he knew with almost certainty that his love was returned. The obstacle, whatever it was, might be cleared away. He was unable to regard Phyllys' refusal as decisive.

Meeting her alone an hour later he said gravely—

"May we go on as before—no marked change. I will not worry you. But we are cousins still—friends, perhaps?"

She gave him a grieved glance, for it was hard to have to check him, and acquiesced.

Mrs. Keith was in one of her highly-strung conditions, unable to keep still. Phyllys wondered if something fresh had occurred. She was incessantly getting up to pace the room, to gaze out of the window. Even when the autumn day had drawn in, she still kept pulling aside the heavy curtain, looking into the dusk.

So strange was her manner that Phyllys was fain to question anew—"Could' she be right in her brain, or had long trouble upset the mind's balance?"

Colin had been all day invisible. Not fleeing from the pain of seeing Phyllys; that was not his mode. He would have met her this day as the day before, would have talked and made himself agreeable, without a sign of what it meant to himself.

But he had in trouble a resource denied to less fortunate mortals. For weeks he had gone without power to model. Now, suddenly, in the thick of victorious strife, a "new idea" had come with its flash of compelling force. In the silence of night it declared itself, taking him captive.

Phyllys or no Phyllys, the new idea would not be denied. Sadness fled before it. In the absorption of shaping his vision through plastic clay, all else was forgotten or was remembered as a dream. From early morning till five in the afternoon he scarcely left his modelling-stool. Food was brought, and he swallowed or put it aside; messages were disregarded; friends wishing to see him were sent away. Nothing on earth mattered but to put into form, while the power lasted, this coinage of his imagination.

Hours flew as he worked, and when he stopped it was not from mental inability, but from physical exhaustion.

Resisting the impulse to fling himself on the sofa, he went to the drawing-room, wondering what others had been after. Their existence looked tame compared with his own. Still, he did remember Phyllis, and even murmured to himself, with an odd smile, that though she could never be his, he would have "this" still.

"All alone," he said as he went in.

Phyllis answered composedly. "Yes; Mrs. Keith had something to do upstairs. How tired you are!"

"Where's Giles?"

"He had to go out."

One swift glance deciphered her.

She poured out tea and brought it to him. It had been an endless day with her, not flying on wings as with him. She was glad to have anything to do.

Colin thanked her, refused eatables, drank the tea, and leant back, passing a hand over his face.

"Are you wise to work so hard?" she asked.

"It's the essence of wisdom."

"Not—really!"

"If one doesn't capture notions when they come, they—go!" he said tersely.

"I suppose I mustn't ask what the notion is."

"Something in low relief—historic. Too early a stage yet for words."

"But you see it yourself?"

"Yes."

"It's in the clay. You only have to set it free for other people."

"That's my aim."

"It always seems to me—ought you to talk?"

"It seems to you—?"

"Art with you is such a reality."

"It 'is' a reality."

She would have liked to carry on the subject, but it was kinder to leave him quiet, and she went to the window in Mrs. Keith's fashion. An exclamation all but left her lips at the sight of Giles under a great cedar near. It was Giles; she made out the lines of his solid figure, and pity welled in her heart. She knew how miserable he was, and it was she who had to make him so. If she might but comfort him! Tears came, and she stayed where she was, seeing nothing through the mist. When it cleared, he was gone.

Colin divined that she was in trouble, but he asked no questions, and when she returned, he did not seem to notice her face.

"Giles is there," she remarked. "I suppose he is coming in."

Mrs. Keith's voice sounded faintly in a long scream, shrill and drawn out like that of some wild animal in a trap. Colin was on his feet and in the hall before a word could be spoken, Phyllis flying after him. From the floor above came cries of fire and a smell of burning. Thither rushed the two, followed by butler and footman. Through the shut door of Mrs. Keith's bedroom issued low moaning.

The door was locked—a strong door, not easy to burst open. Colin flung himself against it, without success. He beckoned to the men; but before they could act in concert, the key was turned from within, and a big man emerged. Wreaths of smoke poured out, and darting flames were

visible. He carried the helpless form of Mrs. Keith, having flung a wet towel round her face.

"Giles!" whispered Phyllys.

He must have gone to the front of the house, and have climbed in at the bedroom window over the porch. As this explanation flashed up, she recalled having seen there a light ladder.

"Take her—sharp!" He thrust the limp lady into her son's arms. "Not burnt—frightened. Water, quick—plenty of it!" in peremptory accents. "Keep this door shut, or you'll have the house in a blaze. Hurry, men; not a moment to lose!"

He banged the door to, and could be heard tearing down curtains within, while butler and footman rushed for cans of water, and Colin half dragged his mother to another room. Phyllys followed, disturbed by fears for Giles. Colin delayed a few seconds to assure himself that Mrs. Keith was not burnt, then asked, "Will you look after her? I must go. Send for Dr. Wallace if needful."

"Yes; don't wait. Giles may want you."

She found plenty to do, even with the efficient help of Mrs. Keith's maid. For some time the rescued lady was only half conscious, and when she revived, nervous terror overpowered her, causing renewed faintness.

Then Colin again made his appearance, used up and white.

"Do sit down," urged Phyllys. "Is the fire out?"

"Yes." He leant against the chimney-piece. "Much wrong?" with a glance towards the sofa.

"Only upset. Is anything burnt? Anybody hurt?"

"No one, luckily. Good many things burnt. We have been within an ace of something much worse."

"How did it happen?"

"There was an open box between bed and window, and a pile of clothes on the floor, which had caught first. They made a bonfire, and the breeze from the window must have carried the curtains within reach. Bedding pretty well destroyed—and all drapery in ashes. Two minutes more and the woodwork would have been in flames. I don't understand why she didn't give the alarm earlier."

"Is Giles there still?"

"Can't say. I've been filling cans at the cistern—sending the men to and fro. The room is swamped; more damage from water than even from fire, I suspect."

He made his way to the sofa, and asked—

"Better now?"

Mrs. Keith caught his hand.

"Colin, will you please attend to me? I can't get anybody to listen," she said fretfully. "Where is Giles? I want to see him. They tell me I must not go to my room, and I must go."

"Not yet. Keep quiet for a time."

He took a chair by her side, and inquired, "How did it happen?"

"I'm sure I don't know. How can I tell? It was all horrible confusion. I had put a candle on the floor, just for a moment—and the things must have caught. I was arranging—something—in the box. I didn't notice anything wrong, till there was a roar, and the whole pile had blazed up. I just rushed to the door, and it wouldn't open—and I forgot I had turned the key, and thought I was locked in and should be burnt to death. I must have lost my senses, and when I came to, I was on the floor, and the room seemed full of smoke and flames. I don't know whether I screamed. It was all horrible. I seemed to be going off again, and then somebody lifted me, and I heard

Giles speak. But I don't feel sure of anything except those flames everywhere." She shuddered.

"Was it that box in your cupboard, ma'am?" asked the maid, evidently curious.

She bit her lip. "Yes, I—it was something I wanted to find. You asked me if you could get a ruffle out."

"Yes, ma'am, and you said the key was lost."

"Yes, but last night I found it again—and I had a fancy—" She broke off. "Colin, I don't want people to meddle with that box. I won't have it. There are things of my own in it—things I don't choose to have pulled about. I must go and see."

She was starting up, but the light touch of his hand restrained her. "Not now. You must keep quiet, and the room is not in a state for you at present. I'll see to anything."

"The box is to be put back into the cupboard 'immediately'—just as it is—nothing in it moved or taken out. I won't have it meddled with."

"That is easily done." He would not suggest that the contents probably existed no longer.

Phyllis made her escape, and they went together to the once pretty bedroom, now a scene of desolation. The smell of fire was strong; curtains and cretonne coverings had vanished; blackened remains of burnt material lay about; and water had been flung in streams over walls, floor, and furniture. In the centre stood Mr. Dugdale, surveying the wreck.

"'You' look considerably the worse!" he remarked to Colin.

Colin paid no heed. He was shoving an open and fire-blackened box into the cupboard. But it was empty.

"Everything burnt, I suppose," he said to Phyllis. "No need to say so yet—only excite her."

"What has become of the fellow who rescued your mother?" demanded Mr. Dugdale.

"What fellow? Giles carried her out of the room."

"Giles was not here till later. Says so himself. I'm told it was a stranger—on his way to call. By the time anybody had leisure to notice him, he was like a sweep, and he went off to make himself presentable—told John he would come later. One or two seem to have mistaken him for Giles."

"Oddly enough I did—but it was a mere glimpse."

"His voice was like," murmured Phyllys.

Colin left the room, and Mr. Dugdale, moving to examine the carved bedstead, a valuable piece of furniture, badly charred, uttered an exclamation.

"My goodness!" Then—"Didn't I say so?"

He stooped to lift a framed picture, which seemed to have been put aside, leaning against the wall. He held it up, gazing hard, and Phyllys waited.

"It's—IT!" He turned towards her a black-framed antique portrait in oils. She saw a fine delicate face, with familiar blue eyes.

"Well!" uttered Mr. Dugdale, as if words failed him.

Phyllys put a grave question. "Is that the lost picture?"

"Yes."

It was also the concealed painting, declared by Mrs. Keith to represent her only brother, Jock Reeves.

CHAPTER XXXV

THE OTHER MAN

NOTHING could keep Mrs. Keith quiet. She was unable to rest. Twenty minutes after Colin had left, she dismissed her maid, declaring herself well, and went to the scene of the conflagration, only to find the door locked. Extreme anxiety to know whether the hidden picture had escaped observation oppressed her; but she dared not make direct inquiries. She knew that the dresses on the floor had been consumed; but she also knew that, when the things caught fire, a thick woollen shawl still covered the picture, and her hope was that it might have been left undisturbed. She bitterly regretted now the fancy that had seized her to take one more look at the portrait.

If indeed it had been found, her role would be to profess ignorance of its presence in the box. Somebody else, not she, should bear the blame. She would not risk asking for the key of the door, but made her way to the library, where others were gathered, discussing the event of the day. Colin remonstrated with her for being about, putting her gently into an armchair, and Giles tried to turn the subject, seconded by Phyllis. Mr. Dugdale surveyed her with critical glances.

"Wonderful woman!" he said to himself. "Brass enough for anything!"

Yet she, like they, found it difficult to speak on any other topic but the fire. The dread which weighed upon her nailed her to it.

"I'm sure it is a marvel I was not burnt to death," she said. "Giles was so quick—if he had not been there, I must have been killed—perhaps the whole house burnt down."

"Unfortunately I can't take credit," remarked Giles. "I should like to discover who my 'doppel' can be."

Mrs. Keith was talking still, but she stopped. "'Not' you! How odd! I certainly thought—but I was too terrified to see, and the smoke was stifling."

"Sensible fellow, whoever he was, to throw a soaking towel round your face! First step everybody should take at a fire," observed Mr. Dugdale. "I'm told he had a pretty determined voice."

"Giles' voice," murmured Phyllis.

"If he was my build, probably a coal-heaver!"

"O no—a gentleman!"

"I wish he had stayed to be thanked."

"John tried to make him, but he was in such a state, he said he would look in later. Not hurt—only blackened," added Mr. Dugdale. "We owe him something for his energy. Three minutes' delay might have made all the difference."

Enter the stout butler, composed as always, but with curved eyebrows of intense amaze.

"The gentleman is here, sir, that got in at the window. He asks to see Mrs. Keith."

"Bring him in. We wish to thank him," spoke Giles.

Fear seized Mrs. Keith. The thought might have occurred earlier, but for the bewildering effects of her fright. She rose, and put out protesting hands; but all eyes were turned to the door, and she sank back, knowing that it was too late. With more than usual emphasis the butler gave forth—

"Mr. Jock Reeves!"

Solid of figure and heavy of step, in walked an elderly, but most exact reproduction of Giles. It was Giles in form, Giles in bearing, Giles when he

spoke in voice—but Giles as he would become years later, more stout, with streaks of grey. Phyllys knew him instantly as the "Giles" of Interlaken.

He stopped, looked round, and smiled, as if in expectation of a welcome.

Nobody spoke. The circle seemed stricken dumb. Giles, Colin, Mr. Dugdale, Phyllys, were as if petrified. The three men knew not what to think. Phyllys read confirmation of her midnight suggestion. Mrs. Keith hardly breathed. This was the moment that had hung before her as an awful possibility through years.

Feature for feature he was Giles Randolph. And—his name was Jock Reeves. Brother to Mrs. Keith; uncle to Colin; no relative, not the most distant, of Giles.

He did not seem embarrassed by his reception, perhaps ascribing it to insular shyness. He cheerfully accosted Giles:—

"How d' you do, Colin? I've taken you all by surprise," with a jolly laugh. "You and I might be son and father! Glad to find my nephew so perfect a chip of the old block. Well, Cecil, my dear, I made up my mind to take the bull by the horns. Lucky I did and was at hand! You'll have guessed from my letter what I meant—eh?"

He addressed himself anew to Giles.

"I've put up for a good while with your mother's fantasies, Colin; but really, you know, it was getting beyond a joke! After a quarter of a century at the antipodes to be kept at arm's length from one's kith and kin—no reason but a fad! Couldn't stand it any longer, and that's a fact! So I thought I would see for myself what it all meant. I was in the garden, debating whom to ask for, when I saw a glare and heard Cecil shriek—and the quickest way was over the porch. I'm pretty active still—luckily. The fire was blazing—not three seconds to spare. Then of course I stayed to help, and when we had put it out, I was as black as a crow, and went to the inn, where I'd left my bag. Now I've come back—to see my sister and you young fellows. Not done wrongly, I hope?"

Giles murmured a negative, though the last words had been spoken to Colin.

"You, of course, are Randolph?" He placed a broad hand on Colin's shoulder. "About three feet high when I saw you last. No mistaking you for anything but a Randolph! Not the athletic type. You're the exact image of your uncle Jem—died early, you know. Well, Cecil, I hope you forgive me for not carrying out your eccentric instructions!"

So far he had talked carelessly, in Giles' voice, though with a "jollier" intonation. But the silence made itself felt. He paused.

After these years of unquestioning acceptance, in one moment light had flashed upon all three men, vividly, as with Phyllis before, casting a lurid glare upon past, present, future. No doubt the way for such illumination had been prepared. Many a perplexity, put down to Mrs. Keith's "oddity," now rose with convincing power. Mr. Dugdale's eyes expanded, and for once words failed him. Colin's face grew a shade more ivory-like. Giles flushed darkly crimson, whether with guilt Phyllis could not determine; and by comparison she cared for nothing beside. If "he" were true, if "he" had been in ignorance—all else signified little. The silence was brief, measured by seconds, yet it seemed long. To Mrs. Keith it meant an age of anguish!

For the worst had come. The blow which for twenty-seven years she had used every effort to avert, was fallen. At another time she might have carried matters with a high hand, might have tried to prove the likeness accidental. But the fire and the shock of her brother's appearance had shaken her nerve, and she could neither speak nor move. In previous imaginings of this scene, the one thing that she had not thought of was—silence. Astonishment, reproaches, exclamations, she had expected. The silence was more awful. Would it never end?

Colin broke it. In soft slow tones, dragging more than usual, he informed the newcomer—

"You are making a mistake; pardon me. I am Colin Keith. That is Giles Randolph."

The other spoke his incredulity by a laugh.

"It is true," chimed in a deeper voice. "'I' have always been Giles. 'He' has always been Colin." The form of expression betrayed his thought.

"No, my dear fellow! You don't bamboozle your uncle in that style! Not quite!"

Mr. Dugdale indulged in a whistle; an act so exceptional that it showed his state of mind. A cry from Mrs. Keith was smothered in her handkerchief.

More deliberately still Colin repeated, "'I' am Colin Keith, your nephew. This is Giles Randolph."

Reeves turned upon his heel with a gesture of disdain.

"I don't fathom your object in trying to take me in. But, I promise, you won't succeed. Look here!" He placed himself beside Giles, opposite the long mirror—both tall, substantial in make, upright, with red-brown complexion, straight features, and blue eyes dragged downward at the outer corners. Giles' sombreness was his own; otherwise the two were moulded after one model.

"Coincidence! Humbug! Look at us, and tell me so again! I believe," and he glanced round once more—"I believe you mean it. You are not humbugging me! But how you can have been taken in passes comprehension. Look there!" He pointed to the mirror. "Does it need telling? This is my nephew! You—" grasping Giles' arm—"you' are Colin Keith. That other is Randolph! It is written in your faces—branded there! Mistake! No mistake is possible. Is 'that' what you have been up to, Cecil?"

She shivered under the accusing voice.

"Eh? Is that it?" he repeated.

Mr. Dugdale made a move. He went to a corner of the room, brought thence an oil-painting, and held it beside Colin. Hardly more remarkable

was the resemblance between Giles and Mr. Reeves, than the resemblance between Colin and this Randolph ancestor.

"See?" demanded Mr. Dugdale. "Now we know why it has been hidden!"

"Now I know why I've been treated like a pariah!" muttered Reeves.

Giles strode across to Mrs. Keith, and she cowered before him.

Phyllis' heart bounded with joy; and then came self-reproach that she could be so happy when another was so miserable.

"Will you please to tell me the truth, Mrs. Keith? Am I—or is Colin—your son? Is my name Randolph or Keith?"

She shrank lower, till her bowed head rested on her knees; and in that shame-stricken form they read the answer. But he repeated—

"My name, if you please! Randolph—or Keith!"

And as if the word were dragged from her, against her will, she moaned, "Keith!"

Then she straightened herself, and made a feeble effort.

"I—I—couldn't help it," she stammered, and she laughed hysterically. "They—they—got mixed and I—I—when I found it out—"

"Mixed!" uttered Reeves scornfully.

One low murmur, "Mother!" had been heard from Colin.

But the crushing shame, the overwhelming distress, of Giles' look, drew all eyes, silenced all lips. He stood like a statue, with folded arms and bent head.

"I meant—I meant to tell," gasped Mrs. Keith. "I-I never meant it to go on!"

"And it has gone on! You have let it go on, all their lives! Colin for Giles! Giles for Colin! Though you are my sister, I say it is 'scandalous!'"

Reeves stopped.

Phyllys' hand was on his arm, and a soft voice whispered, "Please don't! Is she—quite like other people?"

"You don't understand—you can't!" Mrs. Keith spasmodically wailed. "It was—a mistake—a mistake—a mis—"

The strain became too great. She burst into a storm of hysterics and had to be carried from the room.

"I believe that girl is in the right," muttered Reeves. "Most charitable view to take, anyway—poor thing!"

CHAPTER XXXVI

THE COIL IN ITS BEGINNING

SOME twenty-eight years before the date of this tale James Randolph, the then owner of Castle Hill, with his wife, spent a winter in the south of France, being ordered there for health. At the same place, staying also, was his brother-in-law, Geoffry Keith. Keith's first wife, the sister of James, had died years earlier; and his second wife, "née" Cecil Reeves, was an attractive young woman.

Mrs. Randolph and Mrs. Keith became warm friends. Then, unexpectedly, Geoffry Keith died, leaving his widow totally unprovided for. Her child, Colin, was born before arrangements for her future could be discussed, and the Randolphs saw that she had everything she needed.

Six weeks after the birth of Colin Keith, Giles Randolph was born; and less than a month later Mrs. Randolph died. Her husband, distracted by the blow, decided to travel in the east. He implored the handsome young widow to take pity on his forlorn little child, and she responded with open arms.

"I shall be gone at least three years," he said, after explaining that, so long as she had charge of the boy, she should have annually the sum of eight hundred pounds. "By-and-by we must arrange something for your future, but I have no heart now for business. If you need more, write to Mr. Penrhyn. My boy must have the best of everything."

Mrs. Keith remained where she was till spring, then took the babes to Switzerland. She loved the Continent, and Randolph had left her free to follow her own devices. Mr. Penrhyn ran out to inspect the child, and wrote a good report to the father. "A pretty intelligent little chap, slight and pale, but healthy," he said.

Randolph never had this letter. An attack of fever carried him off, and Giles was an orphan.

Mr. Penrhyn already held the reins of government at Castle Hill. He was Giles' guardian, but no question existed about leaving the little boy where his father had placed him.

A second winter was passed in the south of France, the baby-boys flourishing. When spring arrived, they were about sixteen months old, bonny blue-eyed children—Giles slim and active, Colin sturdy and robust.

On account of gaieties which she did not like to miss, Mrs. Keith remained imprudently long in the south, and then she was met by the great temptation of her life; the fiery testing of will and principle which comes sooner or later to most, though with some it is spread, diluted, through many years, with others is concentrated into one tremendous pull. It came, as such trials often do, just so shaped as to make a fall easy.

Cecil Keith had not trained herself to be habitually true in word and deed, neither was she a woman of high integrity. James Randolph had not discovered this.

Giles, always sensitive to heat, failed in health, and was ordered to a cooler climate. Mrs. Keith started, travelling by easy stages for the sake of the little invalid; and when a day or two later the nurse fell ill, she was left behind. Mrs. Keith, feverishly anxious, would wait for nothing, but hurried on—perhaps too fast, for Giles grew worse. When two more stages had been accomplished, he sank so rapidly that she summoned a local German doctor, who told her all hope was at an end—Giles was dying.

He promised to call again in an hour or two; and she sat beside the bed, watching the small changed face, realising what this meant to herself. Giles dying, and the responsibility hers! For her own pleasure she had stayed in the south, when she ought to have gone north; and though it might be called only an error in judgment, she would be blamed.

Worse still—if Giles died, her income ceased. While he lived, she was comfortably off, and if he should grow to manhood, she might expect not to be left in the lurch. But his death meant the stoppage of her income. The estate would pass to a distant relative, and Mr. Penrhyn would be powerless.

She shrank with bitter dread from the thought of grinding poverty, and then came the temptation. At first a mere suggestion, almost formless, but it grew into shape. Why not transpose the boys' names? Why not put Colin for Giles, and Giles for Colin? If the little one recovered, the names could be reversed. If die he must, why should not her boy, as Giles, enjoy the wealth which otherwise must pass to strangers? It would mean ease for herself and him. And it need not be for always. Some day she would put things right—would slip out of it. She did not pause to consider how this might be possible.

The change looked simple. No one here knew her or the boys. Their nurse she could get rid of, sending a month's wages by post and dismissing her. Except Mr. Penrhyn and Mr. Dugdale, nobody from home had seen the children, and they not for months. Little ones alter so much in the first year or two that the exchange would never be detected. And if Giles got well, it would not last. It was a precautionary step only, in view of what might happen.

To the German doctor she had not mentioned that Giles was not her child; indeed, she recalled speaking of him as "my little boy." As to names, no difficulty existed. She had grown into the way of calling them "Mop" and "Top," seldom by their true names, and she could soon teach Colin to know himself as "Giles." It was all too fatally facile.

She did not look ahead, did not realise what the burden on her own conscience would be, but simply faced the present emergency, simply saw "wealth" and "poverty" thrown into the balance.

For an hour she wavered, and on the doctor's return she had not consciously made up her mind. But she had been playing with evil possibilities, and when he asked in German whether the two were twins, she found herself claiming the sick boy as her own, talking of the other as "her charge."

Terror then seized her. She had committed herself to a course of deceit, and no man could foretell whither it might lead.

Yet, when the doctor called a third time, she made no sign, took no step to undo what she had done.

All night the child seemed to be dying, but with morning there were tokens of a rally, and as hours passed this strengthened. The doctor would not believe himself mistaken, and still foretold a collapse, but he proved to be wrong. A young English doctor, Wallace by name, passing through the place, was called in to give a second opinion, and his was hopeful. He insisted upon a trained nurse, and telegraphed for one known to him. Mrs. Keith would have given much to avoid both doctor and nurse; but two or three English residents, hearing of a countrywoman in trouble, had called, and they arranged the whole, giving her no choice.

Of course doctor, nurse, and new acquaintances all believed Giles to be Colin, Colin to be Giles. The lie once told had to be repeated, and would have to be repeated, times without number.

At length the boy was pronounced out of danger, and Mrs. Keith found herself in a terrible position. It might be weeks before the little fellow could

be moved. Moreover, soon after first arrival, she had written to Mr. Penrhyn, mentioning the severe illness of—not Giles but "Colin." She had woven a web around her own feet, and one way only of escape lay open, the way of confession.

To a proud nature, like hers, confession of such a deed seemed to lie beyond possibility.

She decided to wait, to see later what could be done. If the child grew well and strong, he must have his rights. In a few weeks she would get away from everybody, and would reverse her own work. Meanwhile, all she could do was to let things drift—a fatal policy!

The boy's recovery was tedious, and he clung to his new nurse, turning fractiously from Mrs. Keith. Mr. Wallace stayed longer than he had intended in the neighbourhood, and both he and the German doctor insisted on the child remaining where he was. Then Mr. Penrhyn appeared, and saw the children under their new names. He was not an astute man, and though he remarked how differently they had developed from what he would have expected, no suspicion entered his mind.

After this, reversion to the old order became a hundredfold more difficult, especially when Mr. Penrhyn, with new determination, insisted on the boy being brought to England and having a home near Castle Hill. Since he was guardian, Mrs. Keith dared not resist. It was evident that he no longer trusted her wisdom, after the mistake she had made in remaining so long in the south.

And still she said to herself that it was only for a while—that in time all must be put straight. Some way would open. Some opportunity would turn up. Speak now she "could" not! Shame herself in the eyes of her little world she "would" not! She did not see how perplexities would thicken, how her little world would widen, how explanation would become more impossible.

Thus soothing her conscience with the thought of "by-and-by," she became in a manner used to the state of affairs, though by fits and starts she underwent much misery. At seasons the deceit—the wrong to one child, the

false position of the other—seemed awful beyond words. Then again for weeks she would acquiesce with a dull content, trying to persuade herself that things were just as well so, since Colin—the real Giles—was far from robust, and Giles—the real Colin—was vigorous in body and mind.

The little one's severe illness had altered him. In their infancy, though of different make, people had often said that the two might be taken for brothers. Nobody now spoke of them as alike, and this added to the extreme difficulty of reversion. No one who had seen them since that illness could be a second time deceived.

To make matters worse, the young doctor, Mr. Wallace, who had been called in to see the boy, took the practice at Castlemere, and thenceforward was always at hand. Perhaps it was hardly surprising, though he was not responsible, that Mrs. Keith detested him.

Thus coil within coil she was bound, and she drifted on till all idea of restitution was put off to a dim distance. Things were thus; and thus, she told herself, they had to remain.

In early days she had not been worried by fear of family likenesses. That came later, when she saw "Colin" fast expanding into a reproduction of the Randolph ancestor, inheriting the gift which she loathed, because she knew it to be a Randolph characteristic; when, too, she saw, year by year, her own son, known as Giles Randolph, growing into an exact copy of her brother, Jock Reeves, like in figure, in feature, in manner, in voice, even in handwriting. So marked was the latter resemblance that for years she had insisted on letters from her brother being addressed to her bankers', and forwarded to her under cover. Jock Reeves seldom wrote more than once a year, being a bad correspondent; and he had given in to the "whim," not troubling himself to oppose it.

But when he came home, and discovered that for no imaginable reason he was forbidden to present himself to her son or to Giles Randolph, matters became serious. She and her son were his only living relatives, and he had looked forward to being much with them. He was well off. He had planned spending the remainder of his years with her.

He had not written to announce his return to the old country. On first arrival in London, he learnt from her bankers that she was abroad, and that any letter coming from him was to be forwarded to a Thun address, there to wait till called for—a precaution doubtless taken because he usually wrote at about this date, for her birthday. Forthwith he travelled thither, took up his abode at Interlaken, sent a few lines to the address specified, and awaited a reply. That he had not long to wait was due to Mr. Forsyth's accidental discovery of his letter. It conveyed to Mrs. Keith her first intimation that the brother, whose advent she dreaded, was close at hand; a very "real" fainting-fit being the result.

A telegram from her next morning appointed an immediate meeting at Interlaken; and the outcome of this interview was that he found himself a tabooed individual, hysterically ordered never to show his face at Castle Hill, or to make the acquaintance of his nephew and his nephew's friend.

He demanded reasons in vain. For a time, he submitted, then came to the same conclusion as others—that she was "queer in the top-story;" and he decided to go to Castle Hill. If he should find the nephew and Randolph to be of her mind, he could but "sheer off."

With his appearance was levelled to the ground in one crash a structure of deceit, built up through twenty-seven years.

They had not been, could not be, happy years. They were shadowed by a perpetual dread. Hundreds of times she had bitterly regretted her own mad folly. But no way out of the tangled web had presented itself, save the one which she refused to face.

She did, indeed, keep in her mind a thought of final confession. Just at the last, when she had lived the life she preferred, when everybody would pity her, when she would not have to face earthly consequences—"then" she would speak out. It did not occur to her that she might not then be able to speak out, except in moments of fright, such as during the storm on the lake; and the impression made was wont to pass quickly.

More often she tried to think that it did not really matter; that Giles was quite as happy under the name of Colin; that his delicacy of health

made him unfit for the position so ably filled by her son; that practically he had all he needed, since if he named a want it was supplied; that, after bringing up her own boy to ease and wealth, she would wrong him by speaking out. The latter was inconsistent with her proposed dying confession; but Mrs. Keith was not consistent. This way or that way she always reached the same conclusion, that the fiction must be continued.

One aim she had long had—to bring about a union between "Giles" and Phyllis. "Colin's" health was fragile. He might not be long-lived; and Phyllis stood next in succession. Should "Colin" die unmarried, the estate would by right pass to her; and if she were "Giles'" wife, she would then possess her own. It would matter little that she seemed in the eyes of the world to do so through her husband.

The incessant strain had told upon Mrs. Keith's health; and as time went by, hysterical tendencies amounted to something beyond hysteria. There was, no doubt, as more than one believed, a touch of "brain" in her excitement, in her powers of tortuous self-deception.

All these years, when recoiling with horror from the thought of exposure, the deepest dread in her mind had been lest Giles—her own boy, her Colin—should despise his mother. Anything rather than that! "His" contempt she could not endure.

But the look that broke her down, the look in those sombre blue eyes, with their drooping corners, which she loved, was not disdain. It was the overpowering shame, the bitter sorrow, that touched her heart; for she, his mother, had brought all this upon him, and she knew how her tale must look in the sight of the one being for whose sake she could almost have died. Not quite; a woman of her calibre dies—quite—for nobody. Self always ranks first. Still, she did love him passionately; and when she thought of her little child's clinging arms, and realised that she might have kept his loving trust in ever-growing measure to life's end, she could have cried with one of old, "My punishment is greater than I can bear."

CHAPTER XXXVII

READJUSTMENTS

MRS. KEITH hardly even attempted to regain self-control, but sobbed herself into a stupor, followed by sleep. Not till the morning did she again see her son; and no human being learnt the details of that interview. She came out of it subdued, humbled, softened; for the first time with a dawning of real contrition. Giles' deep distress, his patient acceptance of his new position, his forbearance towards her, made a profound impression upon one whose thought had always been for self. Now, viewing half a lifetime of deceit with her son's eyes, she was shamed to the heart.

A more difficult interview had to follow. She had promised to send for the other Colin—the true Giles—not denying that she had to ask his pardon. But this was infinitely harder. She did not love Colin as she loved Giles—for the avoidance of confusion it is better to use still the wrong names. From his childhood her knowledge of the great wrong done to him had caused a hardness and bitterness of feeling, against which she honestly fought, but which had too often mastered her.

To humble herself before her own son was one thing; to humble herself before Colin was another. Subdued and softened though she was, when he came in, another spirit rose up.

He murmured a slight greeting, took a seat, and waited.

"Giles wished," she began, and the words stuck in her throat. "I—I—know what you must feel, of course," she muttered hurriedly. "But I meant it for the best."

He made a gesture of acquiescence, gravely polite. Thus far he had said little, but had gone about with his look of "apartness" intensified, as if he were studying events from some outside region, with greater interest in their psychological aspect than in their bearing on himself. The change of

relations was not less bewildering to him than to Giles, though met with outward calm. He did not pretend indifference; he had no thought of shirking his new responsibilities; and acutely as he felt for the real Colin, he had thus far rather implied than expressed sympathy. The fever of modelling possessed him still, and his one longing was to get away from everybody, though no one would have guessed the craving from his manner.

Silence lasted, and those clear compelling eyes almost forced Mrs. Keith to lift hers. She knew his power, and resisted it.

"I've tried—tried to be—fair to you," she faltered.

"I am sure you have, Mrs. Keith—as fair as possible, under the circumstances."

The use of her surname sounded strangely.

"Of course I know how you must feel," she went on, swallowing something down—was it distress at the thought that "he" would be her "son" no longer? Pain in that direction was unexpected; yet, after twenty-seven years, hardly to be wondered at.

"I shall leave Castle Hill at once, as soon as I can arrange where to go. Giles says the same. It doesn't matter—where?" She found herself in danger of a breakdown.

"I think it matters very much."

"No. Giles agrees. He was—very good to me!" and her eyes filled. "He says neither he nor I will be a burden on you—and we have been talking of plans. I shall not trouble you many days. Of course I know—exactly—all you feel!"

"You are sure!" he said gently.

She had to face his eyes. Resistance collapsed. She was obliged to look, and the pain and pity which she found there took her by surprise. She flushed, paled, trembled.

"Do you think it is nothing to lose a mother?" he asked. "You have been a good mother to me, as well as to Giles."

She burst into a passion of tears, touched to the quick. The words which Giles had urged her to speak were now poured forth. "I am sorry—indeed I am. It has been misery! Always knowing—always dreading to be found out! Any moment I would thankfully have told—only I never could—never had courage."

"It would have been happier for yourself."

"Will you ever forgive me?" she entreated brokenly.

He took her hand, not kissing her as he had been in the habit of doing, but with chivalrous compassion. Giles' distress had stirred her intensely, but this went farther.

"So wronged—so wronged!" was all she could sob.

"You have wronged Giles more than me. All these years you have deprived him of his mother."

She clung to his hand sobbing, and even bent her face to kiss it. "How you can be so good to me! I don't deserve it! I thought—I thought—you would hate and despise—"

"You will never think so again."

"If only I had known—if I could have guessed—I would have spoken out long ago." Her lips were again on his hand, when he tried to draw it away. "Colin, you 'have' been a dear son to me—all the while—and I—and I—"

"Don't you think we have said enough?" he asked.

"Yes—perhaps—no use saying more. Only—I do believe now that some day God will forgive me, too—now you and Giles have been so good. Do you think—perhaps He will?"

Colin bent and kissed her brow, as if he had been her son still. "Is Christ less merciful than man?" he murmured.

An hour later Giles was on his way to the library, to write necessary letters. He was oppressed by a dazed sense that in no corner of the house had he a right to stay. He was homeless, a waif astray on the waters of life. The shock to him had been tremendous, the upheaval of feeling immense. As yet he had been hardly able to think of aught else—even of Phyllis—though in the background of his mind existed a heavy consciousness that he could no longer hope to win her. All his life he had used another's wealth. He had now to make his way, to support his mother, with no profession, no adequate means of subsistence.

A few significant words had been spoken by Colin: "You have often said that what was yours was mine. This only means the same, reversed—that what is mine is yours."

But Giles could not allow such generosity on the part of one whom he had—unwittingly—long and deeply injured.

It was no light matter for one of his proud nature—he had inherited his mother's pride together with the Reeves' temper—to step in one moment from the position of benefactor to benefactee; to pass from the landed country gentleman to the impecunious adopted brother. It tried him beyond words. There was indeed one phase of the question which might have brought gratification; the fact that he would give up everything to Colin. But this was more than balanced by all that Colin had lost through him in years gone by.

He stood in the hall, thinking, on his way to the library. Mrs. Keith had to leave. That was beyond debate. Not that Colin would not forgive, but that she had forfeited all right to stay. And the sooner the better!

He too must depart, must bid farewell to the broad acres which he had held to be his own, must wander forth, "not knowing whither he went." That

at least was clear. He had harmed Colin enough. "Time he should be quit of me and mine!" he muttered.

Opening the library-door, he was met by a silencing gesture. Colin lay asleep on the sofa, and Phyllis had been bathing his forehead. She retreated with Giles to the small ante-room.

"His head was so bad," she whispered. "I found him here, after he had been with Mrs. Keith, hardly able to speak. But he won't hear if we talk softly." She had something to say, and she went straight to the point. "I'm so sorry, Giles. If you could know how sorry! So ashamed of myself!"

He supposed her "sorrow" to mean sympathy for him in his changed position. The "ashamed" brought perplexity, though he only said, with a melancholy smile—

"You have to learn that my name is not Giles—that I am Colin Keith."

"So difficult to believe!"

"More than difficult. I find it all but impossible to believe that any one—" he stopped. "And she—my mother!"

"What a life hers must have been! And how extraordinary that it was never found out!"

"Too wildly improbable!"

"I have suspected—lately."

"You!" A deep flush overspread his face. Was this why she had refused him—because she foresaw that he might be a poor man? The conjecture no sooner arose than he crushed it down. He could not think unworthy things of Phyllis. That she could think unworthy things of him would, to his mind, have seemed equally impossible.

"I had the fancy. It explained so much that one couldn't understand. But that isn't all. That wasn't what I wanted to tell you," she went on,

penitent and abashed. "Something much worse. Giles, I—I was afraid—that perhaps 'you' knew!"

"Knew what?"

"What she had done," very low. "That you were—not really Giles Randolph."

"You believed 'I' knew! 'I'—a party to the fraud! Good heavens!" and he looked at her in consternation. "You don't mean it!"

"It was horrid—horrid of me! But I—couldn't understand. Please forgive!"

"You could think me capable!"

She broke into a sob, tears dropping.

"What can have put such a notion into your head? Good heavens!" he repeated, dazed and scandalised. "You knew me so little!" He seemed more grieved than angry.

"I didn't—oh! I didn't really," she sobbed. "It was only what you had said yourself. I never could have dreamt such a thing, but for that—never! But I couldn't forget—'couldn't' understand."

"What did I say?" He spoke gravely, even with sternness.

She faltered some of the utterances which had so weighed upon her mind. "I ought to have known better. I ought to have been sure of you," she said sorrowfully.

"Then—this was why—!" he murmured.

"Yes," she whispered. "Will you forgive me—for ever thinking it 'could' be?"

The response she expected did not come. No touch of his hand, no renewal of his offer. He said dejectedly—

"There is no question of forgiveness. I laid myself open to misconstruction." After a moment's hesitation, he gave the clue which Phyllys had lacked. "What I meant was that Colin's ill-health lay at my door. That it was my doing. That I could never, through life, repay him for all he has lost through me."

"But—how?"

Giles alluded to the tale she had earlier heard of the cliff accident, in which Elsie Wallace was killed; and he seemed relieved not to have to relate the whole. "It was my doing. I was mad with temper and jealousy, thinking she cared more for him than for me. Some jest of his finished me off—not Colin's fault! I did not see how close they were to the edge, on slippery grass—and one push did it. I flung off as I gave the push, and there was a cry, and when I turned back they were gone—both! Never quite clear whether he overbalanced, and she went too, trying to save him; or whether she started back, and he went, trying to save her. But it was my doing. I killed 'her'—and ruined his health for life."

Phyllys' eyes were full again. "How dreadful!" she murmured. "How awful! It was enough to kill you too. Yet you never meant—"

"What of that? I 'did' it! And not a word of reproach from him. Only one wish—that nobody should be told."

"Was—nobody?"

"Her father, of course. He was—good!" with difficulty.

Giles looked in wonder on Phyllys' little hand laid on his knee. He had not expected to see it there.

"You are sorry for me? But—" he could not refrain from laying his hand on hers, and the touch of those soft fingers thrilled him. "Phyllys, I have no home now to offer. I am a penniless man. Even if you could accept me, you would have to wait years!"

"And if I don't mind waiting?"—with her sweetest smile.

"I should be wrong to let you. It is all too indefinite. I am leaving Castle Hill. He has endured too much through my mother. It must end."

"I beg your pardon," a voice said, and Colin came from the inner room. "Sorry to interrupt you, but I found myself hearing something not meant for me."

He dropped wearily into an armchair, and Phyllis held out a slip of paper. "Mr. Hazel has telegraphed for me to go home," she said. Her letter had followed the old Vicar to London and back to Midfell, whence the delay.

Colin read and returned it. "No hurry," he remarked. "About Giles' plans—no, don't go, Phyllis."

"You heard what I was saying. I will not be a burden on you. You have to take your position: so have I." Giles spoke in resolute tones. "Our paths will lie in different directions." A pause. "My mother and I will leave Castle Hill." Another pause. "I shall look-out for an Agency of some sort."

He had to raise his eyes, had to meet a quiet gaze, before which his determination threatened to become like wax in sunshine. "What do 'you' wish?" he asked.

Colin was pressing a hand over his rumpled hair. "Not that!" he said. "I must have your help."

"Of course, if you need me—"

"There must be a break. We will go different ways for a couple of months—then come together our true selves. Go to Midfell with Phyllis, and make the most of your time there."

"Say 'Yes,'" she whispered.

But he hesitated.

"I can't do without you, Giles—that is simple fact. You are good at business, and I am not. I must and will have leisure for modelling. As for

accounts—twenty minutes of them make my head frantic. You shall be my coadjutor—referee—adviser—anything you like. One moment—" as the other was breaking into speech. "You called yourself penniless. I am writing to my lawyers to settle upon you and your heirs the sum of one thousand pounds a year. The letter would be off, if I could have written another page. All I ask is—stay and help me. I will make the position as little trying as maybe."

Giles' strong features worked.

"No," he said. "It is like you; but that won't do. I will stay as long as you need me—as your agent. You shall pay me a fair sum for the work I do; not a penny more. The letter must go into the fire. My mind is made up."

"So is mine!" murmured Colin. He smiled, perhaps recognising that he, in Giles' place, would have followed a like course.

"Well—for the present. Come in—" and Reeves appeared.

"Not interrupting, I hope," he said in Giles' voice.

"No—" and Colin went on with what he was saying. "For the present I give in. It will make no difference in the end. All that I have is yours—and, as you have more than once remarked, 'pride between you and me is a thing impossible.'" The tired eyes laughed. "Your mother will continue to receive her allowance."

"Certainly not. She will depend upon me."

"I beg your pardon," interposed Reeves. "My sister will keep house for 'me.' That was my object in coming home, and she agrees. You may put her out of your calculations."

"Not a bad plan!" mused Colin. "Then the 'allowance' shall accumulate at compound interest for her son and his heirs." He looked at Giles. "And when you can persuade Phyllys to come and be the perpetual sunshine of Castle Hill—"

She flushed up.

"But there was a barrier," confusedly muttered Giles.

"There is no barrier," asserted Colin.

"None!" echoed Phyllys.

They were wrong. A barrier did exist, though not in the mind of Phyllys. It resided in Mrs. Wyverne's fears for the future weal of her beloved grand-daughter. She found it hard to credit that a modern man, who lived a life outside her limitations, who did not employ those forms of religious phraseology in which she delighted, who would not find pleasure in Miss Robins' addresses or profit from Mr. Timkins' exhortations, could be a safe husband for "the child."

But the old Vicar, with his deeper insight and wider grasp, pleaded strenuously; and Phyllys' face spoke for her; and Giles spent two months at Midfell, laying siege to the old lady's heart. Although he was not "one of the family," and although the tale of his mother's duplicity had given her a shock, she did in time learn to differentiate between the characters of mother and son, and did arrive at the knowledge that a man might be a good man, in the best sense of the word, without seeing on every point eye to eye with herself.

Little though she knew it, this shake to her "personal infallibility" theory was one of the most wholesome lessons she had ever received. Her outlook was broadened, to the great gain of herself and those around. But Barbara failed to appreciate the gain; and Miss Robins counted permission given to Phyllys' engagement "a sad falling away."

When a certain happy day arrived, the bridegroom's "best man" might have said to the bridegroom, "You, after all, are the gainer! If broad acres are mine, Phyllys is yours!"

But that would have cast a shadow on the bridegroom's happiness. The words were not spoken; and they never would be spoken. Giles Randolph, owner of Castle Hill, was not a man to consult his own feelings before another's peace of mind. To Phyllys he was always the kindest of brothers; to Colin far more than a brother.

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